

Running From Excuses

Stop reacting, start rebuilding

Preface

If you're holding this book, there's a good chance you're looking for something. Maybe you're looking for answers. Maybe you're looking for motivation. Maybe you're looking for a way out of a situation that feels impossible. Or maybe you're just tired. Tired of starting over. Tired of making promises to yourself that never seem to last. Tired of feeling like you're capable of more but never quite becoming the person you know you could be.

If that's you, I understand, because I've been there.

Before we go any further, I want to tell you what this book is not. This is not a book written by a millionaire. It's not written by a celebrity, and it's not written by a guru. It's not written by someone who has life figured out. In fact, if someone tells you they have life figured out, they're probably lying, selling something, or have become complacent. Life doesn't work that way. We're all adapting. We're all learning. We're all becoming.

I'm no different. I'm an above-average medical sales representative, a husband, and a father. A man who has made mistakes, who has failed, and who has carried pain. A man who spent year after year making excuses — and a man who finally got tired of lying to himself.

This book didn't begin as the book you're about to read. Originally, I set out to write about life skills — the practical things I felt weren't being taught. Credit card debt. Insurance. Sales. Real estate. Financial responsibility. The kinds of lessons I wish more young people understood before learning them the hard way. Those topics still matter, and they always will. But something unexpected happened while I was writing. Every lesson led to a story, and every story led to another lesson. And every lesson eventually forced me to look in the mirror. The deeper I wrote, the deeper I went. What started as a book about life skills became a book about awareness. What started as a book about knowledge became a book about truth. Because the more I reflected on my own life, the more it sank in that most of my problems weren't caused by a lack of information. They were caused by a lack of honesty. I knew what I should do; I just wasn't doing it. I knew what needed to change; I wasn't changing it. And for years, I had an excuse for everything.

The truth is that excuses are comfortable. Excuses protect us. They help us avoid responsibility. They allow us to blame circumstances, people, timing, bad luck, our past, and everything else except the person staring back at us in the mirror. I know, because I did it longer than I'd like to admit.

This book is the story of what happened when I finally stopped. It's the story of childhood trauma, and of a mask that followed me into adulthood. It's the story of alcohol, anxiety, depression, failure, and self-deception. It's the story of losing a business. It's the story of sitting in a dark room, holding my daughter, believing the people I loved would somehow be better off without me. It's the story of finally understanding that the greatest obstacle in my life wasn't the people around me.

It was the person I had become.

Most importantly, it's the story of rebuilding. Not perfectly. Not quickly. Not dramatically. One decision at a time. One habit at a time. One truth at a time.

Along the way, I learned something that changed my life. Actually, I learned a lot of things, but they all seemed to lead back to one question — a question that still sits on a Post-It note on my bathroom mirror, a question I ask myself every day, a question that changed everything.

Who do I have to become?

Not: What do I want? Not: How do I get there? Not: Why is this happening to me? But: Who do I have to become? That question forced me to stop looking outward and start looking inward. It forced me to stop blaming, to stop hiding, and to stop waiting. Most importantly, it forced me to tell myself the truth.

The truth is that this book isn't really about me. It's about you. It's about the stories you're carrying, the excuses you're believing, the habits you're repeating, and the future you're building — whether you realize it or not. You may be carrying things nobody knows about. You may feel behind. You may feel stuck. You may feel exhausted. You may feel like you've wasted years, or like you've gone too far in the wrong direction.

I want you to hear something before you turn the page. Your story is not over. You are not finished. You are not disqualified. And you are capable of far more than you currently believe. I know that, because I once believed the exact opposite.

This book won't solve your problems. No book can do that. What it can do is help you ask better questions. It can help you become more aware, and it can help you tell yourself the truth. And if you're willing to do that, everything can change. Not overnight, but permanently.

So before you continue, I want to ask you the same question that changed my life — the same question that sits on my mirror, the same question that echoes throughout every chapter you're about to read.

Who do you have to become?

Answer that honestly, and this book might change your life. Avoid it, and this will simply be another book. The choice, as always, is yours.

Dedication

To Avery and Isla,

You are the reason I kept going.

There was a time in my life when I believed the lies — a time when I thought the world would somehow be better without me in it. I was wrong. Now I can see that God placed both of you in my life exactly when I needed you most. You gave me purpose when I felt lost. You gave me hope when I couldn't see it for myself. You gave me a reason to become the man I was meant to be.

You have watched me run. You have watched me fail. You have watched me get back up. You have watched me keep promises. You have watched me become. And the truth is that I have been watching you too.

Everything I hope to teach you can be summarized in one sentence:

Never stop becoming.

You are capable of far more than you realize. Do hard things. Tell yourself the truth. Love people deeply. Protect your integrity. And never let excuses decide the direction of your life.

If this book leaves behind any legacy at all, I hope it is this: that you know how deeply you are loved, and that you always remember that your dad kept fighting because of you.

Love, Dad

CHAPTER 1

Playing From Behind

Everyone has a story. Some begin with celebration. Some begin with opportunity. Some begin with heartbreak. Mine began with a question that stayed with me through most of my life.

Why me?

As I've grown older, I've stopped asking that question quite as often. It isn't that I suddenly have all the answers; it's that I've come to understand that asking "Why me?" rarely changes anything. A much better question is, "What am I going to do with the story I've been given?" But before I could ever ask that question, there was another one that came first: why did my story have to begin this way?

I have no memory of my mother. Not because I've forgotten her, but because I never had the chance to remember her in the first place.

She died when I was just seventeen days old.

Every now and then someone will tell a story about their mom. They'll laugh about something she used to say, describe the way she comforted them after a difficult day, or remember birthday cakes, bedtime stories, family vacations, and all the little moments that become treasured memories later in life. I love listening to those stories. They don't make me jealous anymore. Instead, they remind me that every one of us begins life differently.

For a long stretch of my life, I wondered about the smallest things. What did her voice sound like? Did I have her smile? Would she have been the loudest person cheering from the stands at my football games? Would she have loved to travel? Would she have laughed at my terrible jokes? Those questions will never be answered.

As a little boy, though, I didn't spend much time thinking about them. Children don't compare their lives to everyone else's. They accept the world they've been given, exactly as it comes to them. That's one of the things I've learned about childhood: children don't know what "normal" is. Whatever happens inside their home becomes normal. Whatever love looks like, whatever

conflict looks like, whatever encouragement—or criticism—sounds like, that becomes their definition of life.

In hindsight, I wasn't angry that other kids had mothers and I didn't. I just noticed there was an empty space everyone else seemed to take for granted. At football games I watched mothers cheering from the stands. At school programs I saw them straightening collars before pictures and hugging their children afterward. At church I watched whole families sitting together. None of those scenes devastated me. They were quiet reminders that my story had started differently than everyone else's.

What I didn't understand at the time was that God had already begun placing extraordinary people in my life. People who couldn't replace my mother, but people who would become anchors when I needed them most. My father. My grandparents. My aunts and uncles. Teachers. Coaches. Families from church. Families through 4-H and the stock shows. Now I can see that they were quietly shaping a little boy without ever knowing how much they were helping.

No one influenced those early years more than my grandmother. If I close my eyes today, I can still picture her walking through her rose garden. She never hurried. Every morning she quietly inspected each bush, trimming what needed trimming, pulling weeds before they spread, watering what needed attention, and caring for details most people would have walked right past. As a little boy, I thought she just loved roses. As an adult, I understand she was teaching me something without ever saying a word. Everything worthwhile requires care. Everything worthwhile requires attention. Everything worthwhile grows slowly.

The garden wasn't merely something she maintained. It reflected who she was. Patient. Gentle. Intentional. She carried those same qualities into every part of her life. Meals were homemade. Vegetables came from a garden she had spent months tending. She canned food. She baked. She welcomed people into her home. Nothing about her life felt rushed, and nothing felt halfway. She had a remarkable ability to make people feel important for no other reason than that they were with her.

When I was with my grandparents, life felt different. At the time I couldn't explain why. Today I can.

I felt safe.

Children understand safety long before they can define it. They know where they can breathe. They know where they can laugh. They know where they don't have to wonder which version of an adult they're going to meet. My grandparents' house became that place for me.

Those weekends weren't extravagant. They were ordinary. Church on Sunday morning. A home-cooked meal. Watching the Dallas Cowboys. Working outside. Talking around the table longer than anyone planned. Nothing about those afternoons seemed extraordinary then. Today they're priceless.

Every year my grandmother also took me to Virginia and Washington, D.C. At the time I thought we were just taking vacations. Now I can see she was giving me something much greater than a vacation: she was expanding my world. We walked through the Smithsonian museums. We toured the White House. We visited the Capitol. I remember standing where Patrick Henry delivered one of his famous speeches, although I was far too young to appreciate its significance. She never turned those trips into lectures. She exposed me to history, service, character, curiosity, and a world much larger than the little West Texas town where I was growing up, and she let all of it speak for itself.

She understood something I wouldn't grasp until decades later: experiences are among life's greatest investments. The money they cost has nothing to do with it. Their value lies in the way they shape who we become. From where I stand today, I don't think she was preparing me to remember history. I think she was preparing me for life. I just didn't know it yet.

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One of my favorite memories from childhood wasn't Christmas morning or a birthday party. It was Sunday afternoon.

Every weekend after church, our family gathered at my grandparents' house. My grandmother would somehow cook enough food to feed what felt like an entire town, and no matter how many people showed up, there was always room for one more at the table. We lingered over meals, laughed at old stories we'd all heard before, and no one seemed to be in a hurry to leave. After lunch, everyone settled into the living room to watch the Dallas Cowboys.

To most people, that's just another football game. To me, it became something much more. As the fourth quarter wound down, I would feel a knot slowly forming in my stomach. I wasn't thinking about school the next morning. I wasn't thinking about homework. I was thinking about going home.

For a long time I thought I was remembering football. Only later did I understand that I wasn't remembering football at all. I was remembering what came after it.

Trauma has an incredible way of attaching itself to everyday moments. A song. A smell. A season. A garage door. Most people experience those things without giving them a second thought, but someone carrying invisible wounds experiences them very differently. Even today,

certain sounds can transport me back decades before my mind even understands why. That understanding didn't come until much later, though. As a little boy, all I knew was that I wished Sunday afternoons could last forever.

Something else has become clear to me since then. For most of my life I thought I loved hunting. The truth is, I loved being with my dad. There's a difference. The early mornings, the cold West Texas air, sitting quietly in a deer blind for hours—those aren't the memories that stayed with me. Being beside my father did.

The same thing happened with skiing. My dad put me on skis when I was three years old, and I still remember standing between his skis as he slowly guided me down the mountain. He never made a speech about courage or confidence. He just stayed close enough that I felt safe. Today, taking my daughters skiing every year has very little to do with skiing. It's about creating the same memories my father quietly created for me.

Baseball was no different. He coached my Little League teams, and at the time I thought I loved baseball. Today I know I loved having my dad there. He worked long days, yet somehow still found time to coach practices, throw batting practice, and encourage a group of kids who probably had no idea how much of a sacrifice that required. Children rarely remember every score. They remember who showed up.

My father showed up.

Those afternoons became some of the greatest gifts he ever gave me. But there was another reason I wanted to be anywhere my dad was, and I only came to see it clearly later. Everything felt peaceful until she came home.

That sentence is difficult to write because it's painfully true. When my dad was there, I felt safe. When he wasn't, I didn't. That's why I wanted to go everywhere with him. People probably assumed I just enjoyed riding around checking irrigation pivots, sitting quietly in a banker's office, visiting the accountant, repairing windmills, checking cattle, or driving across miles of ranchland fixing fences in the middle of a West Texas summer. The truth was much plainer than that. I'd rather spend an entire day standing beside my father while he worked than spend an afternoon at home.

At the time, I couldn't explain why. Now I can. Being with him meant I could breathe. Being with him meant I knew exactly who was coming home with me that evening. There wasn't uncertainty. There wasn't fear. There was just my dad. And as a little boy, that was enough.

When I think about my father today, hunting trips and baseball games certainly come to mind. But more than anything else, I think about work. Hard work. The kind of work that most people

never see anymore. My great-grandfather helped establish our family farm and ranch in 1941. My grandfather spent his life building it. My father continued carrying that responsibility.

If you've never lived around farming and ranching, it's difficult to explain the lifestyle. The cattle don't care if you're tired. Windmills still break. Fences still fall. Crops don't wait because it's your birthday. The work is there every single morning, waiting. My grandfather farmed into his eighties, climbing onto tractors long after most people would have retired. Nobody complained. Nobody looked for shortcuts. Nobody made excuses. They did the work, day after day, without ceremony.

I didn't understand it then, but those men were quietly giving me an example that would eventually call me back years later, when I had become someone who made excuses. The irony still isn't lost on me. I grew up surrounded by men who quietly did the work every single day. Somewhere along the way, I stopped living like them.

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For a little while, life actually felt like it was moving in the right direction. My father remarried.

Years later, he shared something with me that completely changed the way I viewed that decision. He said, "Randall, I wasn't looking for another wife. I was looking for a mother for you."

That conversation stopped me in my tracks. As a child, I never considered what that season must have been like for him. He wasn't only grieving the loss of his wife. He was trying to raise a little boy who had lost his mother before he ever had the chance to know her. He wasn't trying to replace anyone. He was trying to give me something he believed every little boy deserved: a mother, a family, a chance at something that looked a little more normal.

For a short time, I believed we had found it. She seemed kind. She smiled. She laughed. She genuinely tried. I remember thinking that maybe this was what everyone else's family felt like. Children don't need much evidence to believe tomorrow will be better than yesterday, and I believed it.

Then, almost overnight, everything changed.

Now I understand that trauma has a way of making timelines blur together. I can't tell you the exact day. I can't even tell you the exact year. What I can tell you is that somewhere around six or seven years old, my world quietly shifted. The warmth disappeared. The kindness disappeared. The woman I thought I knew disappeared.

The mask came off.

There is one thing I want to be very careful about here. This chapter isn't about creating a villain, and it isn't about making anyone look evil. It's about helping you understand what repeated trauma does to a child. That's the story. Not revenge. Not blame. Understanding.

The physical abuse started first. As painful as those episodes were, the physical pain was never what stayed with me. Bruises heal. Words don't.

Every afternoon followed almost the same pattern. The school bus dropped me off a little after four o'clock, and for a short while, I was alone. Dad was usually somewhere on the farm or ranch finishing another day's work. Those few minutes became the quietest part of my day. Then I'd begin watching the clock—not out of excitement, but because I knew what was coming.

Sometime after five o'clock, I'd hear the garage door. Even though my bedroom was on the opposite side of the house, I could hear that garage door every single afternoon. To this day, certain garage doors still catch my attention before my mind even understands why.

Then came the second sound: the back door. Not gently closing. Slamming. Hard. Almost as though she wanted me to know she was home. From that instant, I knew I had only seconds. She never stopped in the kitchen. She never changed clothes. She never sat down to unwind after work. She came directly to my room.

The living room had carpet. The entryway had tile. The hallway had carpet again. The instant her high heels hit that tile floor, I knew exactly where she was. Even now, decades later, hearing high heels echo across a tile floor still gets my attention.

Then came the perfume. Strong. Overpowering. For most of my adult life I couldn't understand why certain perfumes instantly made me uncomfortable. Now I know. My body remembered long before my mind did.

The bedroom door would fly open, and the yelling usually started before I even had a chance to speak. Sometimes there was a reason. Sometimes a reason was quickly invented. A spoon left in the sink. A sock behind the dryer. Something forgotten. Something imperfect. From where I stand today, I honestly don't think the reason mattered very much. The anger was already there.

One memory has stayed with me my entire life. I told her I had a headache. She asked why, and as honestly as a little boy knew how, I answered, "I think I'm stressed."

Whether I was seven, eight, or nine, I honestly don't know. Those years blend together. What I remember perfectly is what happened next.

"What does a little boy have to be stressed about?"

The next thing I remember was being hit with a frying pan.

That wasn't an isolated incident. It became my normal, day after day, year after year. But the deepest wounds weren't physical. They were verbal. Almost every afternoon I heard some version of the same messages. "You're lazy." "You're worthless." "Nobody likes you." "You're never going to amount to anything."

Then came the words that would follow me for decades.

"Your mother killed herself because of you."

Even writing those words today feels heavy. As an adult, I know how impossible that statement was. As a little boy, I didn't. Children believe adults—especially the adults they fear.

What made it even worse was that hearing those lies wasn't enough. Many times I was forced to repeat them back. Out loud. Again. And again. Imagine hearing something so many times that you stop questioning whether it's true. Imagine repeating those words yourself until they begin sounding familiar. That's how lies become identities. Not all at once. One repetition, one afternoon, one year at a time.

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Children don't usually fight lies with logic. They absorb them. That's exactly what I did. The abuse wasn't just changing how I felt. It was quietly changing who I believed I was.

Through all of it, I carried a question no child should ever have to ask: why couldn't anyone else see it? Around other people, she became someone completely different—especially around my dad. She smiled. She laughed. She appeared kind. The woman everyone else knew wasn't the woman I lived with.

As a little boy, that was incredibly confusing. How could someone be so different depending on who was in the room? Year after year I wondered if maybe I was the problem. Maybe I deserved it. Maybe everyone else saw something wrong with me that I couldn't see. That's what abuse does. It doesn't merely hurt you. It convinces you that you deserve to be hurt.

People often ask a question whenever they hear stories like mine: "Why didn't you just tell your dad?" That's a fair question, and the answer is straightforward. I was terrified. She had made something crystal clear: "If you tell anyone... it'll be twice as bad."

When you're a child, you don't weigh the odds. You don't think through every possible outcome. You survive. Fear became another prison. I loved my father. I trusted my father. I wasn't protecting him. I was trying to survive. My heart breaks now for that little boy, because he

believed silence was safer than truth. Fear convinced me of that, and fear is incredibly convincing when you're young.

That's why I wanted to go everywhere with my dad. The bank. The accountant's office. Checking irrigation pivots. Repairing windmills. Checking cattle. Driving fence lines. Most people probably thought I just enjoyed tagging along, and I did—but not for the reasons they assumed. Those places represented something much bigger than errands. They represented safety. I'd rather sit quietly in a chair at the bank for hours than spend another afternoon wondering what version of home I was about to walk into. The bank wasn't exciting. The accountant's office certainly wasn't exciting. Being with my dad was. Safety always is.

My father eventually sensed that something had changed. He didn't know what. He only knew his son wasn't the same little boy anymore. The outgoing kid who laughed easily had become quiet. The little boy who loved talking had become guarded. Something was wrong; he just couldn't see what it was. From where I stand today, I can't imagine how confusing that must have been for him. He was grieving. Running a farm and ranch. Trying to raise a little boy. Working from before sunrise until after sunset. He couldn't possibly see everything.

Eventually, family counseling was suggested. At the time, I didn't really know what counseling meant, and I certainly wasn't expecting it to change my life. In hindsight, I think it probably saved it.

The counselor asked questions. Real questions. Questions that couldn't be answered with rehearsed smiles. Questions that slowly exposed what had been hidden through all those afternoons. For the first time, I felt like someone actually saw me. If you've never experienced that after years of believing no one noticed, it's difficult to describe.

Being believed creates hope.

Eventually, I told the truth. Not part of it. All of it. I told my grandparents. I told my father. I told them about the abuse, the threats, the lies. Everything.

Shortly afterward, she was gone.

I never saw her again.

Many people would assume that's where the story ends. It wasn't. It was only the end of one chapter. The abuse stopped, but the lies didn't. They became quieter, that's all. Instead of hearing them from someone else, I started hearing them from myself.

It took me decades to understand that. The most dangerous lies aren't always the ones spoken to us. Sometimes they're the ones we eventually begin repeating in our own minds.

Those lies followed me into junior high. They followed me into high school. They followed me into college. They followed me into marriage. They followed me into business. They followed me into fatherhood. And years later, sitting in a rocking chair holding my daughter, they came back with the exact same message they had whispered to a little boy: "The people you love would be better off without you."

That wasn't a new lie. It was an old one. It had been waiting all along.

That's why I believe unresolved pain never really disappears. It waits. Patiently. Until something causes it to surface again. The abuse had ended, but the fear hadn't. The words had stopped, but the beliefs hadn't. Through most of my adult life I thought I was carrying nothing more than difficult memories. Now I understand I was carrying an identity that had been built on lies. And before I could ever rebuild my life, I would first have to discover that those lies were never true.

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As I've grown older, I've also come to see how incredibly blessed I was to have all four of my grandparents. For a long time, though, I didn't appreciate that.

My father's parents were woven into my everyday life. Granny and Papa were always there. Every Little League game. Every football game. Every stock show. Every milestone. My grandmother eventually struggled just to climb the bleachers, but she still found a way. My grandfather almost always had a video camera in his hands. Every season. Every game. Every memory.

Near the end of my football career, I finally told him, "Papa, you don't have to film anymore. Just watch the game." He smiled. I don't know that he ever completely stopped recording. That was who he was, plain and simple. He wanted to preserve moments, and today I understand why. Those small moments eventually become priceless. My grandparents didn't merely attend events. They attended my life.

My mother's parents had a very different road with me. It had nothing to do with loving me less. Life had become incredibly complicated after my mother's death. There were investigations. Rumors. Courtrooms. Questions no family should ever have to answer. My father was trying to grieve while raising a little boy. My mother's family was grieving a daughter. Everyone was hurting, and the only common denominator was me.

As a child, you recognize when adults become uncomfortable around one another. You just don't understand why. Although my maternal grandparents lived only about fifteen minutes away, our relationship wasn't what it could have been. No one intentionally kept me from them. Everyone

believed they were protecting me. Now I can see that clearly. Protection often comes from love. Sometimes it also comes with unintended consequences.

As I grew older, especially during college and adulthood, I slowly built that relationship. The older I became, the more I saw how deeply they loved me. I only wish I had understood it sooner.

One of the greatest blessings of my life is that I was able to spend time with all four of my grandparents during their final days. Very few people receive that gift. I did. Today, I carry one regret. It isn't that I didn't love them. It's that I wish I had intentionally spent even more time with them.

That understanding forever changed how I look at relationships. There will always be another meeting. Another sale. Another email. Another excuse. There may not always be another conversation. That's one of the reasons experiences have become so valuable to me. Experiences are the world's greatest currency—not because they can be bought, but because once they're gone, they can never be purchased again.

If this book teaches nothing else, I hope it teaches that. Spend the extra hour. Take the trip. Make the phone call. Sit at the dinner table a little longer. Tell people you love them while they're still here to hear it. One ordinary afternoon may someday become one of the most valuable memories you own.

After the abuse ended, everyone expected life to return to normal, including me. I thought once she was gone, everything would somehow go back to the way it was supposed to be. Children naturally believe changing their circumstances automatically changes how they feel. I learned that isn't always true.

The abuse was over; the fear wasn't. The yelling stopped; the lies didn't. They only grew quieter. The deepest wounds had never been on my body. They were in my mind. The stories she planted followed me everywhere—into junior high, into high school, into college, into adulthood. I wasn't carrying bruises anymore. I was carrying beliefs. Beliefs that I wasn't enough. Beliefs that I had to earn acceptance. Beliefs that people eventually leave. Beliefs that something must somehow be wrong with me.

The strange thing about lies is that if you hear them often enough, they stop sounding like lies. They become the soundtrack playing quietly in the background of your life.

Without noticing it happen, I became very good at hiding. Deceiving anyone was never the point; hiding had become survival. The outgoing little boy slowly disappeared. I became quieter. More reserved. More observant. I learned to study people's expressions before speaking. I learned to

read the room. I learned to smile when I didn't feel like smiling. I learned to say, "I'm fine." Even when I wasn't.

The mask didn't appear overnight. It formed one layer at a time. Every lie added another layer. Every disappointment added another. Every fear added another. Before long, I had become someone who looked perfectly okay on the outside while carrying something entirely different on the inside.

The frightening part is that the mask worked. Teachers didn't know. Friends didn't know. Coaches didn't know. Most family members didn't know. Eventually, I didn't know either. I had worn it for so long that I forgot it was there.

That's what unresolved pain does. It quietly becomes part of your identity. You stop saying, "Something happened to me." You begin believing, "This is simply who I am." For a very long time, I believed exactly that.

Ironically, the places where I felt most alive were also the places where I learned some of life's greatest lessons. Football. Rugby. 4-H. The farm. The ranch. Those weren't hobbies to me. They became outlets.

Football, especially, became my release. I was quiet off the field. Reserved. I rarely caused trouble. But once the helmet went on, everything changed. Every collision became an opportunity to release anger I didn't know how to express anywhere else. Every tackle. Every hit. Every snap. For a few seconds at a time, everything else disappeared.

People often talk about physical pain. The truth is, I didn't feel much of it. Emotional pain had already taught me what real pain felt like, and compared to that, broken bones didn't seem nearly as significant. During the first scrimmage of my senior season, I broke my wrist. I remember the exact play. I finished the season anyway. After football ended, the orthopedic surgeon looked at the X-rays and shook his head. He smiled and said, "You're either very tough... or very stupid."

Maybe I was a little of both. But I think there was something much deeper happening. I had become so accustomed to carrying emotional pain that physical pain barely registered. Football didn't create my toughness. It revealed it. Rugby did the same.

At the time, I thought sports were saving me. Now I believe God was quietly preparing me—preparing me for a day when I'd finally stop surviving and begin healing.

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One of the greatest lessons I've learned is that you never truly know what another person is carrying. Nobody wears a hat that says, "I'm hurting." Or "I'm depressed." Or "I'm barely

hanging on." Or "I don't know how much longer I can keep pretending."

Most people just smile. They go to work. They coach their kids. They attend church. They post pictures. They laugh at the right moments. Then they quietly carry burdens that almost nobody else ever sees. I know, because I became one of those people long before I recognized it in myself.

That truth has forever changed the way I try to treat people. Today, I don't assume I know someone's story merely because I can see their face. Kindness isn't something people earn. Sometimes it's something they desperately need. One conversation. One encouraging word. One person who genuinely listens. That can change the direction of someone else's day. Sometimes it changes the direction of their life. I know because there were people who unknowingly did exactly that for me.

As I look back on my childhood today, I don't see it through the same eyes I once did. For a long time, all I could see was the pain. Then I saw the abuse. Then I saw the loss. Today, I see something different.

I see people.

I see my father carrying far more than I ever understood as a little boy—a man grieving the loss of his wife while trying to raise a son and keep a farm and ranch alive, a man who wasn't searching for another wife nearly as much as he was searching for a mother for his little boy. I see grandparents quietly stepping into roles they never expected to fill. I see coaches who unknowingly gave me confidence when I had very little. I see teachers who believed in me. I see 4-H families and stock show families who modeled healthy relationships without ever realizing they were doing it.

Now I see seeds. Seeds God had been planting all along. The remarkable thing about seeds is that they spend a long time underground before anyone ever sees evidence of growth. At the time, I couldn't see any of them. All I saw was what hurt. Today I understand that God was preparing me long before I knew why He was preparing me. That perspective has changed everything.

It also finally answered another question I carried for so many years: why didn't I tell someone sooner? It wasn't because I didn't trust my father. It wasn't because I didn't love my grandparents. It wasn't because I wanted to protect the person hurting me. It was because I was scared. Fear convinced me that silence was safer than truth. Fear became another story I accepted.

That's the thing about fear. If you don't confront it, it quietly begins writing your future.

The abuse eventually ended. The fear didn't—not for a very long time. The stories followed me into high school. Into college. Into business. Into marriage. Into fatherhood. They influenced decisions I didn't even know I was making. Through most of my adult life I thought I was making adult decisions. Now I understand that many of them were little-boy decisions, made by someone who still believed childhood lies.

That truth was heartbreaking when it landed. It was also incredibly freeing. Because if lies could shape a life, then truth could reshape one.

I didn't know it then, but arriving at that truth would take years. It would take failure. It would take success. It would take alcohol. It would take a failed restaurant. It would take lawsuits. It would take a mirror. It would take a rocking chair. It would take a sleeping little girl in my arms. Only then would I begin replacing old stories with new ones. Not stories someone else created for me. Stories that were actually true.

That's one of the reasons I wanted this book to begin here. My childhood doesn't define me—it doesn't—but it explains me. There's a difference. We don't get to choose the opening chapter of our lives. We do get to decide whether we allow that opening chapter to become the entire book.

For far too long, I unknowingly did. I allowed childhood wounds to influence adult decisions. I allowed fear to become my compass. I allowed someone else's words to determine my worth. Most of all, I accepted stories that were never true. From where I stand today, I can see that I wasn't simply living life. I was trying to outrun stories I didn't even know I was carrying.

That's why I called this chapter *Playing From Behind*. It isn't that life had been unfair, and it isn't that I want sympathy. It's that I started adulthood carrying weight most people couldn't see. Invisible wounds. Invisible fears. Invisible stories.

The strange thing is, I don't think I was alone. I think most people are playing from behind. Some carry rejection. Some carry shame. Some carry addiction. Some carry failure. Some carry grief. Some carry words spoken over them decades ago that they still believe today. The stories are different. The weight feels remarkably similar.

The good news is this.

Stories can be rewritten.

Not by pretending the past never happened. Not by ignoring the pain. But by finally telling yourself the truth. That truth would take me years to discover. Before I could rebuild my life, before I could stop making excuses, before I could run toward the man I wanted to become, I first had to see that I had been believing those old stories all along.

That discovery changed everything. It also marked the beginning of a much different road—one that would eventually force me to confront not only the lies I had been told, but the lies I had begun telling myself.

CHAPTER 2

The Cost of Excuses

There are few lies more dangerous than the ones we tell ourselves. Not because they're convincing, but because we want them to be convincing.

For a long stretch of my life, if someone asked me how I was doing, I gave the exact same answer: "I'm fine." Friends asked, and I said it. Coworkers asked, and I said it. Family asked, and I said it. Customers asked, "How's everything going?" and the answer came back the same every single time, word for word. "I'm fine." The strange thing is that eventually I started believing my own answer — or at least I wanted to believe it. The truth was very different from the answer I kept giving. I wasn't fine, and I hadn't been fine for a very long time.

By this point in my life, I had become very good at wearing a mask. The little boy who had learned to hide eventually became a man who knew how to pretend. From the outside, life looked successful enough. I had graduated from college. I had built a career in medical sales. I had gotten married, and I had become a father. Anyone looking in from the outside probably would have assumed everything was going according to plan. What they couldn't see was what was happening underneath the surface. Neither could I.

One of the dreams I had carried since I was young was opening my own restaurant. Growing up around my dad's catering business, I had fallen in love with the idea of bringing people together over great food. For me, it was never just about owning a business. It was about creating something. It was about building something. It was about serving people. I poured everything I had into that dream — my time, my energy, my money, my heart. Like many entrepreneurs, I believed that hard work alone would be enough. Sometimes it is. Sometimes it isn't. The restaurant struggled, and then it failed.

People often summarize that season of my life by saying, "The restaurant closed." That's true. It's also a massive understatement. Closing the doors wasn't the hardest part of it; the hardest part came afterward. Saturday mornings became something I dreaded, because every knock at the door made my stomach tighten. More than once, I opened the front door to find someone

standing there waiting to serve me with another lawsuit. Every single week seemed to bring another reminder of everything that had gone wrong.

Before I ever dealt with the lawsuits, though, there was something far more important to me: my employees. Those people had trusted me, and many of them depended on those paychecks to get by. Before I started worrying about myself, I made sure every one of them received their final paycheck. I made sure payroll was handled and the taxes were addressed. The responsibilities that belonged to me stayed with me. Only after every one of those obligations had been taken care of did I finally begin facing what remained.

And there was a lot remaining. There was debt. There were lawsuits. There was embarrassment, and there was failure. The pressure seemed endless. What made it even more difficult was that I genuinely believed I had failed everyone around me — my family, my employees, my investors, and myself. The restaurant wasn't just a business to me. It had become part of my identity, and when it failed, I quietly believed I had failed right along with it. Now I can see something I couldn't see then. Businesses fail. People don't. At the time, though, I couldn't separate the two. Failure felt deeply personal.

The financial pressure continued growing. The lawsuits continued coming. The anxiety became a constant companion, and the depression quietly settled in. And somewhere during that season, alcohol stopped being something I occasionally enjoyed and became something I depended on. I didn't start drinking because I was celebrating. I started drinking because I wanted to feel different. From where I stand today, I can see that's an important distinction.

Most people assume alcohol was the problem. For me, alcohol wasn't the problem — at least not initially. It was the solution I chose. The real problem was what I was trying to solve. There were the wounds from childhood. There was the pressure from the business. There was the constant anxiety, the depression, the fear, the embarrassment, and the feeling that I was letting everyone down. Alcohol temporarily quieted all of it. At least I thought it did. For a little while, the noise stopped. For a little while, I felt lighter. For a little while, I didn't have to think at all. That's what made it so dangerous. It seemed to work. The problem was that every morning, everything returned — and it usually came back stronger than before.

The cycle became painfully predictable. I would wake up. I would carry the weight. I would go to work, come home, have a drink, and feel a little better. Then I would wake up the next morning and carry even more weight than I had carried the day before. It went on like that, over and over again.

At the time, I would have told you I was a functional alcoholic, and I actually believed those words when I said them. After all, I could still get up every morning. I could still provide for my

family. I could still perform at work, and I could still smile. From the outside, nothing looked completely out of control. That's why the word functional became so dangerous. It gave me permission to stay exactly where I was. These days I don't even like using that phrase, because the truth is I wasn't functioning. I was surviving. There's a difference.

Every morning I woke up carrying anxiety before my feet ever touched the floor. It was already there waiting for me — the pressure, the dread, the heaviness, the constant feeling that something was wrong. I just became accustomed to it. That's one of the frightening things about slow decline. You adapt to it. You normalize it. You convince yourself that everyone must feel this way. And then you stop questioning it altogether.

Today I understand something I couldn't see back then. The hangovers never actually disappeared; I only stopped recognizing them for what they were. Feeling terrible became normal. Feeling anxious became normal. Feeling depressed became normal, and living exhausted became normal too. That's what happens when the decline is gradual. The extraordinary slowly becomes ordinary.

Through all that time, I believed alcohol was helping me manage stress. The truth was very different. It wasn't helping me manage anything; it was helping me postpone everything. There's a huge difference between the two. Every drink pushed tomorrow's problems into tomorrow. Unfortunately, tomorrow always came. And when it did, the problems were still there waiting, usually heavier than they had been before.

I often think about physical pain now. If you break your arm, the pain serves a purpose. Pain tells you something needs attention. Now imagine taking a medication that completely removes the pain while never treating the broken bone underneath. You might feel better for a while, but the injury would still be there. That's exactly what I was doing emotionally. Alcohol wasn't healing the wound; it was numbing the symptoms, and the wound remained. My childhood wounds remained. The shame remained. The anxiety remained. The depression remained. The embarrassment over the restaurant remained, and the lawsuits remained. Nothing had actually changed. I had just delayed dealing with all of it one more day. Then another. Then another.

One of the hardest truths I've ever had to accept is this: you can't heal pain by numbing it. You can't solve anxiety by avoiding it. And you can't rebuild your life while you're constantly escaping from it.

Eventually, something else sank in, and it was harder to face than anything before it. I wasn't just hurting myself. I was hurting the people I loved most.

One of the biggest lies I told myself during that season was that everything I was doing was for my family. The long hours were for them. The stress was for them. The pressure, the drinking, the chasing, the striving — I convinced myself that every bit of it was for them. In hindsight, it wasn't. My wife didn't need a better provider nearly as much as she needed her husband. My daughters didn't need another paycheck; they needed their dad. And although I was physically sitting right there in the room, mentally I was somewhere else entirely.

Even when I was home, I wasn't fully present. I was carrying tomorrow's problems into today's time with the people I loved. I was always thinking, always worrying, always trying to solve another crisis somewhere else. I was sitting right beside my family while living almost entirely inside my own head. My body occupied the room. My mind rarely did.

The painful part is that I didn't recognize any of it. The people who loved me did — especially my wife. She watched the distance grow long before I ever noticed it. She saw me changing. She saw pieces of me disappearing, and she watched the version of me she had married slowly becoming someone else. And honestly, I didn't like that man either. I just wasn't ready to admit it yet.

The fire that had once driven me seemed to be disappearing. Life became routine. Work, stress, drink, sleep, repeat. The scary part wasn't that it happened at all. The scary part was how gradually it happened.

One ordinary day at a time.

It happened exactly the same way childhood lies had quietly become childhood beliefs. Everything compounds. Good habits compound. Bad habits compound. Truth compounds, and so do lies. Every ordinary decision I made was becoming another vote for the man I was becoming. Unfortunately, I didn't like where those votes were leading me.

* * *

The first person who noticed what was happening wasn't me. It was my wife. She didn't need a dramatic speech, and she didn't need a list of everything that was wrong. She was living right beside it every single day. She watched the distance grow — and it wasn't that I had stopped loving my family. It was that I had slowly stopped bringing the best version of myself home to them.

Even now, I can only imagine how difficult those years must have been for her. She saw me carrying burdens I refused to talk about. She watched me smile in public while quietly disappearing in private. She prayed for me long before I was ever willing to pray for myself, and she believed there was still something more inside of me long before I could see it myself.

One day she said something that I've never forgotten. "You're going to have to decide." That was it. There was no lecture, no argument, no long explanation. Just one sentence. She didn't have to explain what she meant, because I already knew. I was standing at a fork in the road. One path continued exactly where I was already headed. The other path required becoming someone completely different. Deep down, I already knew which path I wanted to take. I just wasn't sure I was capable of walking it.

Around that same time, another battle was quietly taking place. Every morning I walked into the bathroom and caught a glimpse of myself in the mirror. At first, I tried not to look at all. Eventually, I couldn't avoid it anymore.

Most people assume the mirror became significant because I had gained weight, and the weight certainly bothered me. A few years earlier I had completed an Ironman triathlon. I knew what discipline looked like, and I knew what my body was capable of doing. Now I barely recognized the person staring back at me. But the extra weight wasn't what hurt the most. What hurt the most was what I saw behind my own eyes.

The fire was gone.

That's still the best way I know how to describe it. The drive was gone. The excitement was gone. The belief, the confidence, the energy — everything that once made me feel alive seemed buried beneath years of excuses, disappointment, and compromise. I remember standing there one morning, looking at my reflection, and feeling something I had never admitted to myself before. I didn't like the man staring back at me. It had nothing to do with how he looked. It had everything to do with who he had become. That truth landed harder than any lawsuit, harder than any business failure, and harder than any criticism I'd ever received.

For so long I had blamed circumstances. I blamed the economy. I blamed the restaurant. I blamed the lawsuits, my childhood, other people. I always had someone or something to point toward. Standing in front of that mirror, there was nowhere left to point. The mirror doesn't care about excuses. It doesn't negotiate with you, and it doesn't soften the truth. It simply reflects what's there.

What I saw wasn't just a heavier man. I saw a husband who wasn't fully present. I saw a father who wasn't bringing his best home. I saw a businessman hiding behind stress, and I saw a man trying to numb his pain instead of healing it. For the first time in a very long time, I stopped seeing a victim. I saw responsibility. That was painful. It was also the beginning of freedom, because as long as someone else owned the problem, someone else owned the solution.

The day I accepted that I was responsible for the direction of my own life, something incredibly hopeful arrived along with the pain. If I had become this man, then I could just as surely become someone else. I didn't need another excuse. I didn't need another reason. I needed another identity. I just didn't know what that identity looked like yet.

What I did know was this: I couldn't keep living the way I was living. Something had to change. I just had no idea where to begin looking for it.

I didn't know it then, but life was about to answer that question in the most unexpected place imaginable. It wouldn't happen in a courtroom. It wouldn't happen at the restaurant, and it wouldn't happen in front of that bathroom mirror. It would happen late one night, in a dark nursery, with a sleeping little girl resting in my arms.

The Rocking Chair

People often assume the hardest day of your life is the day everything falls apart. For me, it wasn't. By then the restaurant had already closed. The lawsuits were already underway. The debt had already piled up. The anxiety had already become part of my daily life, and the drinking had already become my escape. None of those things were the hardest part. The hardest part came after the noise settled. It came after the phone stopped ringing, after there was nothing left to fix. That's when I was finally left alone with myself.

I think that's one of the reasons so many of us stay busy. Busyness becomes another distraction. As long as we're answering emails, solving problems, chasing the next opportunity, or putting out another fire, we rarely have to sit quietly with the questions we've spent years avoiding. I certainly never did.

For a long time I blamed the restaurant for where I was. Then I blamed the lawsuits. Then I blamed the economy. Then I blamed my circumstances. Eventually something uncomfortable became clear to me. None of those things had created what I was feeling. They had only exposed it. The restaurant didn't create my insecurity. The lawsuits didn't create my anxiety. Alcohol didn't create the emptiness. Those things simply uncovered wounds that had been living beneath the surface most of my life. The pit didn't create the pain. It revealed it.

I believe that's one of the reasons God sometimes allows us to reach the bottom. It isn't to punish us. It's to remove every distraction that keeps us from facing the truth. That's exactly where I found myself. There was no more pretending, no more blaming, and no more hiding. It was just me and the man I had become.

It wasn't a man I respected. That's still difficult to admit, even now. It isn't that it hurts my pride today; it's that it reminds me how lost I had become. The version of me living through that

season wasn't the husband I wanted to be. He wasn't the father I wanted to be. He wasn't the leader I wanted to be. And most painfully of all, he wasn't the man I believed God had created me to become.

Every night I would carry my youngest daughter, Isla, into her room after her bottle. I'd sit down in an old rocking chair, hold her against my chest, and gently rock her until she fell asleep. That became our nightly routine together. The room was almost completely dark. A small nightlight cast just enough light across the nursery for me to see her face, and soft music played quietly through the baby monitor. Everything about that room felt peaceful. Everything except me.

Some nights my eyes filled with tears. Other nights I cried without even understanding why I was crying. At first I blamed stress. Then I blamed the restaurant. Then I blamed the lawsuits. Then I blamed exhaustion. Eventually I ran out of things to blame, and the truth was much deeper than any of those explanations. I was broken. Not physically — emotionally, mentally, and spiritually.

People often misunderstand what depression looks like. They imagine someone who never smiles, someone who never leaves the house, someone who can't function at all. That wasn't me. I smiled. I worked. I laughed when I was supposed to laugh, and I showed up wherever I was expected to show up. From the outside, I looked perfectly fine. On the inside, I was drowning.

I've thought about that a lot over the years. Nobody wears a hat that says, "I'm hurting." Nobody wears one that says, "I'm depressed," or one that says, "I'm barely hanging on." Most people just smile, and then they quietly carry burdens that almost nobody else ever sees. I understand that now, because I became one of those people myself.

Night after night I sat in that rocking chair holding my little girl while quietly believing the exact same lies that had been following me since childhood. "You're a failure." "You're not enough." "Everyone would be better off without you." When you've listened to lies for long enough, they stop sounding like lies. They begin sounding like your own thoughts instead. And that frightened me more than anything else did.

I wasn't making plans to end my life. I wasn't thinking about dramatic exits. I just didn't want to wake up. Even writing those words today is difficult — not because I'm ashamed of them, but because I know someone reading this book may understand exactly what I mean by them. I wanted the pressure to stop. I wanted the anxiety to stop. I wanted the constant feeling of failure to stop, and I wanted the noise inside my head to finally become quiet. Somewhere along the way, I convinced myself that my family deserved someone better than me. I know now how distorted that thinking had become. The answer was never my absence. The answer was always my transformation. I just couldn't see it yet from where I was sitting.

* * *

I don't know how long I sat there that night. Maybe fifteen minutes. Maybe an hour. Time has a strange way of disappearing when you're carrying that much weight. I just kept rocking. Forward, then back. Forward, then back. The room was completely silent except for the soft music playing in the background and the quiet rhythm of the chair moving beneath me.

Then something happened. It didn't happen outside of me — it happened somewhere inside of me. For the first time that night, I stopped staring into the darkness. I looked down at her. Really looked. There she was, completely asleep. Her tiny hand rested against my chest, and her breathing was slow and steady. She had absolutely no idea that her father was sitting there fighting the biggest battle of his life.

She trusted me completely.

That thought hit me harder than every lawsuit, harder than every business failure, and harder than every lie I had been believing about myself. This little girl believed I could protect her. She believed I would always be there for her. She believed her dad could fix anything in the world.

Sitting there, something surfaced that brought me to tears. I didn't want to put her down. It wasn't that she hadn't fallen asleep yet — it was that putting her down meant returning to reality. As long as she was in my arms, I could pretend the world outside that nursery didn't exist at all. So I rocked her a little longer. Then I rocked her a little longer still. I wanted to freeze that hour and keep it forever. Just one more minute. One more prayer. One more chance to hold her.

Even now, all these years later, I can still see her face. I can still hear that music, and I can still feel that rocking chair moving beneath me. Some memories never leave you. I'm grateful this is one of them.

People sometimes ask me why I still call Isla my angel. This is why. It isn't that she saved me — God did that. But I believe God chose to use a sleeping little girl to wake up her father. She became the first crack in the darkness. She became the first glimpse of hope, and the first point where the truth finally became louder than the lies.

As I sat there holding her, one thought slowly replaced another. For months — maybe even years — I had been thinking about what life had done to me. That night, I started thinking about what I was doing to the people I loved most. That single shift in perspective changed everything.

The restaurant was still gone. The lawsuits still existed. The debt hadn't disappeared. The anxiety was still there, and so was the depression. Nothing about my circumstances had changed that night. But something inside me had. For the first time in years, I could see that my daughters

didn't need a perfect father. They needed their father. My wife didn't need another provider. She needed her husband. The answer wasn't my absence. The answer was my transformation. It had been all along.

That understanding broke me — in the best possible way. I cried harder that night than I ever had before. It wasn't that I had finally given up. It was that I had finally stopped pretending. For so long I had worn a mask so convincing that even I believed it. That night, it finally came off. Not all at once, but just enough for the truth to get in.

That's the thing about truth. It doesn't have to knock the whole wall down at once. It only needs one small crack. Light has a way of finding even the smallest opening, and hope works exactly the same way.

That night didn't solve my problems. It didn't eliminate the lawsuits. It didn't erase the debt. It didn't magically heal my depression, and it didn't remove my anxiety. But it did something much more important than any of that would have been. It gave me a reason to fight. Not for success. Not for money. Not for another business. For my family. And maybe, for the first time in a very long time, for myself.

From where I stand today, I can honestly say that God answered every single prayer I prayed in that rocking chair — just not in the way I expected Him to answer them. I asked Him to take away my pain; instead, He showed me my purpose. I asked Him to remove me from the struggle; instead, He walked with me through it. I asked Him for an ending, and He gave me a brand-new beginning instead. At the time, I didn't understand any of it. Today, I thank Him for it.

There isn't a single prayer that goes unanswered. Sometimes the answer is yes. Sometimes the answer is wait. Sometimes the answer is no. I often wonder about it now. What if God wasn't failing to meet my expectations? What if He was patiently preparing to exceed them instead? I didn't know it then, but while I was asking God to end my pain, He was quietly preparing to transform my entire life.

The next step wouldn't begin in the rocking chair, though. It would begin a short time later. It would begin late one night, alone in a hotel room, with a phone in my hand and one decision that would change the trajectory of my life forever.

The Hotel Room

The rocking chair changed my heart. It didn't immediately change my habits. I wish I could tell you that I walked out of that nursery and never struggled again, but that isn't my story. The anxiety didn't disappear the next morning. The depression didn't magically lift. The temptation to drink didn't vanish, and life didn't suddenly become any easier. If anything, my circumstances

looked exactly the same as they had the day before. The difference was that, for the first time in years, I no longer wanted to stay the same. That desire became the beginning of everything that followed.

I can see now that I had spent year after year trying to change my life without changing myself. That never works. You can't build a different future while remaining the same person who created the present. Something deep inside me finally understood that truth. I didn't need another opportunity. What I needed was another identity.

Not long after that season, I found myself in yet another hotel room while traveling for work. Like most people in medical sales, I spent a lot of nights on the road. Hotels became routine for me. Different city. Different room. Same schedule every time. One evening, after another long day, I was lying in bed doing what so many of us do. I was scrolling, mindlessly moving from one post to the next. Then something caught my attention. It was an advertisement for a men's coaching group.

To this day, I don't remember exactly what the advertisement said. I don't remember the headline, and I don't remember the sales pitch. What I remember is the feeling it gave me. It was as though that message had found me at the exact instant I was finally ready to hear it.

Over the years, plenty of people had offered me advice. Some of it was good. Some of it wasn't. None of it had ever really landed — and it wasn't that the advice itself was wrong. I just wasn't ready to hear it yet. This time was different. For the first time in a long time, I felt something I hadn't felt in years.

I felt possibility.

I didn't know where it would lead. I didn't know if it would work, and I didn't know whether it would actually change anything at all. I only knew one thing for certain. Doing nothing was no longer an option. So I clicked. Immediately. There was no debate, no overthinking, no waiting until Monday, no telling myself I'd come back to it later. I just clicked.

That may have been one of the most important clicks of my life. It didn't solve a single one of my problems, but it represented something I hadn't done in years. I bet on myself.

One of the first challenges my coach gave me was straightforward: quit drinking. At first, it almost sounded too easy to matter. How could one single decision possibly change everything? In hindsight, I can see that it didn't change everything. It changed me.

All that time, I had convinced myself alcohol helped me relax. I told myself it helped me sleep. I told myself it helped me deal with stress. The truth was much different. Alcohol wasn't helping

me deal with anything. It was helping me avoid everything. Avoidance disguises itself as relief. For a little while the pressure feels lighter. For a little while the anxiety gets quieter and the noise fades away. Then morning comes, and everything you postponed is still sitting there waiting for you. Only now, it's heavier than it was.

One of the greatest discoveries of my life came during that season. Alcohol wasn't the root; it was the symptom. If I quit drinking without changing the man who depended on it, something else would eventually come along and take its place. I couldn't merely become a man who didn't drink anymore. I had to become a man who no longer needed alcohol to escape his own life. That's a completely different kind of transformation altogether.

The first few weeks weren't glamorous, and nothing magical happened. The lawsuits didn't disappear. The debt didn't disappear, and the pressure certainly didn't disappear. What disappeared was the fog. For the first time in years, I could actually think clearly. For the first time in years, I wasn't waking up carrying the consequences of whatever I had done the night before. For the first time in years, I was finally facing reality exactly as it was. Reality can be uncomfortable to face, but reality is also honest. And honesty — honesty is where the rebuilding truly begins.

Little by little, I stopped asking, "How do I escape this?" and started asking a completely different question: "What's the next right step?" Not the next ten steps. Not next year. Just the next single step. I didn't know it then, but that single shift in thinking would eventually change every area of my life. Because becoming someone new doesn't happen all at once. It happens one next step at a time.

* * *

The clarity that came from quitting drinking gave me something I hadn't experienced in years. It gave me the ability to think honestly. For the first time in a long while, I wasn't trying to solve today's problems while standing in yesterday's fog. The restaurant was still gone. The lawsuits were still there. The debt was still very real. Nothing about my circumstances had improved overnight. The difference was that I was finally seeing all of them for what they actually were.

They were problems. They were not identities.

I had been confusing the two for as long as I could remember. The restaurant failed, and therefore I was a failure. I struggled with alcohol, and therefore I was weak. I was battling anxiety, and therefore something must be wrong with me. Those statements sound ridiculous to me now. At the time, though, I believed every single one of them. That's what lies do. They quietly become your identity.

The coaching group challenged much more than just my drinking. It challenged the stories I had been telling myself. It challenged the excuses, and it challenged the blame. Most importantly of all, it challenged my sense of ownership.

One conversation in particular still stands out to me. My coach asked me a simple question. "Randall... what part of this is your responsibility?" I remember immediately thinking about everything that wasn't my responsibility. The economy wasn't. The restaurant wasn't. Neither were the lawsuits, my childhood, the pressure, or the stress. I had a whole list ready to go. Then I stopped, because for the first time, it dawned on me that I was answering a question he hadn't even asked. He didn't ask me what had happened to me. He asked me what part of it was my responsibility.

That question stayed with me. I couldn't stop thinking about it. Little by little, something began changing inside me. Instead of asking, "Why did this happen?" I started asking, "What am I going to do now?" That's a completely different question. One question searches for blame. The other searches for responsibility. Responsibility is heavy. It's also incredibly freeing at the same time. Because if I'm responsible for my response, then I still have choices. I still have agency, and I still have hope.

One of the greatest lies I had believed through all those years was that someone else was eventually coming to rescue me. Maybe another opportunity would come along. Maybe another business would save me. Maybe more money would fix it. Maybe someone would finally understand what I was carrying. The truth is, nobody was coming. And strangely enough, accepting that fact wasn't depressing. It was liberating. Because if nobody was coming to save me, then maybe God had already given me everything I needed to begin saving myself. Not by myself, but through Him — and through choosing differently. It would happen one decision at a time. One promise at a time.

One ordinary day at a time.

That's when I finally understood something my father, my grandfather, and my great-grandfather had been quietly teaching me my entire life. The work still has to be done. The cattle don't care how you feel. The fences still need repairing. The windmills still break, and the crops still need attention. Life doesn't stop just because we're feeling discouraged. The work always remains. Somewhere along the way, I had drifted away from that example. Now I was slowly finding my way back to it.

The remarkable thing about that season is that nothing looked particularly dramatic from the outside. There wasn't one giant breakthrough. There was no overnight transformation, and there was no movie scene where everything suddenly became clear. It was much quieter than that. It

was one honest conversation. It was one difficult decision. It was one promise kept. Then another, and another after that. The changes were almost invisible — until one day I looked back and saw that I wasn't the same man who had walked into that hotel room. I still had a long way to go. But for the first time in years, I was finally moving in the right direction, and I could feel it.

I didn't know it then, but one conversation was about to permanently change the way I looked at accountability, discipline, and excuses. It wasn't gentle, and it wasn't polished. In fact, it made me angry. Years later, I'm incredibly grateful that it did.

* * *

One day, during that first coaching program, I received a message that hit me harder than almost anything I had heard up to that point in my life. It wasn't encouraging. It wasn't gentle, and it wasn't designed to make me feel better. It was designed to wake me up. The message read:

"You don't need accountability, you need f'ing discipline! You're the one putting food and booze in your mouth, not anyone else! Don't like it? Not what you want to hear? Stop f'ing doing it!! Take a little pride in strengthening your weaknesses and start becoming an all-around asset! If you want to quit drinking, you literally will not take another drink. If not, you'll keep lying to yourself and proving what takes precedence!"

I hated reading it. Every part of me wanted to defend myself. I wanted to explain the restaurant. I wanted to explain the lawsuits, the stress, the childhood trauma, the anxiety, and the depression. I had an answer ready for everything. Then something occurred to me. He wasn't asking for my explanation. He was confronting my excuses, and those are two very different things.

That message stayed with me because every single sentence in it forced me to look in the mirror instead of looking at everyone else. It stripped away every place I had been hiding. Was the restaurant difficult? Absolutely it was. Were the lawsuits real? Without question they were. Did childhood trauma affect me? More than I understood at the time. But none of those things were physically picking up a bottle.

I was.

That truth hurt. It also became one of the most freeing turning points of my life. I certainly didn't enjoy hearing it, but it left me with nowhere else to hide, and that turned out to be exactly what I needed. For so long I had been looking for accountability. As it turned out, accountability wasn't what I was missing at all. Discipline was. Accountability can remind you. Accountability can encourage you. Accountability can ask hard questions. But accountability can't make your decisions for you. At some point, every one of us has to decide who we're going to become when no one else is watching. That's what discipline is.

For the first time, I began understanding the difference between knowing what to do and actually doing it. I had spent so much of my life collecting information. I knew alcohol wasn't helping me. I knew I needed to lose the weight. I knew I needed to become more present with my family, and I knew I needed to stop making excuses. Knowledge had never been my problem. Execution was the problem.

Seeing that changed everything for me. I stopped searching for another motivational speech. I stopped waiting until I felt inspired, and I stopped telling myself that tomorrow would somehow be different. Tomorrow had become my favorite excuse. Eventually it became clear to me that tomorrow never changes anything. Only today does. One decision, made today — that's where change actually begins.

The coach's words were hard to hear. Today, I'm grateful for every one of them, because sometimes the most loving thing someone can do is refuse to participate in your excuses. They cared more about the man I could become than about the comfort of the man I was. I needed that. They weren't trying to tear me down. They were refusing to let me settle, and there's a world of difference between the two.

Honestly, I don't think that message changed my life all by itself. What it did was confirm something I had already begun discovering in the rocking chair and the hotel room. Nobody was coming to save me. God had been inviting me to become someone different all along. The decision had always been mine to make.

That became the turning point for me. I stopped asking, "How do I fix my life?" and I started asking the one question that would eventually end up written on a Post-it note stuck to my bathroom mirror.

Who do I have to become?

I had no idea how much that one question was about to change the direction of my life. The answer wouldn't come all at once. It would begin with one unremarkable decision — the simple decision to lace up a pair of running shoes.

Chapter 3 ## Momentum

One of the biggest misconceptions people have about transformation is that it happens all at once. It doesn't. From where I stand today, I can tell you there wasn't one morning when I woke up and suddenly became a different man. There wasn't one prayer, one workout, one conversation, or one breakthrough. There were hundreds of small decisions that slowly began moving my life in a different direction.

The rocking chair awakened me. The hotel room gave me hope. The coaching group gave me direction. Now came the hard part: living it.

Quitting drinking wasn't the finish line. It was the starting line. Alcohol had spent year after year covering up problems I refused to face, and the instant I removed it, every one of those problems was still waiting for me. The lawsuits. The debt. The anxiety. The embarrassment. None of them disappeared. For the first time in years, though, I had a clear mind to face them.

That changed everything.

Instead of spending another day avoiding difficult conversations, I started making them. Phone calls I had been putting off for months suddenly became today's responsibility. Financial decisions I had avoided finally got made. Paperwork that had been sitting untouched got touched. The remarkable thing about facing your problems is that most of them become smaller the second you stop running from them. Not easier. Smaller. Because uncertainty almost always grows larger in our imagination than it does in reality.

Every conversation I completed gave me a little more confidence. Every responsibility I handled gave me a little more peace. It wasn't that life had suddenly become easy; it was that I was finally moving instead of hiding. I often tell people today that action creates clarity. I didn't know those words back then. I only knew that every difficult thing I stopped avoiding became one less thing controlling my life.

Little by little, hope returned. I started sleeping better. My thinking became clearer. The constant fog that had followed me for so long slowly began lifting. My family noticed the difference before I fully did. I was more present, more engaged, more optimistic. Not perfect. Just different. For the first time in a very long time, I believed I might actually become the man I had started envisioning in that hotel room.

Momentum is an incredible feeling. Once you've spent years standing still, even small progress feels enormous. That's exactly where I found myself. I wasn't celebrating because everything had

been fixed. I was celebrating because I was finally moving in the right direction.

Then something happened that I never saw coming. One day my coach made a statement that immediately stopped me. He said, "You can't do this without me."

I don't know exactly what everyone else in the room thought. I only know what happened inside me. Everything resisted those words. I remember sitting there thinking, "Watch me."

Now I can see that wasn't confidence. That was pride. There's a difference. At the time, though, I couldn't see it.

Part of my personality has always been incredibly stubborn. Sometimes that stubbornness has served me well. Other times it has gotten in my own way, and this became one of those times. Instead of hearing the value of community, I heard dependency. Instead of hearing someone encouraging continued accountability, I heard someone telling me I wasn't capable on my own. Those are two completely different messages. Unfortunately, I heard the wrong one.

So I left.

I honestly believed I was making the right decision. I believed I had learned everything I needed to learn. I believed I could continue growing without anyone else's help. I believed I had proven enough to myself that I could handle the rest alone. In hindsight, I wasn't leaving because I had become strong. I was leaving because my ego had quietly convinced me I no longer needed anyone. That's a dangerous place to live. I just didn't know it yet.

For a while, it looked like I had made the right decision. Life continued improving. I stayed away from alcohol. I kept working, kept paying down responsibilities, and kept believing I had everything under control. If someone had looked at my life from the outside, they probably would have said, "See? He didn't need the coaching group after all." Honestly, I probably would have agreed with them.

That's the dangerous thing about slow drift. It doesn't announce itself. It whispers. I didn't wake up one morning and decide to stop growing. I didn't consciously choose to become complacent. I just became a little less intentional.

One ordinary day at a time.

The daily conversations became less frequent. The accountability disappeared. The uncomfortable questions disappeared. The challenge slowly disappeared. At first, nothing looked different. Then life reminded me of something I had forgotten: growth is much easier to begin than it is to sustain. Those are two completely different skills. Starting requires courage. Sustaining requires humility. I had plenty of courage. Humility I was still learning.

Only later could I see exactly what had happened. I confused progress with transformation. Because life had improved, I assumed I had changed. Those aren't the same thing. Improvement can happen because your circumstances change. Transformation happens because you change. I was improving, but I hadn't finished transforming. The old man was still there. Quieter. Less obvious. But still there. Waiting.

One thing I now understand about discipline is this: discipline doesn't disappear. It gets replaced. If you stop intentionally building good habits, unhealthy ones quietly begin filling the empty space. Nature hates a vacuum. So does character. Without realizing it, I slowly relaxed the very disciplines that had helped me begin rebuilding my life. I wasn't drinking, but I also wasn't growing. Those aren't the same thing either. Growth requires intention, every day — not out of fear of slipping, but because becoming never stops. I didn't understand that yet.

At the time, I honestly thought I had arrived. Not completely, just enough that I stopped feeling the urgency I had once felt. Life has a remarkable way of exposing that kind of thinking. It doesn't usually happen immediately. It waits. Then it tests the very areas where you've quietly become comfortable. That's exactly what happened to me.

The world changed, almost overnight. The pandemic arrived. Hospitals closed their doors. Travel stopped. Face-to-face meetings disappeared. Medical sales no longer looked anything like medical sales. The relationships that had energized me for so many years suddenly became emails, phone calls, and virtual meetings. The part of my career I loved most wasn't selling products; it was sitting across the table from another human being. Listening. Learning. Helping solve problems. Now I found myself sitting alone behind a computer screen.

Every day looked almost identical. Wake up. Open the laptop. Answer emails. Make phone calls. Document everything. Close the laptop. Repeat. The work wasn't necessarily harder. It just wasn't fulfilling. I was technically busy all day, yet I felt disconnected from the part of my career that had always given me energy.

As if that wasn't enough, life added another unexpected challenge. Within days of each other, I underwent reconstructive wrist surgery followed by hip surgery. Almost overnight, the physical outlets that had always helped me manage stress disappeared. I couldn't lift. I couldn't train. I couldn't run. The very things that had helped quiet my mind were temporarily taken away.

Today I understand something important about that season. The pandemic didn't create my weaknesses. The surgeries didn't create my weaknesses. Just like the restaurant, they exposed them.

The boredom became familiar. The isolation became familiar. Old habits started whispering again, not because they were good, but because they were familiar. That's what unhealthy habits do. They don't usually return when life is easy. They wait until you're tired, until you're isolated, until the structure that once protected you quietly disappears.

At first, it wasn't alcohol. It was comfort. Comfort in small decisions. Comfort in telling myself, "I'll get back to it tomorrow." One skipped workout became another. One unhealthy meal became another. One excuse quietly invited the next. The frightening part wasn't that I was slipping. It was that I almost didn't notice.

That's how almost every decline begins. Not with one terrible decision. With a hundred small ones. The same way growth compounds, so does complacency. Little compromises eventually become new standards. Before long, what once would have bothered you becomes normal.

I don't think I was intentionally quitting. I was drifting. There's a huge difference. Nobody drifts toward becoming healthier. Nobody drifts toward a stronger marriage. Nobody drifts toward deeper faith. We drift toward comfort, toward convenience, toward whatever requires the least amount of intentionality. That's exactly where I found myself. The old excuses I thought I had defeated weren't dead. They had merely been waiting. Waiting for isolation. Waiting for fatigue. Waiting for me to believe I no longer needed the disciplines that had started changing my life.

That truth humbled me. It also taught me one of the most valuable lessons I've ever learned: growth isn't something you achieve. It's something you protect. Every day. Not out of fear of failing, but because life never stops testing your foundation.

The pandemic exposed mine. It showed me that I had improved, but that there were still parts of me that hadn't fully transformed. At first, that discovery discouraged me. Today I'm grateful for it. Because if those weaknesses hadn't been exposed then, they would have remained hidden, and hidden weaknesses have a way of becoming much bigger problems later.

One of the greatest gifts that difficult season gave me was honesty. It forced me to admit I wasn't as strong as I thought I was. It wasn't that I lacked potential; it was that I had quietly stopped doing the small things that made me strong in the first place.

That season reminded me of something I had watched my father and grandfather do my entire life. The work doesn't stop just because life becomes inconvenient. The cattle still need feeding. The fences still need repairing. The windmills still break. The work remains, every single day. No excuses. Watching those men growing up, I thought they were nothing more than hardworking farmers and ranchers. Now I can see they were living something much deeper.

Consistency.

They weren't motivated every day. They were committed. There's a difference. Motivation comes and goes. Commitment stays. That understanding became one of the greatest gifts my father ever gave me — not through a speech, but through an example. For years I had admired his work ethic. Now I finally understood it.

The older I get, the more convinced I become that consistency is one of the greatest demonstrations of love. Showing up. Again. And again. And again. That's what my father did. That's what my grandfather did. Somewhere along the way, I had drifted from that example.

The pandemic didn't only expose my weaknesses. It reminded me where I came from. It reminded me who I wanted to become. I knew I had two choices. I could continue drifting, or I could intentionally begin rebuilding again. This time I wasn't after another breakthrough; I wanted a foundation that could withstand whatever life brought next.

By the spring of 2021, I knew something had to change. Again. At first, that truth frustrated me. Part of me thought, "I already learned these lessons." I had. The problem wasn't the lessons. It was that I had stopped living them. That was a difficult truth to accept. Nobody had pulled me off course. I had just stopped steering. One ordinary decision at a time.

This time, I approached things differently. I wasn't looking for another emotional breakthrough. I wasn't looking for another motivational speech. I wasn't looking for another coach to rescue me. I was looking for consistency. Plain consistency. The kind that doesn't attract attention. The kind that quietly changes everything.

I began rebuilding the same way I had the first time. One decision. Then another. Then another. No grand announcement. No dramatic social media post. Just work, every day.

Slowly, momentum returned. I started training again, and my body began responding. More importantly, my mind began responding. The fog that had settled over me during the pandemic slowly began lifting. Hope returned. It wasn't that life had suddenly become easy; I was moving again. Movement creates hope. Standing still rarely does.

One goal found its way onto my calendar: another triathlon. I didn't need another medal. I needed another mountain. Training gave my days purpose again. It gave me structure. It gave me something to prepare for instead of merely reacting to whatever happened next.

I realize now that the race itself was never the point. The training was. Every workout became another promise kept. Every early morning became another vote for the man I wanted to become. The race gave those routine days a direction, nothing more.

When race day finally arrived in the fall of 2021, I crossed the finish line with a medal around my neck. People saw the finish. I saw something completely different. I saw hundreds of uneventful mornings. Hundreds of ordinary decisions. Hundreds of opportunities where I could have chosen comfort, and didn't. That's what I was most proud of. Not the race. The consistency.

Crossing that finish line reminded me of something I had forgotten: I was capable of far more than I had recently believed. Not because I had become extraordinary, but because I had become intentional again. That distinction matters. The race wasn't changing me. It was revealing me. It showed me that the discipline was still there. It had only been buried beneath comfort and complacency.

The question became: how do I keep this momentum? Not for another race. For life.

That question stayed with me for months. I thought about it while driving, while working, while training. I knew I needed something that couldn't be negotiated. Not another goal, because goals eventually end. I needed something that became part of my identity. I didn't know exactly what that looked like yet. I only knew I was tired of rebuilding the same life over and over again. I wanted to build something that would last. I wanted to become the kind of man who no longer negotiated with himself.

Now I believe God had already been preparing the answer. I just hadn't reached the day yet.

That day arrived on an average Monday. October 17, 2022. At first glance, there was nothing remarkable about it. It looked like every other Monday. Only later did I understand that it became one of the most important days of my life.

That morning, I laced up my shoes and went for a run. There was nothing extraordinary about the run itself. I had run thousands of miles before. I had completed marathons. I had completed an Ironman. I had trained for triathlons. Running wasn't new. The commitment was.

When I finished that run, a simple thought entered my mind. Tomorrow...I'm going to run again.

The next morning, I did. Then the next. Then the next. No announcement. No challenge. No social media post. No audience. Just a promise. A promise to myself.

I understand now that I wasn't creating a goal. I was creating a standard. Goals eventually end. Standards become part of your identity. At the time, I didn't know how many days I would run. I never said thirty. I never said one hundred. I never said one year. I decided one thing: I wasn't going to miss. That small decision quietly changed everything. Every morning I had one question to answer. Will I keep my word today? The run was never the point. Integrity was.

Around that same time, I grabbed three Post-it notes and stuck them to my bathroom mirror. Nothing fancy. Nothing motivational. Just three reminders I desperately needed to see every single day.

Who do I have to become?

Right Now.

Your integrity is more important than what you sell.

Those three notes became my daily conversation. Some mornings they encouraged me. Other mornings they exposed me. Every morning they reminded me that becoming wasn't about another finish line. It was about another regular day.

The first question eventually became the foundation of everything that followed. Who do I have to become? Not "How do I make more money?" Not "How do I lose weight?" Not "How do I fix my marriage?" Those are outcome questions. This became an identity question. Who do I have to become to build a stronger marriage? Who do I have to become to earn trust? Who do I have to become to become the father my daughters deserve? Who do I have to become to become the man God created me to be? Every meaningful change in my life eventually pointed back to that single question.

The second note said only two words. Right Now. No excuses. No tomorrow. No Monday. No waiting until life settled down. Right now. If a difficult conversation needed to happen, right now. If an apology needed to be made, right now. If something important needed my attention, right now. Procrastination had already stolen enough years from my life. I wasn't giving it another day.

The third note became deeply personal. Your integrity is more important than what you sell. At first, I wrote it because of my career. Eventually it dawned on me that it had almost nothing to do with sales. Integrity matters when nobody else is watching. Integrity matters when nobody would know if you skipped the run. Integrity matters because you know. That became enough.

As the days turned into weeks, something remarkable happened. I stopped asking myself whether I felt like running. I simply ran. Feelings became less important. Commitment became more important. Little by little, the excuses became quieter. They hadn't disappeared; my discipline had finally become louder.

I don't think the running streak changed my life because of the miles. It changed my life because every single morning I reminded myself of one simple truth.

I am the kind of man who keeps his word.

That identity became stronger than any excuse I could create. And once that happened, everything else slowly began changing with it. I had no idea where those quiet morning runs would eventually lead. I only knew one thing. For the first time in a very long time, I wasn't running from my life anymore.

I was finally running toward it.

Chapter 4 ## Becoming

People often ask me which day was the hardest. Day 7? Day 30? Day 100? Day 365? The truth surprises them: none of those days. The hardest day was Day 1. It wasn't the run itself that made it hard. Day 1 was hard because Day 1 required a decision. Every day after that only required keeping it. There's a huge difference between the two.

People spend a lot of time chasing motivation. I did too. I kept waiting to feel inspired, and I kept believing that if I could just find enough motivation, consistency would naturally follow. It never did. Motivation is emotional. Discipline is a decision. Motivation comes and goes; discipline quietly stays. Running every day taught me that lesson better than anything else ever had.

There were mornings when I couldn't wait to get outside, and there were other mornings when I stared at my shoes hoping I'd think of a good excuse. Cold mornings. Windy mornings. Rain, travel, long workdays, family vacations, sickness, busy schedules. Life never stopped happening, and the decision remained the same: run today.

From where I stand today, I don't think I was building a running streak at all. I was rebuilding trust. Not other people's trust. My own.

For most of my adult life I had made promises to myself that I never kept. I'll start Monday. I'll quit next month. I'll get back in shape. I'll drink less. I'll spend more time with my family. Every promise felt sincere when I made it, and every broken promise quietly taught me something: "You don't really follow through." I never said those words out loud. I didn't have to. My actions had already taught them to me.

Running interrupted that story. Every morning I finished another run, I quietly gathered another piece of evidence — evidence that I could keep my word, evidence that I could finish what I started, evidence that I wasn't the same man who had stood in front of the mirror believing he couldn't change. That's why I tell people the streak isn't what matters. Integrity matters. The streak just became visible evidence of an invisible transformation. One promise. Kept. Then another. Then another.

Eventually, something remarkable happened. I stopped wondering whether I was going to run, because I already knew the answer. The negotiation disappeared. That may be one of the greatest gifts discipline has ever given me: it removes unnecessary negotiations. Once you've decided who you're becoming, many decisions have already been made for you. I no longer asked, "Am I going to run today?" The only question left was, "When?"

That same principle slowly spilled into every other area of my life — marriage, parenting, health, work, faith. The more promises I kept, the more I trusted myself. The more I trusted myself, the less I depended on motivation. In hindsight, I can see that confidence wasn't something I found. It was something I built. One ordinary morning at a time. One quiet run at a time. One small promise at a time.

Most people see extraordinary lives. Very few people ever see the unremarkable days that quietly built them. That's where becoming actually happens. Not on race day. Not at the finish line. Not when everyone is watching. It happens early in the morning when no one would ever know if you chose the easier path. That's where character is built. That's where identity changes. That's where excuses quietly lose their voice.

But I don't want to give the impression that one decision smoothed the road ahead, because it didn't. One of the biggest misconceptions people have about growth is that once you make the decision to change, everything gets easier. That wasn't my experience. The decision is only the beginning. The real work starts the next morning. And the morning after that. And the one after that. The beautiful thing about momentum is that it compounds. So does complacency. The direction depends entirely on what you choose to repeat.

By the time my running streak had reached several months, people began asking questions. "How do you keep going every day?" "Don't you ever take a day off?" "What happens if you're traveling?" "What if you're tired?" Those questions made me smile, because they revealed something I hadn't even noticed. People thought the difficult part was the running. It wasn't. The difficult part had been making the decision that running was no longer negotiable. Once that decision was made, running became what I did. There's a huge difference between making a decision every day and living according to one you've already made. That's what standards began teaching me.

For a long stretch, my life had been controlled by negotiation. "I'll start Monday." "I'll skip today." "I deserve a break." "One day won't matter." Every excuse sounded reasonable in the instant I made it, and reasonable excuses still produce the same results. Eventually the truth landed. Every negotiation weakened my integrity. Every promise I broke taught me not to trust myself. Every promise I kept taught me the opposite. That's why I say I wasn't building a running streak. I was rebuilding self-trust.

People often ask me if I was trying to become a runner. Not really. I was trying to become a man who kept his word. Running just happened to become the vehicle. One small promise, repeated every day. That's all it was.

One morning during a run I caught myself smiling. It wasn't that the run felt easy — it didn't. I smiled because I noticed I hadn't argued with myself before leaving the house. There was no debate. No internal negotiation. No "Should I?" I had already answered that question months earlier. That's freedom. Not the kind that comes from discipline removing difficulty, because it doesn't. The kind that comes from discipline removing unnecessary decisions.

The more I thought about it, the more I saw that almost every successful person I admired had something in common. They weren't making fewer difficult decisions. They were making fewer unnecessary ones. They had already decided who they wanted to become, and everything else aligned with that identity.

Seeing that changed the way I looked at every area of my life. I stopped asking, "What do I feel like doing today?" and started asking, "What would the man I'm becoming do today?" Those are two completely different questions. One is driven by emotion. The other is driven by identity. And identity almost always wins. If I believe I'm someone who keeps promises, I naturally keep looking for promises to keep. If I believe I'm someone who quits when life gets hard, my actions eventually prove me right. Identity quietly shapes behavior. Behavior quietly shapes your life.

That's why I became so fascinated by one simple question: Who do I have to become? It didn't magically solve my problems. What it did was change where I looked for the answers. Year after year I had searched for better strategies, better plans, better motivation. The better answer was becoming a better man. Everything else began growing from there.

The remarkable thing is that nobody else noticed this transformation at first. There wasn't some dramatic announcement. No celebration. No applause. Just another regular morning. Then another. Then another. Transformation almost always happens quietly, long before anyone else notices. That's okay. Some of the most important work you'll ever do happens where no one else is watching.

The longer the streak continued, the more I understood something else: people were paying attention. Not because of me. Because consistency stands out in a world full of starts and stops. Friends would occasionally ask, "How many days are you at now?" Others would say, "I saw you were running in the snow," or, "Didn't you just get back from a trip?" The truth was, none of those days felt particularly extraordinary while I was living them. They were just Tuesday. Wednesday. Saturday. Uneventful days.

That's one of the greatest lessons running has ever taught me: extraordinary lives are almost always built through ordinary days. People celebrate the milestone. Very few people celebrate the hundreds of mornings that made the milestone possible. I began thinking about that during my runs. Why do we admire the finish line so much while overlooking the thousands of small

decisions that made it possible? The answer, I think, is that unremarkable work isn't exciting. It's repetitive. Quiet. Unnoticed. But that's exactly where character is built.

One morning another thought came to me: the race isn't preparing you for race day. The race is preparing you for life. That sentence stayed with me, because I could see it was true. Running every day wasn't teaching me how to become a better runner. It was teaching me how to become a better husband, a better father, a better employee, a better friend, a better leader. Every difficult run became another opportunity to practice keeping my word when I didn't feel like it.

That lesson carried into every other part of my life. Marriage doesn't always feel easy. Parenting doesn't always feel easy. Business certainly doesn't always feel easy. Neither does faith. Neither does becoming. There are days when you just don't feel like doing the work, and those are the days that matter most. Anyone can stay committed when everything feels good. Character is revealed when it doesn't. That truth removed another excuse from my life. I stopped waiting to feel inspired. I stopped waiting to feel motivated. I kept showing up. Again. And again.

Eventually, another opportunity presented itself. Someone asked if I wanted to run an ultramarathon. Sixty-two miles. One hundred kilometers. My first thought wasn't, "Can I do it?" My first thought was, "Who do I have to become to finish it?" That question had quietly become the filter for every major decision in my life. Not "Can I?" but "Who do I need to become?" Those are very different questions. One focuses on ability. The other focuses on identity. Identity changes everything.

Training for that race wasn't really about sixty-two miles. It was about becoming the kind of man who could prepare for sixty-two miles. The race was months away, but the man I needed to become started changing that very day. The workouts changed. The nutrition changed. The sleep changed. The priorities changed. None of it happened because race day had arrived. It happened because identity had. Goals have a remarkable way of changing tomorrow. Identity changes today. That distinction has stayed with me ever since. One of the greatest mistakes I made earlier in life was chasing accomplishments. Now I chase becoming. Accomplishments eventually end. Becoming never does.

The ultramarathon wasn't another finish line. It became another classroom — another opportunity to learn, another opportunity to discover where my limits actually were. More importantly, it became another opportunity to discover that many of the limits I believed in weren't physical at all. They were stories. Stories I had believed for most of my life. Stories that sounded remarkably similar to the ones I first heard as a little boy. "You're not enough." "You can't do this." "You should quit." The amazing thing about discipline is that it slowly begins answering those stories without saying a word. Every promise kept becomes another piece of

evidence. Every ordinary day becomes another vote. Eventually, the evidence becomes louder than the lies. And when that happens, you don't just accomplish difficult things.

You become someone different.

That's what I had been searching for all along.

One morning, during a run, I found myself thinking about the little boy who believed he wasn't enough. It wasn't planned; the thought just appeared. Maybe that's one of the greatest gifts running has given me. When the distractions disappear, the truth has room to speak. As the miles passed, something hit me that stopped me in my tracks. That little boy wasn't weak. He never was. He survived things no child should ever have to survive. He endured years of abuse. He carried lies that weren't his. He learned how to smile while hurting. He learned how to survive.

For a long time, I looked back at that little boy with sadness. Now I look at him with compassion. Even gratitude. Because if he hadn't refused to quit, the man writing these words wouldn't exist.

That understanding changed the way I viewed my entire life. I stopped seeing myself as someone who had been broken and started seeing myself as someone God had been preparing. Those are two completely different perspectives. Preparation often feels like punishment while you're living through it. Only later do you recognize the purpose. That doesn't mean I would ever choose those experiences again. I wouldn't. It just means I no longer believe God wasted them. Nothing was wasted. Not the abuse. Not the restaurant. Not the lawsuits. Not the depression. Not the alcohol. Not the rocking chair. Every painful chapter became preparation for another one.

The older I get, the more convinced I become that God rarely wastes pain. He redeems it. Sometimes not immediately. Sometimes years later. Sometimes through helping another person who's walking through something remarkably similar. That truth slowly changed the reason I shared my story. At first, I talked about it because I was trying to understand it. Now I talk about it because someone else might need hope. Maybe that's the purpose of healing. Not merely feeling better, but helping someone else believe they can too.

Around this same time, another understanding quietly settled into my heart. I wasn't chasing happiness anymore. I was creating it. For years I had believed happiness waited somewhere in the future. After the next promotion. After the next race. After the next business opportunity. After life finally settled down. I couldn't have been more wrong. Happiness isn't something we discover. It's something we build. One ordinary day at a time. One promise at a time. One conversation at a time. One decision at a time.

Everything compounds. Excuses compound. Discipline compounds. Kindness compounds. Truth compounds. Hope compounds. The question is, what are you compounding today?

That thought stayed with me for weeks, because I could see that I had spent years compounding excuses. Now I wanted to compound integrity. I wanted plain days that quietly pointed me toward the man I believed God had created me to become. Not because I thought I'd ever arrive — becoming never ends. There's always another lesson. Another opportunity. Another promise. Another chance to grow. Understanding that removed an enormous amount of pressure from my life. I stopped trying to arrive. I kept becoming.

The funny thing is, once I stopped chasing a destination, I started enjoying the road itself. I smiled more. Laughed more. Spent more time truly present with my family. I wasn't thinking about tomorrow nearly as much anymore. Today deserved my attention. My daughters deserved my attention. My wife deserved my attention. Life deserved my attention. For longer than I'd like to admit, I had been physically present while mentally somewhere else. Now I was finally beginning to live where my feet actually were. That may sound simple. It isn't. Presence is one of the greatest gifts you can ever give another human being. I learned that the hard way, through all the seasons when I wasn't giving it.

Running taught me many things. Discipline. Consistency. Self-trust. But maybe the greatest lesson it taught me was this.

Life isn't won in extraordinary moments. It's won in ordinary ones.

One sunrise. One difficult conversation. One workout. One apology. One promise. One day. Repeated often enough, those ordinary days quietly become an extraordinary life.

I didn't know it then, but those everyday runs were laying the foundation for something much bigger than I could imagine. Not another race. A framework. A way of living. A question that would eventually organize every area of my life. Not, "What do I want?" But, "Who do I have to become?" That question would eventually lead me to four simple pillars that transformed the way I looked at health, learning, relationships, and stewardship. They weren't created overnight. They were discovered.

One ordinary day at a time.

Chapter 5 ## Who Do I Have to Become?

There are certain questions that quietly change the direction of your life. It isn't that they're complicated. It's that they're honest.

For most of my life, I asked the same questions everyone else asks. How do I make more money? How do I lose weight? How do I grow my business? How do I save my marriage? How do I become successful? None of those are bad questions, and I've asked every one of them. The problem wasn't the questions themselves. The problem was where they began. Every one of them started with how.

Year after year I chased better strategies, better systems, better routines, better plans. I honestly believed that if I could just discover the right method, my life would eventually fall into place. It never did.

The running streak quietly exposed why. Every morning I laced up my shoes, I wasn't getting healthier because I had found a better training plan. I was getting healthier because I had become someone who kept promises. Identity came first. Everything else followed. That truth changed the way I looked at every area of my life.

One morning, standing in front of my bathroom mirror, I caught myself staring at the same three Post-it notes I had looked at every day for months. Suddenly, one question seemed to stand above all the others.

Who do I have to become?

I stood there for a long time thinking about those six words. The more I sat with them, the more I understood they were completely different from every goal I had ever written down. Goals ask what you want. This question asked who you must become before those things naturally follow. That completely changed the direction of my thinking.

Instead of asking, "How do I build a better marriage?" I asked, "Who does my wife deserve?" Instead of asking, "How do I become healthier?" I asked, "Who naturally lives the life I'm trying to build?" Instead of asking, "How do I become successful?" I asked, "Who creates enough value that success eventually becomes the byproduct?"

Those are very different questions. One chases outcomes. The other transforms identity.

The more I lived with that question, the more something else became clear: the answer never stayed the same. The man I needed to become to quit drinking wasn't the same man I needed to

become to complete an ultramarathon. The man I needed to become to earn trust wasn't the same man I needed to become to keep trust. The man I needed to become at forty wasn't the same man I needed to become at forty-five. Growth changes the answer, and that's exactly how it should be, because becoming never ends. Every season asks something different from us.

That's one of the reasons that Post-it note has never come off my mirror. The question is still alive. Every morning it asks me the same thing: Who are you becoming today? Not next year. Not after another promotion. Not after another race. Today.

That one question quietly eliminated hundreds of smaller ones, because once I knew who I wanted to become, many of my daily decisions became much easier. Would the man I'm becoming have another drink? No. Would the man I'm becoming skip another promise? No. Would the man I'm becoming avoid that difficult conversation? No.

Identity began answering questions before discipline ever had to. That's when something remarkable sank in: the strongest discipline usually grows out of a clear identity, not the other way around.

The mirror eventually became much more than a place where I brushed my teeth each morning. It became a conversation — not with my reflection, but with myself. Every morning those three handwritten notes quietly asked me the same question. Who are you becoming? Not, what are you accomplishing? Not, how much money are you making? Not, how many miles have you run?

Who are you becoming?

The longer I lived with that question, the clearer one thing became. Results never lie. I could tell myself I valued my health; my habits answered honestly. I could tell myself I valued my marriage; my presence answered honestly. I could tell myself I valued integrity; my daily choices answered honestly. Results don't judge us. They reveal us, nothing more. Oddly enough, I found that freeing, because once the truth is exposed, you finally know where to begin.

For a long stretch of my life I had spent enormous amounts of energy trying to change outcomes. Lose weight. Make more money. Build a better business. Become more successful. The problem wasn't the goals. The problem was that I kept trying to change the fruit without ever examining the roots. Healthy roots naturally produce healthy fruit, and the same is true in life. If I became healthier, better habits would naturally follow. If I became more disciplined, consistency would naturally follow. If I became a better husband, my marriage would naturally grow stronger. Everything kept pointing back to identity.

That understanding followed me everywhere — during sales calls, during workouts, while traveling, even while sitting in airports. I found myself asking, "Who does this situation require me to become?" Sometimes the answer was patience. Sometimes courage. Sometimes humility. Sometimes discipline. Sometimes it was nothing more than listening instead of talking. The answer changed. The question never did.

One morning another thought found its way onto my bathroom mirror.

You versus you.

At first, those three words didn't seem particularly profound, but the longer I looked at them, the more freedom they created. For as long as I could remember, I had quietly compared myself to everyone else. Other sales representatives. Other runners. Other fathers. Other husbands. Other people on social media who always seemed to have life figured out. Comparison became exhausting, because no matter how much progress I made, someone always appeared farther ahead.

Eventually the truth landed. I wasn't competing against anyone else. I was competing against yesterday's version of myself. That was the only comparison that actually mattered. Could I become a little more patient today? Could I become a little more disciplined today? Could I become a little more present today? Those became races worth running, because those races never required someone else to lose for me to win.

Another Post-it eventually appeared.

Always grateful. Never satisfied.

At first glance, those ideas seem to contradict one another. They don't. Gratitude reminds me to appreciate where I am. Never being satisfied reminds me that growth never stops. I can be deeply thankful for today while still believing God isn't finished with me tomorrow. Both can exist at the same time. One keeps me humble. The other keeps me moving.

Over time, another thought found its place on the mirror: You are the CEO of your life. Hire. Fire. Promote. Accordingly. The first time I wrote it, I laughed. Then I thought about it. Every habit is an employee. Every relationship has influence. Every repeated thought eventually produces behavior. Some habits deserve promotion; others need to be fired. Some relationships deserve greater access; others require healthy boundaries. Some thoughts deserve to be believed; others should never have been hired in the first place.

The more time I spent standing in front of that mirror, the more I understood those notes weren't motivational. They were diagnostic. Every morning they exposed where my life wasn't matching

the man I claimed I wanted to become. That isn't always comfortable — growth rarely is. But honesty has a remarkable way of simplifying life, because once you stop lying to yourself, you finally know where the work belongs.

One quote challenged me more than almost anything else during that season. It wasn't a quote I immediately liked. In fact, the first time I heard it, I wanted to argue with it. It said, plainly, "The truth only offends those who live outside of it."

That sentence stayed with me — not because it made me feel good, but because it exposed me. For most of my adult life I had surrounded myself with ideas that protected my comfort. Now I was intentionally surrounding myself with ideas that challenged it. Those are two very different ways to live. Comfort rarely transforms us. Truth does.

The more honest I became with myself, the less interested I became in collecting information. I became much more interested in applying it. For years I believed another book would change my life. Then I believed it would be another coach. Another seminar. Another podcast. Another breakthrough. Eventually something became obvious: information had never been my problem. Application was.

I already knew I should exercise. I already knew alcohol wasn't helping me. I already knew my marriage deserved more of me. I already knew excuses were costing me years. Knowledge wasn't missing. Execution was. That truth humbled me. I had spent so much of my life collecting ideas that never became habits.

In hindsight, I think that's where many people become frustrated. They confuse learning with changing, and they're not the same thing. Knowledge informs. Application transforms. The world is full of informed people; transformation belongs to the people willing to live what they've learned. One page applied is worth more than an entire bookshelf ignored. One difficult conversation is worth more than another motivational speech. One promise consistently kept is worth more than another notebook full of goals.

That understanding completely changed the way I approached growth. I stopped asking, "What else do I need to know?" Instead, I started asking, "What do I already know that I'm not living?" That question exposed me — and it wasn't a lack of information it revealed. It was a lack of consistency. The answer wasn't another lesson. The answer was another normal day lived with intention.

Little by little, I stopped chasing dramatic breakthroughs and started honoring plain repetition. The same habits. The same disciplines. The same commitments. Again. And again. And again.

Most people underestimate repetition because repetition isn't exciting. But repetition quietly creates mastery. The basics, repeated consistently, eventually become extraordinary.

I think about my father often when I consider that idea. Every day he woke up and handled the basics. The cattle. The fences. The equipment. The land. Nothing glamorous. Nothing flashy. Just the work that mattered. Life works exactly the same way. The basics never stopped working. We just stopped valuing them.

That's when I began understanding something that would eventually organize every area of my life. I wasn't trying to become healthier, or wealthier, or more successful. I was trying to become more intentional. Because intentional people don't merely react to life. They prepare for it.

That thought quietly became the bridge to everything that followed. For so long I had been reacting. Now I wanted to begin living proactively — not because I had life figured out, but because I was finally becoming the kind of man who understood that ordinary preparation changes extraordinary moments. I just didn't know how to organize that way of thinking yet. That answer would come one everyday run, one small thought, and one simple framework that eventually became the foundation for everything else.

One morning during a run, a simple picture came into my mind. A table. Nothing elaborate — just a table with four legs. If one leg weakens, the table doesn't immediately collapse. It begins to wobble.

The longer I thought about it, the more I saw that's exactly what had happened in my own life. For as long as I could remember, I had treated every area of my life as though it existed independently. If my health suffered, that was one problem. If my marriage struggled, that was another. If my finances became stressful, that was something completely separate. The truth was much different. Everything was connected. When my energy declined, my patience declined. When my patience declined, my relationships suffered. When my relationships suffered, my mindset followed. When my mindset suffered, everything else eventually felt the effects.

For too long I had been trying to repair individual problems while ignoring the foundation holding everything together. No wonder life always seemed out of balance.

The more I thought about that table, the more obvious it became. I didn't need another complicated system. I needed something simple enough to remember every day. Something practical. Something honest. Something I could return to regardless of what life looked like.

I filled notebook after notebook during that season — pages of ideas, thoughts from morning runs, lessons from books, questions I kept asking myself. As I read back through those pages, I noticed something. Almost everything I had written fit into one of four areas. My body. My

mind. My relationships. My stewardship. The categories were different, but the purpose was the same. Each one represented an area where I needed to become more intentional.

Little by little, those four areas became clearer. I wasn't trying to invent another self-improvement program; I was trying to simplify my own life. Whenever life felt overwhelming, I needed a place to return. Not another motivational speech. Not another complicated plan. Just the fundamentals — the same way my father approached the ranch. Every day he returned to the basics. The fences. The cattle. The equipment. The land. Nothing glamorous. Just faithful stewardship of what had already been entrusted to him.

That picture stayed with me. Maybe life wasn't asking me to become more complicated. Maybe it was inviting me back to the fundamentals.

That understanding brought an incredible sense of peace. For the first time in years, I wasn't asking, "How do I fix my life?" I was asking, "Which part of my foundation needs attention today?" That question felt manageable. Honest. Actionable. Instead of trying to rebuild everything at once, I could strengthen one leg of the table. Then another. Then another. Little by little, the wobble disappeared — not because life became easier, but because the foundation became stronger.

I didn't know it yet, but those four simple areas would eventually become the framework I now call E4. Creating a brand had nothing to do with it. I was trying to build a life that wouldn't collapse every time another storm arrived. The more I lived it, the more convinced I became of one simple truth. Strong lives are rarely built on extraordinary ideas. They're built on ordinary fundamentals, lived consistently.

That's where I finally stopped reacting to life and began preparing for it.

The framework didn't appear all at once. It wasn't something I sat down and designed in a single afternoon. It emerged through years of failure, years of rebuilding, and years of asking one question over and over again.

Who do I have to become?

The answer kept changing. The categories didn't. No matter what season I was in, every challenge seemed to point back to one of four areas. If my body was neglected, everything else became more difficult. If my mind wasn't growing, my decisions suffered. If my relationships weakened, success felt empty. If I wasn't faithfully managing what God had entrusted to me, peace disappeared. Everything was connected.

That truth simplified my life in a way I never expected. Instead of trying to fix everything at once, I could just ask, which pillar needs my attention today? Some days the answer was my health. Some days it was my attitude. Some days it was spending uninterrupted time with my wife or my daughters. Some days it was making a phone call I had been avoiding or taking responsibility for a financial decision. The answer changed. The process stayed the same. Tell yourself the truth. Take the next step. Keep your promise. Repeat tomorrow.

The older I get, the less interested I become in complicated systems. Complicated systems usually impress people. Simple systems change people. I wanted something my daughters could understand. Something a high school student could use. Something a young couple could build their marriage around. Something a business owner could apply on Monday morning. Something I could still be living twenty years from now. That's what this framework became. Not another program. A way of living.

From where I stand today, I can see how each pillar quietly rescued another part of my life. Taking care of my body gave me the energy to become present again. Sharpening my mind changed the way I responded to problems. Strengthening relationships reminded me that success means very little if you arrive alone. Learning to steward my time, money, opportunities, and influence brought a kind of freedom I had spent years chasing in all the wrong places.

None of those pillars stood alone. Each one supported the others, just like the legs of a table. Remove one, and everything becomes unstable. Strengthen all four, and life becomes remarkably resilient.

I wish someone had handed me that framework when I was twenty years old. It wouldn't have prevented every mistake. It wouldn't have removed every hardship. But I believe it would have helped me respond to those hardships very differently. Then again, maybe I had to live through everything first. Maybe the restaurant, the lawsuits, the depression, the rocking chair, the hotel room, the pandemic, the routine morning runs — maybe all of those seasons were preparing me to understand something I couldn't have appreciated any other way.

Today, I don't see E4 as four categories. I see it as stewardship. Stewardship of the body God gave me. Stewardship of the mind He's continuing to shape. Stewardship of the people He's placed in my life. Stewardship of every opportunity He's entrusted to me.

When I finally began looking at life through that lens, everything changed. Not overnight. Not dramatically. One small decision, one quiet promise, one ordinary day.

At a time.

Those four pillars would eventually become the foundation for the rest of this book — not because I believe they're the only framework that works, but because they're the framework that rebuilt my life. And before we explore each pillar individually, there's one more distinction that completely changed the way I think. For so long I had lived reactively. The future I wanted required something entirely different. It required learning how to live proactively.

CHAPTER 6

Reactive vs. Proactive

One of the most expensive habits I've ever had wasn't financial. It was reactive living. Through most of my adult life, that's exactly how I operated. I reacted to problems. I reacted to stress. I reacted to conflict. I reacted to financial pressure. I reacted to disappointment. I reacted to emergencies. And every single time I reacted, I paid interest.

At the time, I didn't know I was doing it. I thought I was adapting. I thought I was handling whatever life threw at me. Today, I see it very differently. I was constantly paying interest on problems that could have been addressed months—or even years—earlier. That sentence has stayed with me because it explains so much of my life.

Ignore your health long enough, and eventually you pay interest. Ignore your marriage long enough, and eventually you pay interest. Ignore your finances long enough, and eventually you pay interest. Ignore your mindset long enough, and eventually you pay interest. Life always collects. The bill always comes due. The only question is whether you'll pay now or pay much more later. For a long stretch of my life, I chose later.

Later always cost more.

When I look back over my own story, I can see it clearly. The restaurant didn't fail overnight. My drinking didn't become destructive overnight. My health didn't decline overnight. My marriage didn't become strained overnight. Everything compounded. One decision. One excuse. One ordinary day at a time.

The encouraging part is that the opposite is also true. Truth compounds. Discipline compounds. Kindness compounds. Integrity compounds. One small promise kept today makes tomorrow's promise a little easier to keep. That's exactly what I had experienced through running. Nothing dramatic happened on Day 14, or Day 37, or Day 83, but every day quietly built on the one before it. Eventually, the ordinary became extraordinary. That's how life works, whether we're moving toward the life we want or away from it.

The problem isn't reacting once in a while; life demands that from all of us. The problem is when reacting becomes your lifestyle. That's where I lived far too long—always trying to catch up, always solving yesterday's problems, always putting out another fire. I wasn't preparing. I was surviving. And preparation never feels urgent until you need it.

That's one of the greatest lessons my father taught me without ever intending to. Farmers don't wait until harvest to start planting. Ranchers don't wait until the cattle are thirsty before looking for water. Fences are repaired before the cattle get out. Equipment is maintained before it breaks. Preparation is simply part of the lifestyle. Growing up, I watched that every single day. I just didn't understand how much it applied to life outside the ranch.

Somewhere along the way, I stopped living proactively and started reacting instead, and the consequences quietly compounded year after year. Then one morning, during a run, another thought crossed my mind. Don't wait for life to settle. Move within it. That sentence challenged me, because I had spent so much of my life telling myself, "Once things slow down..." "Once work gets easier..." "Once this lawsuit is over..." "Once life settles..." Then I'll start. But life never settled. There was always another responsibility, another problem, another excuse. Waiting had quietly become another form of procrastination.

Then it finally hit me: if I waited for perfect conditions, I'd spend my entire life waiting. That's when I stopped asking life to become easier and started asking myself to become stronger. That one shift changed everything. My circumstances didn't immediately improve—my response did. And our response is one of the few things we'll always have the power to control.

One of the greatest shifts in my thinking came when I stopped asking, "How do I avoid problems?" and instead started asking, "Who do I need to become before the next problem arrives?" Those two questions produce completely different lives. One waits for circumstances to improve. The other prepares regardless of circumstances.

Preparation became one of the greatest gifts running ever gave me. People often assume I'm training for races. I'm really not. I'm preparing for life. If someone called me tomorrow and asked me to run a half marathon, I'd say yes—not because I specifically trained for a half marathon, but because the foundation is already there. The same would be true for a marathon. Preparation gave me options.

Life works exactly the same way. Most people wait until the diagnosis before taking their health seriously. They wait until the marriage is struggling before learning how to communicate, until the bank account is empty before creating a budget, until life hurts enough to finally pay attention. I know, because I did exactly that.

Playing catch-up is exhausting. Preparation is peaceful.

That sentence has become one of my favorite reminders. Preparation doesn't eliminate storms; it changes how you walk through them. Storms are still coming. Disappointment is still coming. Loss is still coming. Life doesn't stop being life because you've become proactive. The difference is that you're no longer constantly surprised by difficulty. You're prepared to respond instead of merely react. That distinction changed everything for me.

One of my favorite thoughts came to me during a run: there is a miracle in the present moment. Not yesterday. Not tomorrow. Right now. That thought stayed with me because I saw how much of my life I had spent somewhere other than the present. I replayed yesterday's failures. I worried about tomorrow's problems. Meanwhile, today quietly disappeared. I missed conversations. I missed moments. I missed opportunities to just be where my feet already were.

The more intentional I became, the more I noticed something remarkable. Peace isn't waiting somewhere in the future. Peace is built by faithfully living today. That's why the Post-it note on my mirror said only two words: Right Now. Not someday. Not eventually. Right now. That little reminder quietly eliminated dozens of excuses. If a difficult conversation needed to happen—right now. If I needed to apologize—right now. If I needed to make a decision—right now. Procrastination had already stolen enough years from my life. I wasn't giving it another day.

From where I stand today, I don't see the restaurant as the end. I don't see the lawsuits as punishment. I don't see the rocking chair as my lowest point. I see all of them differently now.

Preparation.

Preparation for the husband I needed to become. Preparation for the father my daughters deserved. Preparation for the conversations I'm now able to have with people who feel hopeless. Preparation for this book. At the time, none of those seasons felt like preparation. They felt like interruptions. Today I believe something very different. Sometimes what looks like an interruption becomes the road you were meant to travel all along.

That perspective changed the way I view setbacks. Instead of asking, "Why is this happening to me?" I found myself asking, "What is this trying to teach me?" That question continues changing my life—not because I always like the answer, but because growth usually begins the instant we're willing to ask it honestly.

The more proactive I became, the clearer it became that I didn't need another complicated plan. I needed a roadmap. Not someone else's roadmap. Mine. A roadmap built around becoming instead of reacting. A roadmap I could return to every single day. One ordinary decision at a time.

The roadmap didn't appear all at once. I didn't sit down one afternoon with a whiteboard and suddenly organize my life. It happened much more naturally than that. The more I paid attention, the more I noticed patterns. Every challenge I faced seemed to expose the same areas over and over again. When my health suffered, everything else became more difficult. When my thinking became unhealthy, my decisions followed. When my relationships weakened, success felt empty. When I failed to steward my time, money, opportunities, and influence well, everything else became unstable. Life wasn't divided into separate compartments. Everything was connected.

Seeing that simplified my life in a way I never expected. I had spent so long trying to solve individual problems. Now I understood that what I actually needed was to strengthen the foundation.

The more I thought about it, the more another picture came to mind: a house. People spend a tremendous amount of money choosing countertops, paint colors, flooring, furniture, and landscaping. Very few people get excited about pouring the concrete foundation. Nobody drives past a new home and says, "Would you look at that foundation?" Nobody notices it—until something starts cracking. Then it's all anyone talks about.

Life works the same way. We admire the visible things. The promotions. The vacations. The accomplishments. The medals. The finish lines. Very few people pay attention to the foundation quietly holding everything together. That's exactly where I had spent so long neglecting the work. The restaurant wasn't really my problem. The lawsuits weren't really my problem. Alcohol wasn't really my problem. Those things exposed weaknesses in a foundation that had needed attention long before any of them showed up.

Once I understood that, I stopped looking for another shortcut and started returning to the basics. Not glamorous. Not exciting. The basics. The same basics my father had been living every day of his life. The same basics my grandfather quietly modeled. Show up. Do the work. Take care of what's been entrusted to you. Repeat tomorrow.

There's something incredibly freeing about simplicity. I had long believed I needed a more complicated answer. I didn't. I needed a more consistent one. That truth changed how I looked at almost everything. Instead of trying to fix my entire life all at once, I asked one question: "What's the next faithful step?" Not the next ten. Not the next year. The next one. Then I took it. Then another.

The remarkable thing about small decisions is that they rarely feel significant while you're making them. Nobody celebrates another healthy meal. Nobody applauds another early morning. Nobody notices another difficult conversation you chose not to avoid. Those choices rarely feel extraordinary—until enough of them accumulate. Then one day people look at your life and say,

"You're so disciplined." Or, "You're lucky." Or, "I wish I had your consistency." What they don't see are the thousands of everyday decisions that quietly built what they're now admiring.

That's why I no longer chase extraordinary days. I chase ordinary faithfulness. Because everyday faithfulness compounds, just like excuses once did. One day at a time. One promise at a time. One decision at a time.

Eventually, something else sank in. Preparation isn't really about avoiding pain. It's about becoming the kind of person who can carry it differently. That became one of the greatest shifts in my thinking. I stopped asking God to remove every difficult season. Instead, I found myself praying, "God, help me become the man this season requires." Those are very different prayers. One asks for escape. The other asks for growth. My life changed when I stopped praying for easier circumstances and started praying for stronger character.

Without realizing it, I had begun laying the foundation for everything that would follow. Not another race. Not another business. A way of living—one that would eventually organize every area of my life around four simple pillars. They weren't revolutionary. They were foundational. And foundations change everything.

One of the things I wish someone had taught me when I was twenty years old is that you don't need a perfect plan before you begin. You only need a direction. For the longest time, I kept looking for someone to hand me the blueprint. A coach. A mentor. A seminar. Another book. Another system. Another shortcut. I kept believing someone else had the missing piece.

The older I get, the more I understand that coaches, mentors, and books are incredibly valuable. I've learned life-changing lessons from every one of them. But eventually there comes a point when you have to stop collecting information and start building your own roadmap. No one else can do that part for you. People can encourage you, challenge you, correct you, even save you years of mistakes. But they can't become you. They can't make your decisions. They can't keep your promises. That's your responsibility.

Oddly enough, I found that incredibly freeing. It meant my future wasn't limited by someone else's imagination. It would be shaped by my willingness to become the man I believed God was calling me to become.

One question became incredibly helpful during that season: What do I want? Simple, but not easy. The second question became even more important: Why do I want it? Because if the "why" isn't strong enough, the "what" won't survive very long. I've watched people set incredible goals that disappeared within weeks. The goals weren't unrealistic. The reason behind them just wasn't strong enough to survive discomfort.

Eventually I added one more question: Who can help me get there? That question changed my perspective. For most of my life I had believed asking for help somehow made me weaker. I couldn't have been more wrong. It takes far more courage to admit you need guidance than it does to pretend you've got everything figured out. Pride isolates. Humility invites growth.

Every meaningful breakthrough in my life has another person's fingerprints on it. My father. My grandparents. My wife. My coaches. My mentors. Friends who loved me enough to tell me the truth. Every one of them helped shape the man I'm still becoming. Understanding that removed another excuse. I no longer had to pretend I could do everything alone. I only needed to remain teachable.

One of the greatest lies I ever believed was that strength meant independence. Today I believe something completely different. Strength means remaining humble enough to keep learning. The day I believe I've arrived, I'll probably stop growing. I hope that day never comes. The more I grow, the more I discover how much I still have to learn. That's actually become one of my favorite parts of life. Every season asks something new of me. Every season introduces another opportunity to become.

The answer isn't perfection. The answer is progress. One small step. Then another. Then another. Direction has become far more important to me than speed. I don't need to know every step five years from now. I need to know only the next faithful one. That's enough. God has never shown me my entire future. He has faithfully shown me enough for today, then enough for tomorrow, then enough for the next step.

When I trace my life backward, almost every meaningful decision happened before I felt completely ready. Opening a restaurant. Joining a coaching group. Quitting drinking. Beginning a daily running streak. Writing this book. None of those decisions came with certainty. They came with faith. Sometimes faith looks remarkably plain. Sometimes it looks like nothing more than taking the next step before you can see the entire staircase.

The more I lived that way, the less overwhelmed I became. Life became simpler. Not easier. Simpler. Tell yourself the truth. Keep today's promise. Take the next step. Repeat tomorrow.

That's how I stopped reacting to life. That's how I began preparing for it. And without realizing it, I was quietly laying the foundation for every chapter that follows.

CHAPTER 7

Energy

If there is one area of life where people consistently lie to themselves, it's their health. I know because I did it year after year. Very few people wake up one morning and decide to neglect themselves. It happens gradually. One skipped workout. One poor meal. One excuse. One ordinary day at a time. Then one day they look in the mirror and wonder, "How did I get here?"

I know exactly how that feels.

A few years before my lowest point, I had completed an Ironman triathlon: a 2.4-mile swim, a 112-mile bike ride, and then a marathon. At one point in my life, I had the discipline to finish one of the most physically demanding endurance events in the world. Then life happened. Excuses happened. Alcohol happened. Convenience happened. Before I understood what was going on, I had gained nearly fifty pounds. The athlete disappeared. The energy disappeared. The confidence disappeared. When I stood in front of the mirror, I didn't just dislike how I looked. I disliked who I was becoming.

There's an important distinction there. Energy isn't about appearance. It's about capacity — the capacity to fully show up for the people who matter most. During that season, I wasn't doing that. I had become a liability. That's a difficult word to write. It's also the truth. If I didn't have the energy to be fully present for my wife, I was a liability. If I didn't have the energy to engage with my daughters, I was a liability. If my health limited my ability to serve the people around me, I was a liability.

Everything begins with energy. Not because it's more important than the other pillars, but because it supports every one of them. You only get one body. One. There isn't another one waiting. There isn't a replacement. That reality deserves our attention. Most people don't think much about their health until it begins disappearing. Then comes the diagnosis. The injury. The wake-up call. I don't say that to shame anyone. I've lived it. I've stood in front of the mirror making excuses. I've convinced myself tomorrow would somehow be different. I've believed convenience would eventually produce the same results as discipline. It never did. Eventually, I stopped lying to myself, and that's when everything began changing.

One of the greatest lies I used to tell myself was, "I don't have time." Today, I don't believe that anymore. We all have the same twenty-four hours. The real question isn't whether we have time. The question is whether we've made our health a priority. That's uncomfortable. It's also true.

People often think they need expensive equipment. The perfect gym. The newest workout. The latest diet. The truth is much simpler than that. You don't need perfection. You need consistency. I haven't had a gym membership in a long while, and I've discovered that remarkable results usually come from remarkably common habits repeated consistently. That's the difficult part. Not knowledge. Consistency. Most people already know what healthy looks like. Eat better. Move more. Sleep more. Drink water. Repeat. The basics aren't exciting, but they're effective. And the basics always work.

One of the biggest shifts in my thinking came when I stopped training to look better and started training to become more capable. That may sound like a small change. For me, it changed everything. I stopped asking, "How do I look?" and started asking, "What am I capable of?" Could I carry someone to safety if I had to? Could I sprint toward danger instead of away from it? Could I physically protect the people I love? Those questions mattered far more to me than visible abs ever would.

Capability creates confidence. Not arrogance — real confidence, the kind that comes from preparation rather than appearance. That understanding completely changed my relationship with fitness. I stopped chasing mirrors and started building capacity. Because when your energy improves, everything else has an opportunity to improve with it. Your patience. Your relationships. Your work. Your leadership. Your attitude. Everything. That's why Energy became the first pillar. It isn't the most important one; it's the multiplier. The stronger your energy becomes, the greater your capacity to strengthen every other part of your life.

There was another lesson running quietly taught me: your mind usually quits long before your body does. Every runner knows that voice. "Slow down." "Skip today." "Nobody will know." "You've done enough." Sometimes those thoughts are wise. Most of the time, they're just uncomfortable. Learning the difference changed my life. The body is remarkably resilient, and so is the human spirit. Both deserve far more credit than we usually give them. That doesn't mean ignoring pain. It means refusing to surrender every time discomfort shows up.

Growth almost always introduces itself as discomfort. That's true physically. It's true emotionally. It's true spiritually. Avoiding discomfort doesn't protect your future. It weakens it. That's why I've learned to welcome certain kinds of discomfort — less because I enjoy suffering than because I know who usually waits on the other side of it. A stronger husband. A stronger father. A stronger friend. A stronger leader. A stronger man.

One of the biggest changes in my own life happened before I ever became faster. It happened when I finally became teachable. I met Paul Duncan while I was building my running streak. Paul is a former professional triathlete, and when I first met him, he was already more than seven hundred days into his own running streak. That immediately caught my attention — not the number itself, but the reason behind it. He wasn't chasing miles. He was setting an example. His son was watching. That resonated deeply with me. Mine were watching too.

The more time I spent learning from Paul, the more I understood that I didn't really know how to run. I knew how to work hard. Those aren't the same thing. Paul became my coach as I prepared for my first one-hundred-kilometer ultramarathon, and the very first thing he started teaching me wasn't speed. It was patience. Heart-rate training. At first, I honestly thought something was wrong. My training pace became painfully slow — slow enough that I felt like people walking their dogs might pass me. Everything inside me wanted to run faster. Paul kept saying the same thing: "Trust the process." The goal wasn't running fast. The goal was building the engine. The foundation. He taught me that if my heart rate climbed too high, I wasn't building endurance anymore. I was only teaching my body to survive.

That lesson fascinated me. Some of the hardest runs I've ever completed weren't hill repeats. They weren't sprint workouts. They weren't races. They were slow runs — runs that required tremendous discipline because every instinct told me to speed up. Instead, I had to intentionally slow down. I had to pay attention. I had to remain patient. I had to trust that doing the fundamentals well would eventually produce the results I wanted. It required concentration. Humility. Discipline.

Now I can see that Paul wasn't merely teaching me how to become a better runner. He was teaching me how to build a better life. Foundations before speed. Basics before breakthroughs. Patience before performance. Those lessons extended far beyond running. They changed the way I approached everything else.

One of the greatest surprises during that season was discovering that slower eventually became faster. At first, that made absolutely no sense to me. Everything inside me believed progress meant pushing harder. Running faster. Working harder. Doing more. Paul kept reminding me that endurance isn't built through constant intensity. It's built through consistency. The better my aerobic base became, the more efficiently my body learned to move. Little by little, the pace naturally improved. I hadn't forced it; the foundation had become stronger.

That lesson has stayed with me far beyond running. How often do we chase speed before building the foundation? We want a stronger marriage, but we skip the small conversations. We want financial freedom, but ignore the daily habits that create it. We want deeper faith, but

neglect the quiet minutes that strengthen it. We want confidence, but avoid the everyday promises that slowly build trust. Life keeps teaching the same lesson. The basics matter. They always have. They always will.

Running also stripped away distractions in a way nothing else ever had. There were no emails. No meetings. No television. No notifications. Just me, the road, my thoughts, and God. Some mornings the road was flat. Other mornings it climbed relentlessly. Sometimes I ran on smooth pavement, sometimes on rocky trails, sometimes on gravel roads, sometimes into a brutal West Texas headwind. Some mornings the sun felt incredible. Other afternoons the heat seemed unbearable. Every run looked different.

Just like life.

Some seasons ask you to sprint. Some ask you to climb. Some ask nothing more than that you keep putting one foot in front of the other. No two runs are identical, and no two lives are either. That's one of the reasons comparison slowly disappeared from my thinking. I wasn't running someone else's course. I was running mine.

One morning another important truth landed. At some point, your one hundred percent may only look like forty percent compared to yesterday. That's okay. If forty percent is honestly everything you have today, then forty percent becomes one hundred percent. Progress doesn't always look impressive. Sometimes it just looks consistent. Seeing that removed a tremendous amount of pressure from my life. Perfection creates anxiety. Consistency creates hope. And hope isn't wishful thinking. Hope is confidence built one promise at a time.

As my confidence quietly grew, another opportunity appeared. Someone asked if I wanted to run a one-hundred-kilometer ultramarathon. Sixty-two miles. People immediately asked the obvious question: "Why?" The answer surprised even me. I wasn't trying to prove anything. I wasn't chasing another medal. I wanted another opportunity to become.

Training for sixty-two miles required everything I had been learning. Patience. Discipline. Humility. Preparation. Trusting the process instead of chasing immediate results. Race day finally arrived. Unlike a triathlon, there weren't massive crowds. No loud music. No grand production. Just runners, trails, rugged terrain, and miles of quiet. Oddly enough, that was exactly what I needed. The race wasn't about excitement. It was about endurance. One step. Then another. Hour after hour. Everything I had practiced during those slow heart-rate runs suddenly made sense. The foundation carried me. Not speed. Not adrenaline. The basics.

When I finally crossed the finish line after sixty-two miles, I wasn't thinking about the medal. I wasn't thinking about the time. I was thinking about my family. A few minutes later, my

daughters walked over and placed the finisher's medal around my neck. That meant more to me than finishing the race itself. Months earlier they had watched Dad leave the house for another routine run. Now they were standing at the finish line. Not celebrating a race — celebrating the man I was becoming. That's a moment I'll never forget. Not because of the medal. Because of who put it there.

The ultramarathon didn't convince me I could run sixty-two miles. It reminded me that ordinary disciplines, practiced consistently over time, quietly prepare you for extraordinary moments. Life works exactly the same way. The finish line only reveals what the quiet days have already built.

As I thought about those sixty-two miles, another truth quietly settled into my heart. The ultramarathon hadn't changed me.

It revealed me.

People often ask where confidence comes from. For years I would have answered, "Winning." Today, I answer very differently. Confidence comes from keeping promises. One promise. Then another. Then another. Eventually, you gather enough evidence that you stop questioning whether you'll show up. You already know you will. That kind of confidence can't be purchased. It can't be borrowed. It can't be faked. It has to be earned.

One ordinary day at a time.

One of the greatest gifts running ever gave me wasn't endurance. It was self-trust. For longer than I'd like to admit, I had taught myself that my promises were negotiable. I'll start Monday. I'll begin next month. I'll get serious after this trip. Every broken promise quietly taught me another lesson: "You don't really mean what you say." The running streak began teaching me something completely different: "You can trust yourself again." That may be one of the greatest transformations I've experienced. It wasn't that I became stronger physically. It was that I became dependable — to myself, to my family, to the people around me.

Dependability is a quiet kind of strength. It doesn't usually make headlines. It just keeps showing up. The older I get, the more I admire dependable people — people who quietly do what they said they would do. Not when it's exciting. Not when it's convenient. Every day. Rain. Wind. Heat. Travel. Busy schedules. They keep showing up anyway. That's exactly what my father modeled. That's exactly what my grandfather modeled. Now I finally understood what I had been watching my entire childhood. They weren't extraordinary because they were talented. They were extraordinary because they were faithful. Faithful people quietly build extraordinary lives. Understanding that changed the way I looked at success. Success stopped being something I chased. It became someone I was becoming.

The more I reflected on my own road, the more something else came into focus. Running had never been about running. Not really. It had become a daily reminder that excuses no longer controlled my life. Every morning I laced up my shoes, I was making the same statement: "Excuses don't get a vote today." That's powerful. Not because of the miles. Because of the identity. One ordinary decision repeated often enough eventually becomes who you are.

The remarkable thing is that nobody else can make that decision for you. Not your spouse. Not your coach. Not your pastor. Not your parents. Eventually, every one of us stands alone in front of the mirror. No audience. No applause. No excuses. Just one question.

Who am I becoming?

That question has become one of the greatest gifts God has ever given me — not because it always has an easy answer, but because it always has an honest one. The answer changes. The question never does. Every season asks something different. The man I needed to become to survive the restaurant isn't the same man I needed to become to finish an ultramarathon. The man I needed to become to quit drinking isn't the same man I need to become to remain present for my family today. Growth changes the answer. That's healthy, because becoming never ends.

I don't ever want to arrive. I don't ever want to believe I've figured life out. The day I stop learning, I'll probably stop growing. That's why I still ask the question every morning: Who do I have to become today? Not next year. Not after another accomplishment. Today.

That question eventually organized every part of my life. I wasn't searching for another self-improvement system; I was searching for a life built on truth instead of excuses. Little did I know that simple question would eventually grow into the framework that now guides almost every decision I make.

Chapter 8 ## Education

When most people hear the word education, they immediately think about school. Grades. Diplomas. Degrees. That's not what this chapter is about. Education, at least the way I define it today, has very little to do with a classroom. It's about becoming. It's about remaining curious. It's about refusing to believe you've arrived — every single day, for the rest of your life.

For a long stretch I assumed education ended the day I graduated from college. I couldn't have been more wrong. The most valuable education I've ever received happened after I walked across that stage. It came through books, mentors, failure, conversations, experience, and reflection. Life itself became my classroom.

That understanding changed everything. Suddenly every mistake carried value, every setback carried a lesson, and every difficult conversation became an opportunity to grow. Education stopped being about information. It became about transformation.

When I struggled in sales, I studied sales. When I wanted to better serve my customers, I studied people. When I wanted stronger relationships, I studied communication. When I wanted better health, I studied health. When I wanted a deeper faith, I spent more time in Scripture. When I wanted a stronger mindset, I intentionally sought people who had already walked roads I hoped to travel. Nobody assigned those lessons. Curiosity did. That's the difference. No one can force another person to grow. Growth becomes powerful when learning becomes personal.

The more I learned, the more I recognized how little I actually knew. When I was younger, I thought confidence came from having answers. Today I believe confidence comes from remaining teachable. Those are two completely different people. The first eventually stops growing. The second never has to. That's why I still seek coaches, still read, still ask questions, and still spend far more time listening than talking. I hope I never stop being a student, because the day I believe I've arrived is probably the day I'll stop becoming.

One thought kept returning to me during that season. A sword that never gets sharpened eventually becomes dull. The answer isn't swinging it harder. The answer is stepping away long enough to sharpen the edge. That's exactly how I now view education — not collecting more information, but sharpening the sword, preparing the instrument before the battle arrives. Life will eventually test every one of us. The question is whether we've been preparing long before the test begins.

That's when something else hit me. Not everything deserves access to your mind. That sentence stopped me, because I had spent so long becoming intentional about what entered my body while

remaining almost completely unintentional about what entered my mind. Imagine allowing someone to walk into your house every day carrying bags of garbage. Eventually your house becomes unlivable. Our minds work exactly the same way. Every conversation, every headline, every social media post, every television show, every opinion, and every repeated thought — everything leaves something behind. The question isn't whether information influences you. It does. The question is whether you're intentionally deciding what gets through the gate.

One of the greatest investments you'll ever make isn't in the stock market. It isn't in real estate. It isn't even in your career. It's in your mind. Everything in your life eventually passes through it — every decision, every relationship, every opportunity, every response. The quality of your thinking eventually determines the quality of your life.

Through most of my early adulthood, I thought education was something you finished. Graduate high school. Graduate college. Get the degree. Start working. In hindsight, I had completely misunderstood what education actually was. School teaches you subjects. Life teaches you wisdom. The two aren't always the same. I've met people with advanced degrees who continually make poor decisions. I've also met people who never attended college who possess incredible wisdom. Knowledge and wisdom aren't identical. Knowledge tells you that something is true. Wisdom teaches you how to live it. That's the education I became interested in. Not information. Transformation.

One of the greatest changes in my life happened when I stopped asking, "What do I have to learn?" and began asking instead, "Who can teach me?" That subtle shift changed everything. Books became conversations. Podcasts became mentorship. Failure became tuition. Every person I met knew something I didn't, and if I stayed curious, life constantly offered another lesson.

Coming to see that removed something I had quietly carried for a long time. Pride. Pride says, "I already know." Humility asks, "What am I missing?" One question stops growth. The other fuels it.

I've discovered that the wisest people I know all seem to have something in common. They're incredibly curious. They ask questions. They listen. They aren't trying to prove how much they know; they're trying to learn one more thing. That's become one of my favorite ways to approach life: walk into every room believing someone knows something you don't. Because they probably do. That perspective has made me a better husband, a better father, a better salesman, a better runner, and a better leader. Most importantly, it has made me a better student. I hope I never stop being one. The day I believe I've learned everything I need to know, I'll probably stop becoming.

And I never want becoming to end.

One of the greatest lies I ever believed was that learning automatically produces change. It doesn't. I've read books that changed absolutely nothing about my life — and it wasn't that the books weren't good. It was that I never applied what they taught. I've also read a single sentence that completely changed the direction of my thinking. The difference wasn't the amount of information. It was what I chose to do with it. Knowledge by itself has very little value. Applied knowledge changes everything.

That's why I eventually stopped measuring how many books I finished each year. I became much more interested in one question: what am I doing differently because of what I just learned? If the answer was nothing, then I hadn't really learned anything. I had merely been entertained.

That truth changed the way I approached reading. Instead of trying to finish another chapter, I stopped whenever something challenged me. Sometimes I'd reread the same page several times — not because I didn't understand it, but because I wanted to live it. The goal wasn't another completed book. The goal was another transformed habit.

I think that's one of the biggest mistakes our culture makes. We celebrate consuming information. We rarely celebrate applying it. The world doesn't need more people who know what to do. The world needs more people willing to actually do it. One applied lesson is worth more than one hundred forgotten quotes. One difficult conversation is worth more than another notebook full of highlights. One healthy decision repeated consistently is worth more than another inspirational podcast. Application changes identity. Information simply fills notebooks.

I learned that lesson the hard way. Year after year I collected ideas. I attended seminars. I listened to podcasts. I highlighted books. I took pages of notes. Yet my life often looked exactly the same. The problem wasn't what I knew. The problem was what I refused to practice.

Eventually I began asking myself another question: what's one thing I can live today? Not ten things. One. If I learned about gratitude, practice gratitude today. If I learned about forgiveness, make the phone call today. If I learned about discipline, keep today's promise. That approach simplified growth tremendously. Small changes became sustainable. Sustainable changes became habits. Habits eventually became identity. Identity quietly changed my life.

One lesson, applied consistently, can change everything.

That's why I no longer read just to finish books. I read to become someone different. The same is true for this book. If you finish every chapter but never apply a single lesson, nothing changes. If one idea changes the way you live tomorrow, everything changes. That's why I included questions throughout this book — not so you'll agree with me, but so you'll wrestle with your

own answers. My answers built my life. Yours will build yours. That's exactly the way it should be.

Education isn't complete when you've learned something. Education becomes complete when your life begins reflecting what you've learned. That's when knowledge finally becomes wisdom.

One lesson I learned through medical sales has stayed with me far beyond my career: people don't care how much you know until they're convinced you genuinely care about them. That lesson changed the way I approached almost every conversation. When I first entered sales, I thought success depended on having all the answers — knowing every product, every study, every statistic, every objection. The longer I worked with physicians, nurses, and hospital staff, the more I understood something. They weren't looking for another salesperson. They were looking for someone they could trust.

Trust is built long before someone signs an agreement. It's built through consistency, through listening, through following through — through doing exactly what you said you were going to do. Education taught me something important there too. The more I learned, the less I felt the need to prove how much I knew. I became much more interested in asking better questions. Curiosity became one of my greatest professional advantages. Instead of walking into an office thinking, "What do I want to say?" I started thinking, "What do I need to understand?" Those are completely different conversations. People feel the difference. They know when they're being talked to. They also know when they're genuinely being heard.

That lesson carried into my marriage, into parenting, into friendships, and into leadership. Listening became more valuable than speaking. Understanding became more valuable than impressing. One question eventually became part of almost every meaningful conversation I had: "Help me understand." Those three words changed relationships. It wasn't that they solved every disagreement; it was that they communicated humility. Humility creates space for learning. Pride usually shuts the conversation down before it ever begins.

I've discovered that education isn't really about accumulating more answers. It's about asking better questions. The quality of your questions often determines the quality of your life. Ask shallow questions, and you receive shallow answers. Ask honest questions, and life usually responds honestly. That's one of the reasons I've become so fascinated with questions throughout this book. Questions don't tell people what to think. They invite people to think.

No one ever changed my life by forcing answers on me. The people who changed my life asked questions I couldn't ignore — questions I carried home, questions that followed me onto runs, questions that stayed with me long after the conversation ended. Questions like, "Who do I have

to become?" That single question has probably shaped my life more than any answer ever has. The right answer may inspire you for a moment. The right question can shape you for a lifetime.

Education eventually taught me that the greatest classroom isn't a building. It's life itself. Every conversation teaches something. Every failure teaches something. Every success teaches something. Every difficult season teaches something. The only real question is whether we're paying attention. For too long, I wasn't. Today, I hope I never stop learning, because I hope I never stop becoming.

As I continued learning, I noticed something else. The people I admired most all shared one characteristic: they were readers. It wasn't that reading somehow made them smarter. Reading kept them teachable. Every book became another opportunity to borrow someone else's lifetime of experience.

I've often thought about how incredible that really is. A person spends thirty, forty, sometimes fifty years learning difficult lessons, then condenses those lessons into a few hundred pages. For the price of a book and a few hours of your time, you gain access to decades of wisdom. That's an incredible return on investment. The problem isn't access. The problem is application. I've met people with bookshelves full of incredible books whose lives never changed. I've also met people who built extraordinary lives from faithfully applying just a handful of timeless principles. The difference wasn't intelligence. It was action.

Seeing that completely changed the way I approached personal growth. Instead of constantly searching for the next great idea, I started asking, "Am I living the ideas I already know?" That question exposed me. I didn't need another book telling me to become more disciplined; I needed another disciplined day. I didn't need another podcast on marriage; I needed another intentional conversation with my wife. I didn't need another financial seminar; I needed to steward today's money wisely.

Growth became much simpler. Not easier. Simpler. Learn. Apply. Repeat. The same pattern kept showing up everywhere I looked. Read, practice, reflect, repeat. Listen, apply, repeat. Fall down, get back up, repeat. Life isn't nearly as complicated as we often make it. Consistency has a remarkable way of making complicated things simple.

One of the greatest educational experiences of my life didn't happen because I learned something new. It happened because I finally understood something I had heard many times before: there is a tremendous difference between information and wisdom. Information answers questions. Wisdom asks better ones. Information fills your mind. Wisdom shapes your life. Information can impress people. Wisdom quietly serves them. That's the kind of education I wanted — not

education that merely made me more knowledgeable, but education that made me more useful. More dependable. More compassionate. More prepared. More intentional.

The more I grew, the more I noticed another interesting pattern. The wisest people I knew weren't constantly talking. They were constantly observing — listening, asking questions, learning. That changed my approach to leadership. I stopped feeling like I needed to have every answer. I simply needed to remain curious enough to keep asking better questions.

Curiosity has become one of the greatest gifts God has given me. Curiosity keeps pride from taking over. Curiosity keeps growth alive. Curiosity reminds me that every person I meet knows something I don't. That's incredibly freeing. It means every conversation becomes an opportunity, every relationship becomes another classroom, and every day becomes another lesson. The day we stop learning, we quietly begin declining. I don't ever want that day to come.

I hope that five years from now I'm embarrassed by some of the things I believe today — not because they were wrong, but because I continued growing. If I'm exactly the same man ten years from now, then somewhere along the way I stopped becoming. I don't want that. I hope I'm always becoming. Always learning. Always refining. Always growing. Not for my sake alone, but for my family, for the people I lead, for the people I serve, and for the readers who trusted me enough to spend time with this book. If I'm asking you to keep becoming, I owe you the same commitment myself.

That may be the greatest lesson education has ever taught me. The student never graduates. He just keeps showing up, ready to learn again tomorrow.

From where I stand today, I don't believe education's greatest purpose is helping us make a better living. I believe its greatest purpose is helping us become better people. There's a difference. A better living can provide comfort. A better person creates impact.

For most of my adult life I measured success by accomplishments — promotions, income, business opportunities, athletic goals. One by one, I accomplished many of the things I once believed would finally make me feel successful. Oddly enough, the feeling never lasted very long. Another goal always appeared. Another mountain. Another finish line. Another opportunity. Eventually it sank in that I had been measuring the wrong things. The older I become, the less interested I am in asking, "What have I accomplished?" I'm much more interested in asking, "Who have I helped?" That question changed my definition of success.

One of the greatest blessings of my career in medical sales has been the opportunity to serve physicians, nurses, and hospital staff who dedicate their lives to helping others. Being around those people for so many years taught me something I don't think I'll ever forget. The most

respected people in the room usually aren't the ones trying to prove they're the smartest. They're the ones constantly learning. Medicine changes. Technology changes. Research changes. The best physicians never stop studying — and no one makes them. They study because lives depend on it.

That principle extends far beyond medicine. Our marriages deserve that kind of curiosity. Our children deserve that kind of curiosity. Our faith deserves that kind of curiosity. Our leadership deserves that kind of curiosity. The instant we believe we've figured everything out, growth quietly stops. I hope I never become that person. I hope I remain curious enough to ask questions that make me uncomfortable. I hope I remain humble enough to admit when I'm wrong. I hope I remain teachable enough to continue changing. Because if this road has taught me anything, it's this: growth is never something we graduate from. It's a lifelong invitation — an invitation to become a little wiser, a little more patient, a little more compassionate, a little more intentional, every single day.

When I think about education today, I no longer picture classrooms. I picture conversations with my daughters. Long walks with my wife. Early morning runs. Books filled with highlighted pages. Coaches who challenged me. Friends who told me the truth. Failures that humbled me. Successes that reminded me to stay grateful. Life has become my classroom. Every day offers another lesson. The only question is whether I'm paying attention.

Education isn't about filling your mind. It's about shaping your character. Character is what remains when the information is forgotten. Character is what your family experiences every day. Character is what your coworkers trust. Character is what your children imitate. Character is what quietly introduces you long before you ever speak. Everything we consistently learn eventually becomes someone. The question is, who are we becoming?

That question naturally leads us to another pillar — one that, for many years, I misunderstood almost as much as education. I thought relationships happened naturally. I eventually learned they require just as much intention as every other area of life. Maybe more.

That's where our next pillar begins.

CHAPTER 9

Empathy

For a long time, I misunderstood empathy. I thought empathy meant agreeing with someone, avoiding difficult conversations, trying to make sure everyone felt comfortable. I couldn't have been more wrong. Empathy isn't lowering the standard. Empathy is caring enough to understand someone's story before you judge their behavior. That lesson changed my relationships more than almost anything else I've learned — maybe because I needed it so desperately myself.

Growing up, there were many times I wished someone would just ask, "Randall... what's really going on?" It wasn't sympathy I was after. I wanted someone to understand. Sometimes the greatest gift you can give another person isn't advice. It's your attention. Through much of my life I believed people needed better answers. Today I believe most people first need someone willing to truly listen. Listening has become one of the greatest demonstrations of love I know — not waiting for your turn to speak, not trying to solve every problem, but listening. Really listening.

The older I become, the more convinced I am that everyone is carrying something. Some burdens are visible; most aren't. The person who seems angry may actually be exhausted. The person who appears distant may be grieving. The person who seems impatient may be carrying fear nobody else knows about. I've learned to become much slower when judging people — not because everyone is right, but because everyone has a story.

My own story taught me that. There were years when people saw a quiet teenager; they didn't see the abuse. Years later, people saw a businessman; they didn't see the anxiety. They saw someone who smiled; they didn't see the depression. They saw a husband and father; they didn't see the man sitting in a rocking chair wondering if his family would somehow be better off without him.

Appearances rarely tell the whole story.

That's why empathy begins with curiosity. Instead of asking, "What's wrong with that person?" I try asking, "I wonder what they've been through?" That question has changed countless conversations. It reminds me that behavior often has roots we can't see. Understanding those

roots doesn't excuse unhealthy behavior; it only helps explain it. That distinction matters, because empathy doesn't ignore truth. Empathy delivers truth with compassion.

Jesus modeled that perfectly. He never compromised truth, and He also never forgot the person standing in front of Him. I've tried to remember that in my own life — especially when someone disappoints me, especially when someone frustrates me, especially when someone doesn't meet my expectations. Because I've been that person too. I've disappointed people. I've needed grace. I've needed second chances. Remembering my own story has made it much easier to extend grace to someone else's.

One of the greatest gifts my wife has given me isn't encouragement. It's honesty. Real honesty — the kind that loves you enough to tell you the truth. There have been many conversations over the years where she saw something in me long before I saw it myself. Sometimes she reminded me I was capable of more. Other times she lovingly pointed out where I was falling short. Neither conversation was always easy. Both were necessary. Love isn't merely celebrating someone's strengths; sometimes love quietly refuses to let someone settle. I've become incredibly grateful for that. Empathy isn't avoiding difficult conversations. It's caring enough to have them. That's a lesson I continue learning.

For a long stretch of my career, I believed leadership meant having the right answers. Today I think leadership begins with asking better questions. "How are you... really?" "What can I do to help?" "What are you carrying that nobody else knows about?" Those questions have opened doors that advice never could. People rarely need another lecture. Most people already know where they're struggling. What they often need is someone willing to sit beside them while they find the courage to face it.

I've learned that fixing people isn't my responsibility. Loving them is. That's a tremendous relief, because it means I don't have to carry the weight of changing another person's life. All I have to do is faithfully love the person standing in front of me. God handles the transformation.

One lesson that changed the way I parent came from a truth so plain I had somehow missed it: my daughters don't need a perfect father. They need a present one. Presence has become one of the greatest expressions of empathy in my life. When I'm truly listening, I'm present. When I put the phone away, I'm present. When I stop thinking about work while someone else is talking, I'm present. Presence communicates value. It quietly tells another person, "You matter enough for me to give you my full attention."

For years I thought providing for my family was the greatest gift I could give them. Providing matters. But provision without presence leaves something important missing. Children spell love in ways adults often overlook. They spell it T-I-M-E. Not expensive vacations. Not elaborate

gifts. Time. Conversations. Shared experiences. Quiet evenings around the dinner table. Long car rides. Throwing a ball in the backyard. Ski trips. Fishing trips. Running errands together. These are the things that don't seem particularly significant while they're happening — until years later, when they become the memories your children carry into adulthood.

As I've reflected on my own childhood, it has hit me that the times I treasure most weren't expensive. They were ordinary. Watching football with my grandparents. Working alongside my dad. Traveling with my grandmother. Sitting quietly in a deer blind. Those experiences shaped me far more than possessions ever could, and that's one of the reasons experiences have become so valuable to me today. Experiences are the world's most valuable currency — not for what they cost, but for the way they become part of who we are. Money comes and goes. Experiences become stories. Stories become memories. Memories quietly shape generations.

The more I thought about empathy, the more I saw that it always begins with one decision: slow down. People are difficult to love when we're constantly in a hurry. People are difficult to understand when we're always thinking about the next meeting, the next email, the next task, the next obligation. Empathy requires margin. Margin requires intention. Intention requires priorities. Everything is connected. The quality of our relationships rarely depends on how much we know. It depends on how well we love.

One of the greatest changes empathy brought into my life was forgiveness. It wasn't that forgiveness suddenly became easy; it was that I finally understood who was carrying the weight. Year after year, I believed holding on somehow protected me. I thought if I stayed angry, if I stayed bitter, if I remembered every painful detail, then somehow justice would eventually be served. Instead, I discovered I was the one carrying the burden.

Forgiveness doesn't erase the past. It doesn't pretend something painful never happened. It doesn't excuse abuse. It doesn't remove accountability. Forgiveness refuses to allow yesterday to continue controlling today. That truth took me years to accept. There are still days when old memories surface — still times when I remember words spoken over a little boy who didn't deserve them. The difference is that those memories no longer determine who I become. They remind me where I came from, not where I'm going.

I've often been asked whether I ever forgave my stepmother. The answer surprises some people. Yes. She never asked for it, and nothing was suddenly resolved. I forgave her because I needed to. Forgiveness wasn't setting her free.

It was setting me free.

That doesn't mean trust automatically returns. Trust and forgiveness are not the same thing. Trust is rebuilt through consistent behavior. Forgiveness is a decision. Healthy boundaries still matter. Wisdom still matters. Discernment still matters. One doesn't cancel the other.

That's another lesson empathy taught me. You can love someone and still establish healthy boundaries. You can forgive someone and still recognize that certain relationships require distance. Those ideas once seemed contradictory to me. Today they make perfect sense, because love doesn't always mean unlimited access. Sometimes love says, "I genuinely wish you well," while also recognizing that wisdom requires separation. That's difficult. It's also healthy.

The more I grew, the more I understood that empathy isn't only something we extend to other people. Sometimes it's something we must learn to extend to ourselves. That may have been one of the hardest lessons of all. For longer than I'd like to admit, I spoke to myself in ways I would never speak to another human being. I replayed mistakes. I magnified failures. I ignored progress. I demanded perfection. If someone else had spoken to me the way I spoke to myself, I would have called it abuse. Yet I accepted it because the voice sounded familiar.

Eventually I recognized whose voice it really was. It wasn't God's. It wasn't truth. It was an old recording that had been playing since childhood. Once I recognized that, I finally had a choice. Would I continue repeating those lies, or would I begin replacing them with truth? That process didn't happen overnight. It happened one thought at a time. One prayer at a time.

One ordinary day at a time.

The lies grew quieter. They never disappeared entirely; truth finally became louder than they were. That's what empathy ultimately taught me. Every person you meet is carrying a story — including you. Treat both with grace. Tell both the truth. Then keep moving forward, not carrying yesterday but learning from it. That's where healing begins. And healing has a remarkable way of changing not only the person receiving it, but every person whose life they eventually touch.

As I continued thinking about empathy, something else came into focus. The people who impacted my life the most all had one thing in common: they made me feel seen. It wasn't that they solved all my problems. They took the time to understand them.

I think back to my grandmother. She probably never realized how much she was shaping my life. She wasn't giving motivational speeches. She wasn't teaching leadership seminars. She simply loved me. Consistently. Quietly. Faithfully.

My father did the same thing. He wasn't perfect — neither am I — but he kept showing up. He coached my baseball teams. He took me hunting. He taught me to ski. He let me ride beside him while checking cattle, fixing fences, or spending an afternoon at the bank or accountant's office.

At the time, I thought we were just running errands. Today I understand something much deeper. He was giving me his time. Time became trust. Trust became memories. Those memories eventually became part of the foundation I would stand on years later.

That's one of the reasons I believe empathy is expressed far more through actions than words. People may forget what we say. They rarely forget how we made them feel. Understanding that changed the way I approached leadership. Whether I was working with physicians, leading a team, coaching someone, or just talking with a friend, I stopped asking, "How do I impress this person?" I started asking, "How can I leave this person better than I found them?" That question became incredibly freeing. It shifted the focus away from me and toward them.

The funny thing about empathy is that it usually comes back to us. We're not looking for something in return; people naturally trust those who genuinely care. Trust isn't demanded. It's earned — one conversation at a time, one promise kept at a time, one relationship at a time.

I've come to believe that leadership is really stewardship. God places people in our lives for a reason. Our spouse. Our children. Our coworkers. Our friends. Sometimes complete strangers. Each interaction gives us an opportunity: to leave someone encouraged, to leave someone heard, to leave someone with a little more hope than they had before we met. That may be one of the greatest responsibilities we'll ever carry.

The older I become, the less interested I am in being remembered for accomplishments. I hope I'm remembered for how I treated people, because accomplishments eventually fade. Influence doesn't. The conversations we have today, the encouragement we give today, the grace we extend today — all of it may become part of someone else's story for years to come. We'll probably never know. That's okay. Most seeds are planted long before anyone sees the harvest. That's how my grandmother lived. That's how my father lived. That's how I hope to live.

Empathy isn't weakness. It's strength under control. It's choosing compassion when judgment would be easier. It's choosing curiosity before criticism. It's remembering that every person you meet is fighting a battle you know nothing about — including the person looking back at you in the mirror.

The world has enough critics. It has enough outrage. It has enough people determined to win every argument. What it desperately needs are more people willing to understand before they're understood. More people willing to listen before speaking. More people willing to love without keeping score. Those people change families. They change workplaces. They change communities. Sometimes they change generations.

When I trace my own life back, I can clearly see the people who changed mine. None of them changed it through perfection. They changed it through presence. Through consistency. Through love. I hope, by God's grace, that someone can someday say the same about me. Because if becoming has taught me anything, it's that success without relationships is empty. The people we love will always matter more than the things we achieve.

That's why empathy became the third pillar. Not because relationships are easy — because they're worth everything.

Chapter 10 ## Economics

For most of my life, I thought money was the goal. It wasn't greed driving that belief. I genuinely thought money would solve my problems. If I made more, life would become easier. If I built a successful business, I'd finally feel successful. If I could just get ahead financially, everything else would eventually fall into place. I know a lot of people who believe that. I used to be one of them.

The restaurant taught me something I never expected: money is a terrible foundation for your identity. Businesses succeed, and businesses fail. Markets rise, and markets fall. Jobs change, and economies change right along with them. If your identity rises and falls with those things, you'll spend your entire life on an emotional roller coaster. I know, because I lived it. When the restaurant failed, I didn't just lose a business. I believed I had lost myself.

That was one of the greatest financial lessons I've ever learned. Your net worth and your self-worth are not the same thing. They never have been, and they never will be. When that truth finally landed, it freed me, because for a long stretch I had unknowingly tied my value to my performance. A good sales month, and I felt valuable. A bad month, and I questioned myself. A successful business made me feel confident, and a failed business made me feel like a failure. Nothing about that way of living is sustainable. Eventually it sank in that money makes a wonderful tool and a terrible master.

The more I reflected on it, the more I understood something my father had quietly modeled my entire life. Money was never the goal. Stewardship was. Growing up on a farm and ranch, I watched my father take care of things — equipment, land, animals, people. Nothing was wasted. That wasn't because we had unlimited resources; it was because every resource mattered.

That lesson followed me into adulthood. Everything we own is eventually something we've been entrusted to manage: our money, our time, our opportunities, our influence, even our talents. None of them truly belong to us. They're gifts. So the question isn't, "How much do I have?" The better question is, "How well am I managing what I've already been given?"

That one question completely changed the way I looked at finances. Instead of constantly chasing more, I started becoming grateful for what I already had. Gratitude has a remarkable way of changing financial decisions. Grateful people usually make better stewards, while entitled people usually make bigger consumers. I've been both. Stewardship creates peace; consumption never seems satisfied. The more I chased things, the less fulfilled I became. The more I focused on stewardship, the more freedom I experienced. That surprised me, because freedom isn't found in owning everything.

Freedom is found in needing less.

The restaurant taught me that. The lawsuits reinforced it, and the rebuilding years confirmed it. Money matters — I'm not pretending it doesn't. It provides opportunities, it creates choices, and it allows generosity. But money has never been the destination. It's one more area where integrity matters, one more area where becoming matters, one more area where small decisions quietly compound over time.

One of the greatest financial mistakes I ever made had nothing to do with investing. It had everything to do with believing that more would finally be enough. I kept chasing the next opportunity, the next promotion, the next business, the next accomplishment. The finish line kept moving. Every time I reached what I thought would finally satisfy me, another target appeared. That cycle is exhausting — and ambition isn't the problem. The problem is that fulfillment was never designed to come from accomplishment alone. The restaurant exposed that lie. Medical sales challenged it. Running eventually confirmed it.

Happiness doesn't come after success. For me, happiness had to come before it.

That statement probably would have frustrated a younger version of me. At one point in my life, I honestly believed happiness was something you earned. Earn enough money, build enough success, accomplish enough goals — then you'd finally be happy. Life taught me the opposite. Happy people usually build better businesses. Happy people usually become better spouses, and happy people usually become better parents. It isn't that life is easier for them. It's that they aren't asking accomplishments to provide something accomplishments were never designed to give: peace.

Understanding that changed the way I looked at work. I still work hard — probably harder than ever. The difference is that work no longer defines me. It gives me an opportunity to serve, to provide, to create value, to steward the abilities God has given me. That's very different from asking work to determine my worth.

One lesson from medical sales has stayed with me ever since I learned it. The best sales representatives aren't focused on selling; they're focused on solving problems. That shift completely changed my career. Every morning I stopped asking, "How do I make another sale?" Instead I asked, "How can I create more value today?" The amazing thing is that income eventually followed value. Not immediately, and not perfectly, but consistently. That's how stewardship usually works: value first, reward second.

The same principle applies almost everywhere in life. Healthy marriages create value. Great parents create value. Honest leaders create value, and faithful employees create value. Money

usually follows people who consistently create value for others. That doesn't mean every faithful person becomes wealthy. It just means value has a remarkable way of opening doors.

The more I thought about stewardship, the more something became clear to me: money amplifies character. If someone is generous with very little, they're usually generous with much. If someone lacks integrity with very little, more money rarely fixes that problem — it usually magnifies it. That's why stewardship starts long before wealth ever arrives. It's learned through everyday decisions: paying bills on time, keeping promises, living below your means, giving generously, being grateful. Those habits quietly become character, and character eventually shapes every financial decision you'll ever make.

The more I understood that, the less interested I became in appearing successful. I became much more interested in becoming faithful. Faithfulness has become one of my favorite words. Faithful husband. Faithful father. Faithful steward. Faithful friend. Faithful employee. Faithful leader. Those titles matter much more to me than successful businessman ever will, because success can disappear. Faithfulness stays with you.

One question eventually became a filter for almost every financial decision I made: Does this move me toward freedom, or farther away from it? Years ago, I would have answered that question very differently. Back then, I thought freedom meant having more money. Today, I think freedom means needing less. There's an incredible difference between the two. The more I chased things, the more I discovered there was always something else to chase — a newer vehicle, a larger home, a different title, a bigger account, another accomplishment. The finish line kept moving, and contentment never seemed to arrive.

Then something unexpected happened. As my priorities began changing, so did my definition of wealth. Wealth became having dinner with my family without thinking about work. Wealth became taking my daughters on a ski trip. Wealth became watching my wife laugh while we explored another part of the world together. Wealth became having the health to climb a mountain, to run another trail, to throw a football in the backyard, to be fully present.

Experiences slowly became far more valuable than possessions. There's nothing wrong with possessions; the difference is that experiences become part of us. Nobody can repossess a memory. Nobody can foreclose on time spent with your family, and nobody can take away the conversations that changed your life. Those become part of who you are forever.

One of the greatest gifts my parents and grandparents gave me wasn't money. It was experiences. Hunting trips with my dad. Washington, D.C. with my grandmother. Watching football with my grandparents, working cattle, driving fence lines, skiing together. Those memories have appreciated in value every single year of my life. That's a remarkable investment. The older I

become, the more convinced I am that experiences are the world's most valuable currency. They're one of the few investments that continue increasing in value long after they're over.

Seeing that changed the way my wife and I began making decisions. Instead of asking, "What can we buy?" we found ourselves asking, "What will our daughters remember?" That's a completely different conversation. Children rarely remember the price of Christmas. They remember how it felt. They remember traditions, vacations, road trips, Saturday mornings, conversations around the dinner table — unremarkable moments. Those moments quietly become their childhood, and one day they'll become their stories. That thought carries tremendous responsibility, because whether we realize it or not, we're writing our children's memories every single day.

Money can certainly create opportunities. But it can never replace presence. I learned that lesson from my own father. He worked incredibly hard, yet somehow he still found time. Time to coach. Time to hunt. Time to ski. Time to let a little boy ride beside him while checking cattle or stopping by the bank. At the time, I thought we were just spending the day together. Today I understand he was giving me something money could never buy: his attention, his example, his presence. That may have been the greatest investment he ever made in me. It's certainly one of the greatest investments I hope to make in my own daughters.

The more I thought about stewardship, the more I saw that money is only one resource among many. Time, energy, attention, relationships, influence — they're all forms of wealth, and they're all entrusted to us. The question has never been, "How much do I have?" The question is, "What am I doing with what I've already been given?" That question has a way of simplifying life, because stewardship isn't measured by comparison. It's measured by faithfulness.

And faithfulness always begins today.

One lesson the restaurant taught me that I never could have learned from a textbook was the difference between ownership and stewardship. Ownership says, "This is mine." Stewardship says, "This has been entrusted to me." That shift in thinking changed almost every part of my life. My house isn't really mine; it's something God has entrusted to my family. My career isn't really mine; it's an opportunity to create value for others. Even my daughters aren't my possessions. They're gifts, and I'm trusted to raise them well. That perspective removed an enormous amount of pressure. I no longer felt like I had to control everything. I only needed to faithfully manage what had already been placed in front of me.

That applies to money too. One of the greatest financial habits my wife and I developed wasn't making more. It was becoming intentional. Money has a way of disappearing when it doesn't have a purpose. Every dollar eventually goes somewhere; the question is whether you decided

where, or whether it decided for you. Intentional living changed that for us. We began talking about our priorities before making purchases. We weren't trying to eliminate fun. We wanted our spending to reflect our values.

That's a very revealing exercise. If someone looked at your calendar and your bank statement, would they be able to identify what matters most to you? That's an uncomfortable question. It was for me too, because money tells the truth — not about how much we have, but about what we value. I discovered there were seasons where I claimed family was my highest priority while my calendar quietly disagreed. I claimed health mattered while my habits disagreed. I claimed faith mattered while my schedule disagreed. Results have a remarkable way of exposing reality. That isn't condemnation; it's clarity. And clarity gives us an opportunity to change, one decision at a time.

I've also learned something else about stewardship: generosity changes the giver as much as the receiver. When we hold everything tightly, fear usually grows. When we learn to give, trust grows. That doesn't mean giving irresponsibly. It means recognizing that everything we have is temporary. We arrive with nothing, and we leave with nothing. Somewhere in between, we become managers. The older I get, the more freedom I find in open hands. Open hands receive, and open hands give. Closed fists usually do neither.

That's one of the reasons gratitude has become such an important part of my life. Grateful people tend to become generous people, and generous people tend to become joyful people. Giving doesn't always change their circumstances, but it does change their perspective. I've discovered that contentment isn't found when we finally have enough. Contentment begins the instant we become grateful for what's already enough. That's a lesson I'm still learning, every single day.

One of my favorite definitions of success has become remarkably simple. Success is faithfully stewarding everything God has entrusted to you. Not someone else's life — yours. Not someone else's opportunities — yours. Not someone else's gifts — yours. Comparison quietly disappears when stewardship becomes the goal, because God has never asked me to manage your life. He's asked me to faithfully manage mine. Understanding that brought an incredible amount of peace.

It also reminded me that every pillar we've talked about so far shares something in common. They're all ultimately about stewardship. Stewarding your body. Stewarding your mind. Stewarding your relationships. Stewarding your resources. Everything points back to becoming the kind of person God can trust with whatever He chooses to place in your hands. That became my new definition of wealth — not what I owned, but who I was becoming.

As I've reflected on this pillar over the years, I've come to see that stewardship isn't really about money. Money is only one expression of it. Stewardship is ultimately about trust. Can God trust

me with what He's already given me? That question reaches much farther than finances. Can He trust me with my marriage? Can He trust me with my children? Can He trust me with influence? Can He trust me with success? Can He trust me with adversity? Can He trust me with another opportunity? Those questions have become much more important to me than, "How do I get more?"

I've discovered that people who constantly chase more rarely enjoy what they already have. I know, because I lived there. There was always another goal, another account, another race, another mountain, another milestone. Eventually the truth caught up with me. If I couldn't be grateful where I was, nothing waiting in the future was going to permanently change that. Gratitude isn't created by abundance. Abundance is often recognized through gratitude.

That one lesson quietly changed my entire perspective. Instead of asking, "What do I still need?" I began asking, "What have I already been given that I'm overlooking?" That question has a remarkable way of slowing life down. It reminds me of conversations around my grandparents' table, of hunting trips with my dad, of Washington, D.C., with my grandmother, of my daughters placing an ultramarathon medal around my neck. None of those experiences showed up on a financial statement, yet they represent some of the greatest wealth I've ever known. Money has certainly made some of those experiences possible, but it never created their value. Love did. Presence did. Time did.

I've often thought about the end of life. I don't believe anyone sits on their deathbed wishing they had answered one more email, closed one more sale, or accumulated one more possession. I think they remember people. Conversations. Experiences. Laughter. Faithfulness. The ordinary moments they almost overlooked while they were busy chasing extraordinary ones.

That's one of the reasons my definition of success has changed so dramatically. Today, success looks remarkably plain. Being present with my wife. Laughing with my daughters. Serving customers with integrity. Keeping my word. Taking care of the body God entrusted to me. Growing a little wiser than I was yesterday. Helping someone else believe their life can change. That's success. Everything else is a bonus.

I don't say that because money doesn't matter. It does. It allows generosity, it creates opportunities, and it provides security. But money has never been the destination. It's another tool — a tool that can accomplish tremendous good when placed in the hands of someone who understands stewardship.

The beautiful thing about stewardship is that it keeps us grounded. It reminds us that everything is temporary — every opportunity, every possession, every accomplishment. One day we'll hand all of it back. The only thing that will remain is who we became while we were entrusted with it.

That thought has become one of the greatest motivations in my life. Not to accumulate more, but to become more faithful. Because faithfulness compounds, just like excuses once did. One everyday decision. One quiet conversation. One small act of integrity. Day after day, year after year, until one day you look back and see that you didn't just build a better financial life.

You built a better life.

One that isn't measured by what you own, but by what you faithfully steward. The four pillars all lead me back to the same conclusion. Everything I have, everything I am, and everything I hope to become has been entrusted to me for a season. My responsibility isn't to compare my season with someone else's. It's to be faithful in my own. That understanding quietly brought the first four pillars together — not as separate parts of life, but as one life. One foundation. One question. One daily decision.

Who do I have to become today?

Chapter 11 ## Living the Framework

When I first began organizing my life around these four pillars, I honestly thought they would become another goal. Another checklist. Another system I'd eventually replace with something better.

I was wrong.

The longer I lived them, the more I understood they weren't another program at all. They had become a filter, and every meaningful decision eventually passed through them. If I accepted another responsibility, how would it affect my energy? If I committed to another project, would it strengthen my relationships or quietly weaken them? If I spent money on something, was I stewarding what I'd been given well? And if I found myself reacting emotionally, was there something my mind needed to learn before I responded?

The framework didn't simplify life because it removed difficult decisions. It simplified life because it gave me a better way to make them.

Before E4, life often felt overwhelming. Everything seemed equally urgent. Everything demanded attention. Everything felt important. Eventually I discovered something: just because a thing is urgent doesn't mean it's important. That single insight changed the way I organized my days. I stopped allowing my calendar to determine my priorities and started insisting that my priorities determine my calendar. There's a tremendous difference between the two. Through most of my adult life, my schedule owned me. Now I wanted to steward my schedule instead.

Time is one of the few resources every person receives equally. Twenty-four hours. No more, no less. The difference isn't how much time we have; it's how intentionally we choose to invest it. That thought challenged me, because I could no longer honestly say, "I don't have time." The better answer usually became, "I haven't made it a priority." That's uncomfortable to admit. It's also incredibly freeing, because priorities can change — one decision at a time.

The more intentionally I lived, the more I noticed another pattern: the four pillars constantly influenced one another. When I neglected my health, my patience became shorter. When my patience became shorter, my relationships suffered. When my relationships suffered, my thinking often turned negative. And when my thinking turned negative, my decisions usually followed it down. Everything remained connected.

The opposite was also true. When I took care of my body, I showed up differently at home. When I invested in learning, I became a better leader. When my relationships grew stronger, life

became more meaningful. When I faithfully stewarded what I'd been entrusted with, peace quietly replaced anxiety. None of the pillars stood alone, and that's exactly why the framework worked for me. It reminded me that life isn't lived in compartments; it's lived as one connected story. The stronger the foundation became, the steadier everything resting upon it became.

One of the greatest misconceptions about personal growth is that balance means giving every area exactly the same amount of attention. Life doesn't work that way. Some seasons require more attention in one pillar than another. A newborn baby changes your priorities. A health crisis changes your priorities. Losing a job changes your priorities. Balance isn't treating every pillar equally every day. Balance is refusing to permanently neglect any of them.

That perspective removed another burden I had quietly carried. I stopped chasing perfection and started pursuing faithfulness. Faithfulness has become one of my favorite words because it's attainable. I may not perform perfectly today, but I can be faithful today. I may not solve every problem today, but I can take the next faithful step today. I may not reach every goal this year, but I can faithfully become the man this season requires. That's enough. More than enough. Because I've learned something that continues giving me peace: God has never asked me to be perfect. He has asked me to be faithful.

And faithfulness quietly compounds.

* * *

The longer I lived with the four pillars, the more something else sank in. The framework wasn't changing my life. My daily decisions were. The framework did nothing more than remind me where to focus, and that's an important distinction. It's easy to believe another planner, another journal, another app, or another system will finally change our lives. None of them can. Tools never create discipline. People do. A framework only has value if it leads to action; otherwise, it's just another good idea sitting on a shelf. I had accumulated plenty of those over the years. The difference this time was simple: I was finally living it. Not perfectly. Consistently.

One ordinary decision after another.

One thing I noticed almost immediately was how much easier decisions became. Life hadn't gotten any less complicated — my values had gotten clearer. Every opportunity no longer received the same answer. Some opportunities deserved a "yes." Others deserved a "no." That was difficult for me at first, because I had spent a long stretch of my life believing every opportunity needed to be pursued, every invitation needed to be accepted, every door needed to be opened. Experience taught me otherwise.

Every "yes" is also a "no" to something else. Say yes to another meeting, and you may be saying no to dinner with your family. Say yes to another business opportunity, and you may be saying no to your health. Say yes to constant distraction, and you may be saying no to becoming the person you actually want to be. That truth taught me something I wish I had learned much earlier: not every opportunity deserves access to your life. Discernment became just as important as discipline. Some of the best decisions I've ever made were the opportunities I chose not to pursue. Years ago, I would have measured success by how many doors opened. Today, I measure success by having the wisdom to walk through the right ones.

The same became true with relationships. Not every relationship deserves the same level of influence. Some people encourage growth; others quietly pull you backward. That doesn't mean you stop loving people. It means you become intentional about whose voices shape your thinking. Every one of us is being influenced — by friends, by social media, by news, by coworkers, by family, by culture. The question isn't whether we're influenced. The question is whether we're choosing those influences intentionally.

That thought challenged me deeply, because for far too long I had allowed almost anyone to influence my emotions. One headline could ruin my attitude. One difficult customer could determine my mood. One negative comment could dominate my thoughts for days. Then the truth finally landed: not every voice deserves equal volume. That may be one of the healthiest boundaries I've ever learned. Protect what enters your mind. Protect who speaks into your life. Protect what repeatedly shapes your thinking. Because your thoughts eventually become your decisions, your decisions eventually become your habits, and your habits quietly become your character.

And character becomes your life.

The more intentional I became with those choices, the more peaceful my life became. It wasn't that life stopped being difficult. It was that I finally stopped giving everything permission to steal my peace.

* * *

One of the most freeing discoveries I've made is that life becomes much simpler when your values become non-negotiable. Notice I didn't say life becomes easier. It doesn't. It becomes clearer. For longer than I'd like to admit, every decision felt exhausting because everything seemed equally important. Should I work a little longer? Should I take another call? Should I answer another email? Should I squeeze one more thing into an already full day? Every decision became another negotiation. Eventually it hit me that I wasn't suffering from a lack of time. I was suffering from a lack of clarity.

Once I became clear about who I wanted to become, many of those negotiations disappeared. The answer had already been decided. If something moved me closer to becoming that man, it deserved my attention. If it pulled me away from that man, it probably deserved a "no." That doesn't mean I always get it right — far from it. It means I have a compass now. Compasses don't eliminate storms; they keep you moving in the right direction. That's exactly what the four pillars became for me. Not a checklist. A compass.

There are still days when I get distracted. Days when work demands more than I planned. Days when I become impatient. Days when I miss something important. The difference today is that I recognize it much faster. Awareness shortens recovery. Years ago, I might have drifted for months before realizing I was off course. Now it might take a day. Sometimes an hour. Sometimes only a conversation with my wife. Growth doesn't eliminate mistakes; it shortens the distance between the mistake and the correction. That's encouraging, because perfection was never the goal. Faithfulness still is.

One of the greatest gifts this framework has given me is permission to honestly evaluate my life — not to criticize myself, but to recalibrate. Pilots don't get embarrassed when they make course corrections. They just make them. Continually. That's how they arrive at their destination. Life works much the same way. Very few people live perfectly aligned every single day. The people who continue growing are the ones willing to make corrections sooner.

That thought removed another burden from my shoulders. I no longer viewed setbacks as failure. I began seeing them as feedback. Feedback tells us where to adjust. Failure tells us to quit. Those are very different messages. One produces hope; the other produces shame. I've lived under both. Hope is a much better teacher.

As I've reflected on this long road, one truth continues returning to me: God has never expected me to become someone else. He's been inviting me to become the person He created me to be all along. That's a beautiful difference. I'm not trying to copy another husband, another father, another businessman, another runner. I'm learning to faithfully become the man God uniquely designed me to become. Understanding that brought tremendous freedom. Comparison slowly disappeared, and purpose quietly took its place. The four pillars never asked me to become someone else. They just kept pointing me back toward the man I was always capable of becoming.

And every morning, I still ask the same question: Who do I have to become today? The answer continues changing. The question never does. That's why I believe becoming is a lifelong journey, not a destination.

One ordinary day lived faithfully becomes another step toward the life you were created to live.

* * *

One question I get asked fairly often is, "What happens if you miss a day?" The answer surprises people. I don't. It isn't fear of losing a streak that keeps me going; it's that I already made the decision. People often assume the streak is what motivates me. It isn't. The streak is nothing more than evidence of a decision I made a long time ago. If I ever stop, it won't be because I accidentally forgot. It will be because I intentionally chose to become someone different. That distinction matters.

One morning, my wife asked me a simple question. "Would anyone even know if you skipped today?" I smiled. Probably not. Unless I told someone, nobody would know. There wasn't a referee standing outside my house. There wasn't a camera following me. There wasn't an app sending notifications to the world. I could quietly skip a day and almost nobody would ever notice. Then another thought immediately followed.

I would know.

That became enough. Integrity has very little to do with what other people see. Integrity is about the promises you keep when nobody else is watching. That's why one of the notes on my mirror has stayed there all these years: Your integrity is more important than what you sell. At first, I wrote those words because of my career. Today, they influence every part of my life. Integrity isn't something I turn on at work. It's who I become at home. It's who I become when I'm traveling. It's who I become on vacation. It's who I become when nobody would ever know the difference.

I've learned that integrity compounds just like excuses once did. Every promise kept strengthens it; every promise broken weakens it. Neither happens all at once. Little by little, we become the person our daily decisions are creating.

Seeing that changed the way I looked at success. Success stopped being something other people measured. Success became something I measured in the mirror. Did I keep my word today? Did I love my family well today? Did I leave people better than I found them today? Did I steward what God entrusted to me today? Those questions matter much more to me than trophies or titles, because titles eventually change. Integrity stays.

I've also noticed something interesting. The more faithfully I keep promises to myself, the easier it becomes to keep promises to others. Trust grows in every direction. That's one of the reasons I believe integrity sits underneath every pillar we've discussed. Energy requires integrity. Education requires integrity. Empathy requires integrity. Stewardship requires integrity. Without

integrity, the entire framework eventually begins to wobble. With integrity, everything else becomes stronger. Not perfect. Stronger.

The more I thought about that, the more I recognized something my father had quietly modeled my entire life. Integrity usually isn't loud. It's quiet. It's showing up. Doing the work. Keeping your word. Going home. Doing it again tomorrow. That's exactly how he lived. It's exactly how my grandfather lived. And today, it's exactly the kind of man I'm still trying to become. Because if this entire book could be reduced to one sentence, it might be this:

Become the kind of person who keeps promises.

Everything else grows from there.

* * *

The framework eventually taught me one final lesson. Simple doesn't mean easy. In fact, the simplest principles are often the hardest to consistently live. Drink more water. Move your body. Tell the truth. Keep your word. Read something worthwhile. Put your phone down. Be present. Forgive. Save money. Pray. None of those ideas are complicated. Living them every single day — that's where the challenge begins.

I think we've convinced ourselves that complicated solutions must somehow be better. They're usually not. Complicated often becomes another excuse. If the system is complicated enough, we can always blame the system. Simple removes that option. Simple leaves us with one question: Will I do it? That's why I love simplicity. Simplicity exposes commitment.

I often think about my grandmother tending her roses. Nothing about it was complicated. She just cared for them, every day. She watered them. Pruned them. Protected them. Over time, the garden became beautiful. Marriage works that way. Parenting works that way. Health works that way. Faith works that way. Character works that way. The extraordinary is usually hidden inside ordinary faithfulness, one day after another.

I've come to believe that becoming isn't really about becoming someone entirely new. It's about removing everything that was preventing you from becoming who God created you to be in the first place. That perspective changed the way I looked at growth. Growth stopped feeling like pressure and started feeling like freedom. Freedom from excuses. Freedom from lies. Freedom from comparison. Freedom from constantly chasing someone else's definition of success. Instead, I found myself becoming increasingly grateful for the life God had already placed in front of me. Not perfect. Just mine.

One question continued guiding me through every season: Who do I have to become today? Not forever. Today. Today's husband. Today's father. Today's steward. Today's leader. Today's friend. Today's disciple. Today's version of Randall. Tomorrow will ask different things of me, and tomorrow deserves tomorrow's attention. Today deserves mine.

That one perspective has brought more peace into my life than almost anything else I've learned, because becoming doesn't happen someday. It happens today. Then tomorrow. Then the day after that. Quietly. Faithfully. One decision at a time. One promise at a time. One ordinary day lived with extraordinary intention.

The framework eventually gave me direction. Running gave me discipline. My family gave me purpose. God gave me grace. Everything else has been learning to faithfully steward those gifts. The road continues every morning when I lace up my shoes, every morning when I look in the mirror, every morning when I ask the same question: Who do I have to become today? I hope I never stop asking it, because I hope I never stop becoming.

The four pillars gave me a foundation. What happened next gave them a purpose. They were never meant to stay with me. They were meant to be shared. That's where this journey begins turning outward.

Because becoming isn't only about changing your own life. It's about helping someone else believe they can change theirs too.

CHAPTER 12

Shine Your Light

One of the unexpected things that happened as my life began changing was that people started asking questions. It wasn't that I had all the answers — it was that they noticed something was different. Some asked about the running streak. Others asked about the weight I'd lost. Some wanted to know why I looked happier. Others just asked, "What's changed?"

At first, those questions made me uncomfortable. It wasn't that I didn't want to answer them; I wasn't sure my story was worth telling. Who was I to encourage someone else? I wasn't a millionaire. I wasn't famous. I wasn't a pastor. I wasn't a nutritionist. I wasn't someone who had life completely figured out. I was nothing more than a man who had stopped lying to himself.

The more I thought about it, though, the more something dawned on me. Maybe that's exactly who people need to hear from — not someone pretending to have a perfect life, but someone willing to honestly talk about an imperfect one.

That truth changed everything.

For years I had hidden behind a mask. Now I felt God gently asking me to take it off — not for attention, but for freedom. One conversation at a time, I began sharing pieces of my story. The abuse. The restaurant. The alcohol. The depression. The rocking chair. The running streak. The becoming.

I expected judgment. Instead, something remarkable happened. People began sharing their stories with me — stories they had never told anyone else. Stories of addiction, depression, broken marriages, financial struggles, anxiety, childhood trauma. The more vulnerable I became, the more permission other people seemed to feel to become vulnerable too.

That taught me something I will never forget. Vulnerability is contagious. So is courage. When one person finally tells the truth, it often gives another person permission to do the same. That's one of the reasons I believe silence can be so dangerous. Silence convinces us we're alone. Truth reminds us we're not. Through a long stretch of my life I believed I was the only one fighting the battles inside my own head. I wasn't. I just couldn't see everyone else carrying theirs.

The more conversations I had, the more one thing became clear to me: people are desperate for authenticity. Not perfection. Authenticity. The world doesn't need another polished image. It needs more honest people — people willing to say, "I'm struggling." "I need help." "I don't have everything figured out." Ironically, those conversations almost always create deeper strength than pretending ever could.

That's why I believe your story matters. Its value has nothing to do with whether every detail is unique; it matters because someone else is living a chapter you've already survived. You may become the proof they desperately need that another ending is possible — not because you're extraordinary, but because you're willing to be honest.

That's where light begins. Not through perfection. Through truth.

One of the greatest fears people carry is the fear of being seen — not physically, emotionally. We spend an incredible amount of energy trying to convince the world we're okay, and social media has made that even easier. We post the vacation. The promotion. The race medal. The smiling family picture. Very few people post the panic attack, the marriage that's struggling, the loneliness, the sleepless nights, the fear. I'm not criticizing social media. I'm only saying it rarely tells the whole story.

For years, my smile told one story while my heart told another. Nobody knew I was sitting in a rocking chair wondering if my family would somehow be better off without me. Nobody knew I was using alcohol to quiet anxiety I didn't know how to face. Nobody knew how exhausted I had become pretending everything was fine. That's one of the reasons I believe masks are so dangerous. The longer we wear them, the harder they become to remove. Eventually, we forget they're even there.

One conversation changed that for me. I was sharing a small part of my story with another man, and when I finished, he looked at me and quietly said, "I thought I was the only one."

I'll never forget those words, and not for their uniqueness — I've heard them over and over again ever since. "I thought I was the only one." People aren't nearly as alone as they believe they are. They're suffering in silence. Silence gives shame room to grow. Truth takes that room away.

That doesn't mean we tell everyone everything. Wisdom still matters. Discernment still matters. Healthy boundaries still matter. But every one of us needs someone with whom we can remove the mask — someone who knows the real story, someone who loves us enough to tell us the truth, someone who reminds us who we are when we've temporarily forgotten.

One of the greatest gifts God has ever given me has been people willing to have those conversations. My wife. My coaches. Close friends. Men who challenged me, men who

encouraged me, men who refused to let me settle. Those conversations didn't always feel comfortable — growth rarely does. But they felt honest, and honesty became one of the greatest expressions of love I've ever experienced.

That's one of the reasons I believe your light grows brighter every time you choose truth over image. Vulnerability doesn't earn admiration; it builds connection. People don't connect with perfection. They connect with honesty. The more I shared my struggles, the more I noticed something remarkable. People weren't inspired by my success. They were encouraged by my willingness to admit where I had failed. That surprised me. I thought people wanted polished. They wanted real.

Understanding that changed the reason I began telling my story. I stopped trying to impress people. I simply wanted to encourage them. Because if God could rebuild my life, maybe someone else could begin believing He could rebuild theirs too.

As those conversations continued, I began noticing something I had completely overlooked for most of my life. Pain has a remarkable way of convincing us that our story ends with us. Healing does the exact opposite. Healing reminds us that our story was never only about us.

Every difficult season I'd walked through suddenly had a different purpose. The abuse. The restaurant. The lawsuits. The depression. The alcohol. The running. None of it had been wasted. That isn't to say those experiences were good — they weren't. But God has a remarkable ability to redeem things that were never good to begin with. That's one of the greatest miracles I've witnessed in my own life. He didn't erase my past. He repurposed it. There's a tremendous difference.

If someone asked me today whether I would relive those painful years, the answer would still be no. I wouldn't wish those experiences on anyone. But if they asked whether I would remove what God has done through them, the answer would also be no. Because those painful chapters created opportunities to reach people I never could have reached otherwise.

I've sat across from men battling alcohol. I've talked with fathers who quietly believed they had failed their families. I've listened to people convinced they were beyond hope. Again and again, I've watched something remarkable happen. The instant they realize someone else understands, their shoulders relax. It isn't that all of their problems disappear — it's that they finally stop carrying them alone.

I think that's one of the reasons God rarely wastes pain. Someone else is eventually going to need what you've learned. Not your perfection. Your testimony. The older I become, the less interested I am in protecting my image. I'd much rather protect someone else's hope. If sharing one difficult

chapter from my life gives another person the courage to begin rewriting theirs, then every uncomfortable conversation becomes worth it.

That's why I believe your story has value — not because it's dramatic, but because it's honest. People don't need another superhero. They need another human being, someone willing to admit, "I've been there too." That simple sentence has opened more meaningful conversations than anything else I've ever said. It doesn't remove another person's pain; it removes isolation. Isolation convinces us we're uniquely broken. Community reminds us we're not.

One of the greatest lies I believed for far too long was that asking for help somehow meant I was weak. Now I believe the opposite. Asking for help often requires more courage than pretending you're okay. Strength isn't hiding your wounds. Strength is refusing to let those wounds define the rest of your life. That's a completely different way to live.

The more I thought about shining your light, the more one truth kept surfacing. Light never argues with darkness. It just shows up. Darkness doesn't have to be chased away; it disappears the instant light arrives. Truth works exactly the same way. Hope works exactly the same way. Love works exactly the same way. That's why I no longer feel responsible for changing people. I only want to faithfully shine the light God has placed inside me. He'll take care of the rest.

One image has stayed with me throughout this entire road. A candle. If you light another candle from it, the first candle loses nothing. It doesn't become dimmer. It doesn't become weaker. The room just becomes brighter. I think our lives work much the same way.

Some people spend their entire lives protecting their light — afraid someone else might receive the credit, afraid someone else might become more successful, afraid someone else's success somehow diminishes their own. I've learned the opposite is true. Helping someone else shine never makes your own light smaller. It multiplies it.

That's become one of the greatest joys of my life. Watching someone else begin believing again. Watching someone else quit making excuses. Watching someone else become present with their family. Watching someone else begin asking, "Who do I have to become?" Those experiences have become far more meaningful to me than personal accomplishments ever were. Because accomplishments eventually become memories. People become legacies.

I've thought about legacy quite a bit over the years. When I was younger, I thought legacy meant leaving behind something impressive — a successful business, financial security, recognition. Today I think legacy is much simpler. Legacy is who continues becoming because you chose to become first.

My daughters are part of my legacy, and it isn't anything they'll accomplish that makes them so. It's the example they watched every single day. They're watching how I speak to their mother. They're watching whether I keep my word. They're watching whether I apologize when I'm wrong. They're watching whether my faith is something I merely talk about or something I actually live. Children are incredible observers. They notice consistency long before they understand principles.

That thought has challenged me more than almost anything else, because it reminds me that leadership always begins at home. If my daughters never remember how many miles I ran, I hope they remember that their dad kept his word. If they never remember the ultramarathon, I hope they remember that I showed up. If they never remember another accomplishment, I hope they remember feeling loved. Everything else is secondary.

One day, long after this book has been forgotten, long after someone else has broken my running streak, long after another person has run farther or faster, the people closest to me will still remember how I lived. That thought keeps me grounded. It reminds me that significance is usually found in ordinary faithfulness, not extraordinary moments. One ordinary day lived with integrity, repeated often enough, eventually becomes a life that quietly points other people toward hope.

That's what I want my life to do. Not point people toward me. Point them toward the God who patiently rebuilt me. Because if there's anything worthwhile about my story, it's not that I finally figured life out. It's that God never gave up on me while I was still trying to.

That's the light I hope people see. Not mine. His.

And if my story encourages even one person to believe that another chapter is still possible, then every difficult chapter I lived through becomes worth telling.

Chapter 13 ## The Ripple Effect

One of the most surprising things about becoming is that it rarely stays with you. It spreads. At first, I thought this road was only about changing my own life. Quitting drinking. Becoming healthier. Being more present. Keeping promises. Learning to steward what God had entrusted to me. I thought those changes were personal. Then I began watching something happen that I never expected.

Other people started changing too.

It wasn't that I convinced them of anything. They watched consistency. That's one of the remarkable things about integrity: you never have to announce it. People notice. Not immediately, but over time. The same way excuses quietly compound, integrity quietly compounds too. One conversation becomes another. One example becomes another. One decision quietly influences another person to make one of their own. I don't think we appreciate how powerful that really is.

Every one of us is influencing someone. The question isn't whether we're leading. The question is where we're leading them. That thought challenged me deeply, because leadership isn't a title. Leadership is influence. Parents influence. Teachers influence. Coaches influence. Managers influence. Friends influence. Even strangers influence. Every interaction quietly leaves something behind — hope, discouragement, truth, fear, encouragement, or excuses. We're constantly planting seeds, whether we realize it or not.

One morning during a run, I found myself thinking about a single domino. By itself, it doesn't seem very significant. Small. Unremarkable. Easy to overlook. But tip it over and it hits the next one. Then the next. Eventually, something that began with one small movement creates momentum far beyond itself. Life works the same way. One difficult conversation may save a marriage. One encouraging word may keep someone from giving up. One honest story may convince another person they're not alone. One decision to become healthier may completely change the future your children inherit. The ripple almost always becomes larger than the stone that created it.

That's one of the reasons I stopped asking, "How will this affect me?" and started asking, "Who else might this affect?" Those are very different questions. The first focuses on personal benefit. The second focuses on legacy.

Legacy begins much earlier than most people think. It doesn't begin after we're gone. It begins every morning we choose how we're going to live. Every promise we keep. Every apology we

make. Every difficult conversation we refuse to avoid. Every act of kindness no one else ever notices. Those small moments become someone else's example, whether we intended them to or not.

Understanding that filled me with both humility and hope. Humility, because I recognized how often people had quietly influenced me. Hope, because maybe my own ordinary decisions could eventually encourage someone else — not because they're extraordinary, but because they're honest. Honesty gives people permission to stop pretending.

And pretending has stolen enough lives already.

* * *

One truth kept returning to me as I watched those ripples spread: you never know who's watching. For a long stretch, I assumed nobody noticed the everyday choices I was making. The early morning runs. The books. The conversations. The quiet decisions to keep my word. I couldn't have been more wrong. People notice consistency. They may not say anything. They may never mention it. But they notice.

I think about my daughters often when I consider that truth. Children are always watching — not just when we think they're paying attention. Always. They're watching how we speak to our spouse and how we respond when life doesn't go our way. They're watching whether we tell the truth, whether we apologize, whether we keep our promises, whether our actions match our words. That's both a tremendous responsibility and an incredible opportunity, because children rarely become what we tell them. They usually become what we consistently show them.

That truth challenged me more than almost anything else. There were plenty of days when I didn't feel like running. There were mornings when the weather was miserable. There were business trips, vacations, long workdays. Excuses never completely disappeared. They just stopped making decisions for me.

Some mornings, before I walked out the door, one of my daughters would ask, "Dad, are you going running?" I always smiled, because eventually the answer became obvious. Of course I am. Not because I had to — because that's who I had become. They weren't merely watching a running streak. They were watching integrity, and that matters much more. One day they'll forget how many consecutive days I ran. I hope they never forget what consistency looked like.

The same is true in every area of life. People may not remember our speeches, but they remember our example. Examples quietly outlive words. That's why leadership has become so important to me — not leadership through position, but leadership through example. Anybody can tell another person what they should do. Living it? That's different. The older I become, the

less interested I am in convincing people. I'd rather quietly show them. Not because I do it perfectly, but because consistency has a way of speaking for itself.

I've discovered something beautiful about becoming. When you're focused on faithfully living your own life, you rarely realize how many other people are quietly gathering courage from yours. That isn't pressure. It's purpose. Every small decision has the potential to become someone else's permission. Permission to begin. Permission to hope. Permission to tell the truth. Permission to stop making excuses. You may never know whose life your consistency is encouraging, and that's okay. Seeds are planted long before harvest ever appears.

That's how my grandmother lived. That's how my father lived. That's how every mentor who's impacted my life has lived. Quietly. Faithfully. Consistently. One ordinary day after another. Now I can see that none of those people were trying to become famous. They were only trying to become faithful. Ironically, that's exactly why their influence continues long after the day itself has passed.

* * *

As I continued thinking about influence, another question quietly found its way into my morning runs. What if the greatest impact of my life isn't something I'll ever personally see? That thought humbled me. We're naturally drawn toward immediate results. We like finishing projects, crossing finish lines, checking boxes, seeing progress. Influence rarely works that way. Influence usually unfolds slowly — sometimes over years, sometimes over generations. Think about the people who have influenced your own life.

My grandmother probably never imagined I'd still be talking about her rose garden decades later. My father probably never realized that a little boy riding beside him while checking cattle was learning far more than ranching. He was learning consistency. Responsibility. Faithfulness. He wasn't trying to create life lessons; he was living them. That's what made them so powerful. Authenticity always carries more influence than performance.

The same became true with my daughters. There were mornings when they saw me leave before sunrise for another run. Other mornings they saw me come home tired after a long day of work and still lace up my shoes because I hadn't run yet. They weren't listening to another lecture about commitment. They were watching it.

That understanding changed the way I looked at parenting. Children don't need parents who constantly tell them what matters. They need parents willing to show them. The older I become, the more convinced I am that our children are studying us far more than they're listening to us. They're studying how we respond to disappointment and how we handle conflict. How we treat

waiters. How we speak about people who aren't in the room. How we love our spouse. How we handle stress. How we keep promises. That's why becoming matters so much. Whether we realize it or not, someone is always learning from the way we live.

One day I asked myself another question. If my daughters become exactly like me, would I be proud of that?

That question stopped me — not because I immediately loved the answer, but because it forced me to become brutally honest. There was a season of my life when I wouldn't have wanted that. I wouldn't have wanted them carrying anxiety the way I carried it. I wouldn't have wanted them believing lies the way I believed them. I wouldn't have wanted them using alcohol the way I did. That truth hurt. It also became one of the greatest motivations for change. I wasn't just rebuilding my life anymore. I was changing what my daughters would one day believe was normal.

That's legacy. Not leaving your children more money — leaving them a better example. Money eventually gets spent. Character continues growing long after we're gone. That's the inheritance I hope to leave behind. Not perfection, but faithfulness. Not extraordinary accomplishments, but ordinary integrity. Not a father who had life figured out, but a father who never stopped becoming. If that's what my daughters remember, I'll consider my life incredibly successful.

Because the ripple doesn't stop with them. One day, it may quietly continue through their children. And theirs. That's how one small decision, one everyday promise, one ordinary life can eventually influence generations.

* * *

The more I reflected on legacy, the more something became clear to me. Most people overestimate what they can accomplish in a year — and underestimate what God can do through a faithful life over decades. I know I certainly did. Through much of my life I wanted dramatic breakthroughs. Big moments. Life-changing opportunities. Now I find myself appreciating average Tuesdays. Regular dinners around the table. Everyday conversations with my wife. Routine runs before the sun comes up. Because I've learned something: ordinary moments are where life actually happens. The milestones exist to remind us to appreciate them.

One of the greatest compliments anyone has ever given me wasn't about work. It wasn't about running. It wasn't about finishing an ultramarathon. Someone once told me, "You're the same person in private that you are in public." I don't remember exactly where I was when they said it, but I remember exactly how it made me feel. Grateful. Because years earlier, that wouldn't have been true. I had become very good at wearing masks. Now I wanted nothing more than for my public life to match my private one. Not perfectly. Honestly.

Integrity has a remarkable way of simplifying life. When you're no longer pretending, you no longer have to remember which version of yourself you presented to different people. You just become yourself. That freedom is difficult to describe until you've experienced it.

I don't want my daughters to remember me as the man who ran every day; I hope they remember me as the man who kept showing up. I don't want them to remember me because I finished an ultramarathon; I hope they remember that I finished what I started. I don't want them to remember another accomplishment. I hope they remember the unremarkable evenings. The conversations. The laughter. The ski trips. The vacations. The times when Dad was fully present. Because presence has become one of the greatest demonstrations of love I know.

The more I think about influence, the less interested I become in building something people remember. I'd much rather build people. Businesses eventually close. Awards gather dust. Trophies eventually end up in storage boxes. But people — people carry your influence long after you're gone. That's why I no longer believe success is measured by what you leave behind. I believe it's measured by who continues becoming because you chose to become first.

If one father becomes more present because he read this book, that's success. If one husband chooses honesty over another excuse, that's success. If one young person asks, "Who do I have to become?" before making another decision, that's success. If one person decides their story isn't over yet, then every difficult chapter I lived becomes worthwhile.

I don't know who will eventually read these words. I don't know what chapter of life they'll be in. I don't know what burdens they're carrying. But I know this: hope has a remarkable way of multiplying. One honest conversation can change a family. One family can influence a community. One community can influence generations. Every ripple begins exactly the same way. One person decides to become. Then another. Then another.

That's why I believe shining your light has very little to do with being noticed. It has everything to do with faithfully living the life God has entrusted to you. The light isn't ours to create. It's only ours to carry. And the beautiful thing about light is this: it never runs out by being shared. It just makes the world a little brighter for the next person still trying to find their way.

* * *

One question has stayed with me ever since I began sharing my story. What if the greatest impact of your life is something you'll never personally see? I think about that often. My grandmother never lived to see me write this book. She never knew how many times I'd think about her rose garden while out on a run. She probably never imagined that decades later I'd still be talking

about the quiet way she loved people. She wasn't trying to leave a legacy. She was living faithfully, nothing more.

My father probably never realized that a little boy riding beside him while checking cattle, stopping at the bank, repairing fences, or spending an afternoon at the accountant's office wasn't just learning about work. He was learning integrity. Responsibility. Consistency. Presence. He wasn't giving speeches. He was giving an example.

That's the thing about influence: the strongest examples are usually the quietest. Very few people intentionally set out to change generations. They choose to become faithful in the small moments instead. One conversation. One promise. One act of kindness. One difficult truth spoken with love. Then they repeat it tomorrow. I've come to believe that's how God usually works — not only through dramatic breakthroughs, but through everyday people who faithfully keep showing up.

That understanding has changed the way I define significance. I no longer ask, "Will people remember my name?" I find myself asking, "Will someone love their family better because our paths crossed?" "Will someone tell the truth because I finally told mine?" "Will someone decide not to quit because they learned I almost did?" Those questions matter much more to me. Because names are eventually forgotten. Lives changed continue changing other lives. That's a legacy worth pursuing.

I don't know where this book will eventually go. I don't know who will read it, or what chapter of life they'll be living when they do. Maybe someone will be sitting in a hotel room wondering if anything can change. Maybe someone will be standing in front of a mirror avoiding their own reflection. Maybe someone will be quietly carrying lies they've believed since childhood. Maybe someone will just need hope. If that's you, I want you to hear something I wish someone had told me long ago.

Your story is not over.

The chapter you're living today is exactly that — a chapter. Not the entire book. Don't confuse your current season with your final destination. I did that longer than I'd like to admit. I believed the restaurant defined me. It didn't. I believed alcohol defined me. It didn't. I believed childhood trauma defined me. It didn't. They became chapters. Important chapters. Painful chapters. Necessary chapters. But they were never the ending. The ending is still being written.

So is yours.

That's why I believe shining your light is much simpler than most people think. Tell the truth. Love people well. Keep your promises. Remain teachable. Point people toward hope whenever

you have the opportunity. You don't have to change the entire world. You may only need to change one person's day. Then trust God with the ripple. Because He has always been much better at multiplying quiet faithfulness than we could ever imagine.

CHAPTER 14

The Road Ahead

If you've made it this far, I want to tell you something: I'm proud of you. It isn't the fact that you've finished another chapter that makes me say it. What makes me say it is that somewhere along the way, I believe you've probably started asking yourself different questions than the ones you walked in with. That's the goal of this whole book. Not agreement. Awareness.

When I began writing this book, I never wanted you to walk away trying to become another version of me. The world doesn't need another Randall; it already has one. What the world needs is the version of you that only you can become. That's why I've intentionally resisted telling you exactly what your life should look like. I can't answer that question for you. Only you can answer it. I don't know your story. I don't know your wounds. I don't know what you've survived, and I don't know what you're carrying with you today.

But I do know this much. Every one of us eventually arrives at the same intersection, and the roads that meet there are always the same. Excuses, or ownership. Reaction, or intention. Comfort, or growth. Those are the choices waiting for all of us. Nobody can choose that direction for you. Your spouse can't choose it. Your parents can't. Your coach can't, your pastor can't, and this book can't either. Eventually you're the one standing in front of the mirror. You're the one answering the questions. You're the one deciding who you're becoming. That is both the greatest responsibility and the greatest freedom any of us will ever receive in this life.

Through a long stretch of my life I wanted someone else to rescue me. I wanted someone else to fix my problems. I wanted someone else to tell me exactly what to do. Eventually the truth landed on me. God had already given me everything I needed to begin. Not every answer — just the next step. That's all He's ever really promised any of us: enough light for the next step, never the entire staircase all at once. Faith has always worked that way.

The remarkable thing is that the next step rarely feels extraordinary. Almost every time, it feels ordinary instead. It looks like making the phone call. It looks like having the conversation, taking the walk, reading the chapter. Apologizing to someone you've hurt. Lacing up your shoes.

Turning off the television. Putting down the bottle. Telling yourself the truth. Ordinary decisions, repeated often enough over time, eventually become extraordinary lives.

That's exactly how my own life changed. There was no one massive breakthrough that solved everything; unremarkable faithfulness quietly compounded instead. Again. And again. And again. The same thing can happen for you, and it won't happen by making your story look like mine. It shouldn't look like mine. Your story will look like yours, and that's exactly the point. This book isn't asking you to copy my life. It's inviting you to honestly examine your own. Ask better questions. Tell yourself the truth. Keep today's promise. Then wake up tomorrow and repeat it all over again.

That's where becoming begins. It always has begun there, and it always will.

There is one thing I want to make absolutely clear before we go any farther. This book is not asking you to become me. I don't want that, and I mean it. My road is my road, and yours will be different. Your starting line will be different. Your obstacles will be different. Your gifts will be different. Your calling will be different too. If all you take away from these pages is that you should run every day, you've completely missed the point of the whole book. Running was never the answer. Running was only my vehicle. For someone else, the vehicle might be walking. It might be lifting weights. It might be learning a new skill, or rebuilding a marriage. It might be getting sober. It might be returning to church. It might be nothing more than making the one phone call you've been avoiding longer than you'd like to admit.

The action itself isn't what matters most. The commitment behind it does. That's why I keep returning to the same question: Who do I have to become? Not: What do I have to accomplish? Accomplishments eventually come to an end. Identity keeps growing.

One of the greatest mistakes I made through all those years was believing that success would finally be the thing that changed me. Now I know something very different. Becoming changes success, and not the other way around. The man I had to become in order to rebuild my life would have handled the restaurant differently. He would have handled pressure differently. He would have handled alcohol differently, and he would have handled relationships differently too. That's why becoming always comes first. Everything else grows from there.

If someone asked me today what the greatest lesson from this entire road has been, I don't think I'd talk about the ultramarathon. I don't think I'd talk about the running streak, or even the restaurant. I'd probably say this instead: the life you've always wanted is usually waiting on the other side of the person you're willing to become. That one sentence summarizes the whole path better than almost anything else I could write.

I spent year after year trying to change my circumstances. God spent those same years patiently changing me. Only now can I fully appreciate the difference between those two things. If my circumstances had changed before my character did, I probably would have repeated many of the same mistakes all over again. Instead, God changed the foundation first, and only then did He begin changing what rested upon it.

When I survey my own life from where I stand today, I can clearly see His fingerprints — not only in the victories, but in the valleys too. The abuse. The restaurant. The lawsuits. The depression. The rocking chair. The hotel room. The pandemic. The running. Every chapter of my life carried something forward, and none of it was wasted. That wasn't because every chapter was good. Plenty of them weren't. It's because God is. That's the difference.

I don't claim to understand every painful thing that's happened in my life. I probably never will understand it all. But I do know this: I've watched Him repeatedly create purpose from pain, hope from heartbreak, strength from weakness, and light from darkness. That's why I no longer ask, "Why me?" The better question has become, "God... who can I serve because I walked through this?"

That question changed everything for me. It shifted my focus away from my own wounds and toward someone else's healing.

As I've reflected on everything you've read so far, it has become clear to me that there are really only two ways to live. You can spend your life reacting, or you can spend your life preparing. I know both of those lives well, because I've lived both of them. I spent a long season reacting — reacting to childhood wounds, reacting to financial pressure, reacting to business failure, reacting to anxiety, reacting to alcohol, reacting to circumstances I believed were controlling me. Eventually I discovered something that completely changed my perspective: preparation is one of the greatest expressions of hope there is. People who prepare do it because they believe tomorrow is worth preparing for.

That may seem obvious. It wasn't obvious to me. When I believed my life wasn't going to change, I stopped preparing. I stopped investing in myself. I stopped believing the future deserved today's effort, and when all of that stopped, hope quietly disappeared from my life. The instant hope returned, preparation returned right along with it. I started reading again. I started training again. I started praying differently, planning differently, and thinking differently. Nobody forced any of it on me. It happened because I finally believed tomorrow could be different, and hope always changes today's decisions.

That's one of the reasons I believe excuses are so dangerous. Excuses steal hope. They convince us that nothing we do today really matters, when in fact the truth is exactly the opposite. Today's

ordinary decisions are quietly building tomorrow's life, whether we recognize it or not. Every promise we keep, every conversation we have, every difficult decision we stop avoiding, every act of integrity — every single one of them becomes another brick in the foundation we're building.

The beautiful thing is that nobody else has to understand your foundation while you're building it. When I started running every day, many people probably thought I was just becoming healthier. They couldn't see what was actually happening beneath the surface. God was rebuilding my integrity. When I started asking, "Who do I have to become?" people probably assumed I was setting goals. They couldn't see what was actually happening there either. God was changing my identity. Most of the greatest work God does in our lives happens long before anyone else ever notices it. That's encouraging, because it means your progress doesn't have to be visible to be real.

So keep becoming. Keep planting. Keep preparing. Keep telling yourself the truth. One day someone will look at your life and think, "You're lucky." They'll see the harvest. What they won't see are the thousands of quiet mornings that produced it. That's okay. The harvest was never the goal in the first place. Faithfulness was.

Faithfulness has become one of my favorite words, because faithfulness is something every one of us can choose today. Not next year. Today. You don't have to run sixty-two miles today. You don't have to write a book. You don't have to transform your entire life before the sun goes down tonight. All you have to do is keep today's promise. That's enough for today. Then tomorrow, keep another one. One day you'll look around and understand something remarkable: you didn't merely accomplish more. You became someone different. And that's a life no accomplishment could ever replace. Becoming has never really been about reaching a destination. It's about faithfully walking the road God places in front of you, wherever that road happens to lead.

One ordinary step at a time.

One final thought before we move into the practical application of everything we've discussed. Please don't read this book looking for another motivational high. Motivation fades. I know that because I've chased it myself. There were whole seasons when I thought one more conference would finally change me. Or one more book. One more podcast. One more breakthrough. Then I'd return home, and life would look exactly the same as it did when I left. The problem was never inspiration. The problem was always implementation. Motivation gets you started. Habits keep you moving. Identity is what determines whether you continue.

That's why I no longer chase emotional highs. I chase plain faithfulness instead. There are still mornings I don't feel like running. There are days I don't feel like having difficult conversations.

There are times I'd much rather choose comfort than growth. Those feelings don't surprise me anymore; they're simply part of being human. The difference today is that my feelings no longer get the final vote. My commitments get that vote now.

One of the greatest freedoms I've ever experienced is discovering that I don't have to negotiate with every emotion that enters my mind. Thoughts come. Feelings come. Excuses come. Not all of them deserve a response from me. Some deserve nothing more than to pass by without permission to stay. When that truth finally sank in, it changed my life, because I had spent so many years believing that every thought was true. Now I know better than that. Truth deserves agreement. Lies deserve replacement.

That's why Scripture has become so important to me. It isn't that reading a few verses magically solves life's problems. It's that truth slowly replaces lies. The lies I heard as a little boy. The lies I repeated to myself as an adult. The lies that eventually led me into that rocking chair. None of those lies disappeared overnight. They were replaced, one truth at a time and one decision at a time.

One ordinary day at a time.

If you're waiting until you feel different before you begin, you'll probably spend a very long time doing nothing but waiting. Begin anyway. Tell yourself the truth anyway. Keep today's promise anyway. The feelings eventually catch up to the life you're building. I've watched it happen too many times to believe anything otherwise. One day you'll wake up and understand something. The person you spent all those years hoping to become has quietly turned into the person looking back at you in the mirror each morning. And it won't be the result of one extraordinary breakthrough. It will be the result of thousands of small decisions that nobody else ever saw.

That's how becoming works. It works quietly. Faithfully. Patiently. One day at a time.

Now... let's make this personal.

CHAPTER 15

Your Turn

For most of this book, you've been walking through my story. Now I want you to begin thinking about yours. Please understand — it isn't that my story is more important than yours, because it isn't. If anything, I hope my story has done nothing more than give you permission to look honestly at your own. That has been my goal from the very beginning. I never set out to convince you to become me. I set out to encourage you to become the person you were created to become.

Only you can answer that question. Only you know where you've been making excuses. Only you know which conversations you've been avoiding. Only you know where you've settled, and only you know what you've been pretending not to see. The remarkable thing is that you don't have to solve your entire life today. You just have to tell yourself the truth.

Truth has become one of my favorite words — not always a comfortable one, but always a freeing one. Excuses cannot survive in the presence of truth. The instant we honestly acknowledge where we are, we finally know where to begin.

For a long stretch of my life, I lied to myself. Not that I wanted to lie — the lies were just easier. "I don't have time." "I'll start Monday." "I work too much." "I deserve another drink." "I'll deal with it later." Those statements felt harmless. They weren't. Every one of them quietly delayed the life I actually wanted.

The hardest conversation you'll ever have may not be with another person. It may be the one you have with yourself. No distractions, no excuses, no one else to blame. Just truth. Where are you really? Not where you pretend to be, and not where everyone else thinks you are. Where are you? That question isn't meant to produce guilt. It's meant to produce clarity. Clarity creates direction. Direction creates momentum. Momentum changes lives.

Everything we've talked about in this book began with one honest admission.

I wasn't okay.

That sentence changed my life. It didn't solve my problems — it finally allowed me to begin solving them. You don't have to have every answer today. You don't have to know exactly what your life will look like five years from now, and you don't have to feel completely confident. You only have to become honest enough to take the next faithful step. That's all I did. One conversation. One decision. One run. One promise. Then another. Then another. Eventually, those everyday decisions became a different life.

They can become yours too. Not because you're extraordinary. Because ordinary faithfulness still works. It always has. It always will.

* * *

Before you turn the page, I want to ask you to do something I wish I had done years earlier. Don't answer these questions quickly, and don't answer them the way you hope they're true. Answer them honestly. Because honesty changes lives. Excuses protect comfort. Truth creates change.

So let me ask you a few questions. What story have you been telling yourself that isn't true anymore? What excuse has quietly become part of your identity? What conversation have you been avoiding? What promise have you continued postponing? What part of your life keeps demanding your attention while you continue pretending not to notice?

Nobody else has to answer those questions. You do. That's where becoming begins — not with another book, not with another coach, not with another motivational speech. With honesty.

One of the greatest mistakes I made was believing awareness alone created change. It doesn't. Awareness only reveals where the work begins. The work still has to be done. The conversation still has to happen. The apology still has to be made. The shoes still have to be laced up. The bottle still has to stay closed. The phone call still has to be made. Knowing isn't enough. Action changes lives.

I've often wondered how different my life would have been if someone had asked me these questions when I was eighteen years old. Or twenty-five. Or thirty. Would I still have opened the restaurant? Probably. Would I still have made mistakes? Absolutely — mistakes are part of becoming. But I don't think I would have spent nearly as many years running from myself.

That's why I wrote this book. It isn't that I have life figured out, because I don't. It isn't that I've stopped growing, because I haven't. I wrote it because I hope someone asks these questions sooner than I did. Maybe you're sixteen. Maybe you're sixty. It honestly doesn't matter. Today is still earlier than tomorrow, and one small decision made today changes every day that follows.

That's the beautiful thing about becoming. You don't have to rewrite your entire life this afternoon. You simply have to stop lying to yourself today. Then tomorrow, tell yourself the truth again. Keep another promise. Take another step. Growth rarely happens all at once. It quietly compounds, just like excuses once did. Only this time, you're compounding something much better: truth, integrity, hope, faithfulness. One ordinary day after another.

And one day you'll look back — not with regret, but with gratitude that you finally decided to begin.

* * *

One final encouragement before we leave this chapter. Please don't become overwhelmed. That's another trap. I've watched people become so discouraged by how far they have to go that they never take the first step. I've done it myself. The distance between where you are and where you want to be can feel enormous. Don't focus on the entire distance. Focus on today's step.

The same principle carried me through every difficult season of my life. The restaurant. The lawsuits. Quitting drinking. Rebuilding my health. The running streak. The ultramarathon. Writing this book. None of those things happened all at once. Every one of them happened exactly the same way. One decision. Then another. Then another.

Progress has a remarkable way of disguising itself as routine. While you're living it, it rarely feels dramatic. Then one day you look behind you and realize you've traveled much farther than you ever imagined. That's one of the reasons I no longer become discouraged by slow progress. Slow progress is still progress, and the direction matters far more than the speed.

I think we spend too much of our lives comparing our Chapter 2 to someone else's Chapter 20. Comparison has a way of stealing gratitude for the ground we've already covered. Don't do that. Your story is yours. Your pace is yours. Your calling is yours. The only life you've been asked to faithfully steward is your own. Run your race. Learn your lessons. Keep your promises. Become your person. One of the greatest gifts you can give yourself is permission to grow without constantly comparing your growth to someone else's. God has never compared my road to yours. I've wasted enough years doing that myself. Not anymore.

One lesson I've learned through running has become one of my favorite reminders. You don't finish sixty-two miles by thinking about mile sixty-two. You finish it by faithfully running mile one. Then mile two. Then mile three. Life works exactly the same way. Today's conversation deserves today's attention. Today's opportunity deserves today's effort. Today's promise deserves today's integrity. Tomorrow will eventually become today, and when it does, keep another promise. That's all becoming has ever asked of me. That's all it will ever ask of you.

Don't wait until you feel ready. Don't wait until life becomes easier. Don't wait until fear disappears.

Begin.

God has an incredible way of meeting us after we take the first faithful step. He certainly did for me, and I believe He'll do the same for you. Because the person you're capable of becoming may be much closer than you think. You just haven't met them yet.

* * *

As you work through the rest of this book, I want to encourage you to resist one temptation. Don't merely admire these ideas. Live them. I've spent year after year reading books that inspired me for a few days. Then life returned to normal, and nothing changed. The ideas weren't the problem — the problem was that I admired them more than I applied them. There's a tremendous difference. Admiration feels productive. Application actually is.

If one chapter challenges you to make one difficult phone call, make it. If one page reminds you to apologize, do it. If one question exposes an excuse you've been protecting, tell yourself the truth. Don't wait until you've finished the book. Begin today. The life you're hoping to build doesn't start after the last chapter. It starts after the next honest decision.

One thing I've noticed about excuses is that they're incredibly creative. If we're not careful, we'll even use personal growth as another excuse. "I'll start after I finish this book." "I'll begin after I read one more chapter." "I'll make changes once I know a little more." I smiled writing those words because I've said every one of them. Knowledge without action quietly becomes another hiding place. Don't let that happen. The goal isn't finishing another book. The goal is becoming another person.

Every chapter should leave you asking one simple question: What's one thing I can do today? Not ten. One. One conversation. One habit. One apology. One prayer. One promise. One act of courage. One decision. Then tomorrow, ask the same question again.

I've discovered something beautiful about everyday faithfulness. It removes the pressure of trying to change your entire life at once. God has never asked me to faithfully live next year. He's asked me to faithfully live today. That's enough. More than enough. Because enough faithful todays eventually become an entirely different life.

If there's one thing I hope you remember long after you've finished reading this book, it's this: Don't underestimate ordinary decisions. They may not feel significant while you're making them. Years later, you'll discover they quietly changed everything. That's exactly what happened to me.

I kept today's promise. Then tomorrow's. Then the next. Eventually, the life I once hoped for slowly became the life I was living. Not because I was extraordinary. Because ordinary faithfulness still works. It always has. It always will.

Now let's take everything we've talked about and begin putting it into practice.

CHAPTER 16 ## CLOSE THE BOOK. OPEN YOUR LIFE.

A Final Word

If you've read this far, thank you. Not because you finished my story, but because I hope you've started thinking differently about your own.

When I first sat down to write this book, I thought I was writing about running. Then I thought I was writing about excuses. Eventually it became clear to me that I was writing about becoming. Running was just the avenue. Excuses became the obstacle. Becoming became the destination.

If you remember nothing else from these pages, I hope you remember this. You are not your worst decision. You are not your greatest failure. You are not the lies someone else spoke over your life. You are not the mistakes you've made. You are not too late, and you are not too far gone.

I know those statements are true because I spent a long stretch of my life believing exactly the opposite. I believed the restaurant defined me. It didn't. I believed alcohol defined me. It didn't. I believed depression defined me. It didn't. I believed childhood trauma defined me. It didn't. Those became chapters — important chapters, painful chapters, necessary chapters. But they were never the ending. The ending was still being written.

So is yours.

That's one of the reasons I love books. No one judges a story by the middle. Only by the ending. Life deserves the same grace. Don't decide your future based on a chapter you're still living. Keep writing. Keep becoming. Keep moving.

One ordinary day at a time.

When I look back over my own life, I no longer see disconnected events. I see preparation. A grandmother teaching patience through a rose garden. A father teaching consistency through routine work. Abuse that taught me what lies sound like. A restaurant that exposed where my identity had been misplaced. A rocking chair that finally broke my pride. A hotel room that gave me hope. A pair of running shoes that taught me integrity. An ultramarathon that reminded me

ordinary disciplines prepare us for extraordinary moments. Every chapter carried something into the next one. None of it was wasted — and it wasn't because every chapter was good. It's because God is.

That has become one of the greatest sources of peace in my life. He doesn't waste pain. He redeems it. Sometimes immediately, sometimes years later, and sometimes through another person whose life is changed because you were willing to tell the truth about yours. That's why I finally stopped asking, "Why did this happen?" I became much more interested in asking, "How can God use it?" That question continues changing my life. Maybe it'll begin changing yours too.

As you close this book, I want to ask you for one favor. Don't admire it. Use it. I've read too many books that made me feel inspired for a weekend. Then Monday came. Life got busy, the excitement faded, and nothing actually changed. I don't want that to happen here. If all this book gives you is another collection of highlighted quotes, I've failed. If it helps you become more present with your family, we've succeeded. If it gives you the courage to finally tell yourself the truth, we've succeeded. And if it encourages you to put down the bottle, make the phone call, start the walk, repair the relationship, forgive someone, or forgive yourself — then every page was worth writing.

I don't know what excuse you've been carrying. Maybe it's fear. Maybe it's shame. Maybe it's comfort. Maybe it's believing you're too old, or too young, or too broken, or too far behind. I've believed many of those same lies. They're still lies. The beautiful thing about truth is that it doesn't ask where you've been. It only asks one thing: What are you going to do next?

That's all any of us really have. The next decision. The next conversation. The next opportunity to become. You don't have to become the best version of yourself this afternoon. You just have to become a slightly better version than you were yesterday, then repeat it tomorrow. One ordinary day. One small promise. One quiet decision. That's how excuses lose their power. That's how integrity grows. That's how families change, and that's how generations change. One person decides to become. Then another. Then another.

If my story has taught me anything, it's this: God can do extraordinary things with ordinary people who are willing to keep showing up. I believe that with all my heart, because I've lived it.

I'm not writing these words as someone who has arrived. I'm writing them as someone who's still asking the same question every morning: Who do I have to become today? The answer changes. The question never does. I hope it becomes part of your life the way it has become part of mine — not because I asked you to, but because one morning you'll notice it quietly changing the way you think. The way you speak. The way you love. The way you lead. The way you live.

And one day, without even knowing exactly when it happened, you'll discover something remarkable. The person you spent years hoping to become has quietly become the person looking back at you in the mirror. Not perfect. Not finished. Still growing, still learning, still becoming. That's all any of us are really called to do. Keep becoming. Keep telling the truth. Keep your promises. Keep your light on. Someone you haven't even met yet may someday need the courage your story gives them. Don't hide it. Share it. Then trust God with the ripple. The rest has never really been up to us. It has been our privilege to faithfully show up. Again. And again. And again.

Close the book. Open your life.

That's really what I've been hoping you'd do from the very beginning. It isn't that I want you to remember my story. I want you to begin writing yours. If all this book ever becomes is something you finished reading, it won't accomplish what I prayed it would. But if one ordinary decision from these pages changes the direction of your life, then every difficult chapter I lived was worth it.

I don't know where you're beginning. Maybe you're standing in front of a mirror avoiding your own reflection. Maybe you're carrying wounds from childhood that still whisper lies into your life today. Maybe you're exhausted. Maybe you're successful by everyone else's standards while quietly falling apart on the inside. Maybe you're doing well and just wondering what's next. Wherever you are, start there. Don't wait until you have more confidence. Don't wait until life settles down. Don't wait until Monday. Don't wait until next year. Begin where your feet are. Tell yourself the truth. Keep today's promise. Then wake up tomorrow and keep another one.

You don't have to outrun your past. You don't have to erase it. You only have to stop allowing it to decide who you're becoming. The chapter behind you may explain you. It never has to define you.

As I finish writing these final pages, I find myself thinking about that little boy riding beside his dad in an old pickup. The teenager carrying pain onto a football field. The young husband chasing success in a restaurant. The father sitting in a rocking chair believing lies. The man lying awake in a hotel room wondering if life could ever be different. If I could sit across from every one of those versions of myself today, I wouldn't give them a lecture. I wouldn't hand them a plan. I'd lean across the table and say, "Keep going. This chapter isn't the end. God isn't finished with you yet."

That's what I hope these pages become for you. A reminder. Not that life will become easy, but that your future doesn't have to look like your past. The road ahead won't always be smooth. You'll still make mistakes. You'll still have difficult days. You'll still need to make course corrections. So will I. Because becoming never ends.

That's actually good news. It means tomorrow is another opportunity. Another chance to tell yourself the truth. Another chance to keep your word. Another chance to become.

Thank you for trusting me with a small part of your journey. I hope our paths cross someday. If they do, I probably won't ask how many books you've read, or how many races you've finished, or how successful you've become. I'll probably ask one question.

Who are you becoming?

I hope you'll smile before you answer, because you'll know that question has no finish line. Neither does this road.

Now, go live your story. And when you have the opportunity, help someone else believe they can live theirs too.

If you've made it to this page, thank you. Thank you for trusting me with part of your journey. Writing this book has forced me to revisit some of the most painful chapters of my life. It also reminded me of something I'll never forget. Healing doesn't come from pretending the past never happened. Healing comes from telling the truth about it — and choosing not to let it write the rest of your story.

I don't know what chapter you're living today. Maybe you're standing at a starting line. Maybe you're carrying more weight than anyone around you realizes. Maybe you're rebuilding. Maybe you're thriving. Maybe you're just trying to make it through another day. Wherever you are, I hope you remember this. You are not behind because your story has been difficult. You are not disqualified because you've made mistakes. You are not finished because you've failed. As long as you're still breathing, there is still another decision to make. Another promise to keep. Another opportunity to become.

My prayer is that years from now, you won't remember every story in this book. I hope you'll remember the question. The question that quietly changed my life.

Who do I have to become today?

Ask it when life is good. Ask it when life falls apart. Ask it when you're celebrating. Ask it when you're discouraged. Keep asking it, because the answer will continue changing as you grow. That's the beauty of becoming. It never ends.

If our paths never cross, I hope you'll know this: I'm cheering for you. Not because I know your story, but because I know what it's like to believe another chapter isn't possible.

It is.

Keep telling yourself the truth. Keep your word. Keep showing up. Keep your light on. And whenever you have the opportunity, help someone else believe that another chapter is still waiting to be written.

I'll see you somewhere down the road.